You Only Have Four Problems:
The cure for Anger, Anxiety, Depression & Guilt

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First printing, 2021.

Portions of this manual are works of nonfiction. Certain names and identifying characteristics have been changed.

Excerpts from *The Guide to Rational Living* by Dr. Albert E. Ellis and *The 10 Ox-herding Pictures Workbook* by Kathleen Bishop, M.S., Ph.D. have been used with the authors' express written permission.

Producer: Neil Schauer
Project Development: Statler Gause
Copyeditors: Melissa Gridley, Statler Gause
Cover Design: Twenty3 Media, Austin, TX
Interior Design: Gridley Creative, Tampa, FL

Definition

Cure
/kyoor/

verb

1. relieve a person of the symptoms of a disease or condition

A cure is a substance or procedure that ends a medical condition, such as a medication, a surgical operation, a change in lifestyle or even a philosophical mindset that helps ends a person's suffering; the state of being healed.

You Only Have Four Problems:

The cure for Anger, Anxiety,
Depression & Guilt

by Vincent E. Parr, Ph.D.

DEDICATION

To the three women in my life:

Luney, my partner through life, and
Nicolette & Jennifer, daughters who epitomize joy.

Thanks to you I understood what true beauty and love were. I am very enriched and grateful for your love. Thank you for being exactly who you are. May you be peaceful, happy, and content.

EPIGRAPH

"The flower is not concerned about tomorrow.
It doesn't plan.
It doesn't worry about death;
Nor does it make effort to smell beautifully.
The flower teaches being—Being what one is."

WU HSIN

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PREFACE

"The unexamined life is not worth living."
SOCRATES

"Knowledge is learning something every day.
Wisdom is letting go of something every day."
ZEN PROVERB

In my early years I studied with the world-famous clinical psychologist Dr. Albert Ellis, Ph.D., the creator of Rational Therapy (RT). He later changed RT to Rational Emotive Therapy (RET) and then Rational Emotive Behavior Therapy (REBT), which is how we refer to it today. Albert Ellis is the grandfather of all the Rational therapies and the Cognitive Behavior Therapies (CBT) in use today.

Dr. Ellis taught me how powerful individual words in our thinking can truly be. He taught me that the way an emotion is created can be broken down into a simple formula, and that there are three types of consequences: emotional, behavioral and physiological. It's the beliefs we hold and tell ourselves over and over—about ourselves, about others, and about the things that happen in the outside world—that determine how we feel.

I have spent more than 50 years helping patients and I have seen first-hand how powerful beliefs are. I've observed 1) how consistently predictable they are, and 2) how we create these

emotions in our minds by the way we think. All emotional and psychological suffering is conceived by four specific thinking habits or thought loops we get trapped in, repeating them over and over in our minds until we are nearly drowning in Anger, Anxiety, Depression and/or Guilt.

My second greatest mentor and teacher has been Steve Hagen, a Zen Priest in Minneapolis, Minnesota. He showed me how to put the icing on the top of the cake or, in this case, the experience at the pinnacle of Rational Theory. He pointed the way to a mind that doesn't struggle and made all of Rational Theory come to life. I cannot thank him enough. His teaching is what the world is most missing and what I believe is most lacking in psychology and mental health today! Lucky for us he is still alive and teaching—so get out there and see him!

This book is a summary of the teachings of these last two mentors, Ellis and Hagen. They will help you see clearly what reality truly is and what you can do to prioritize long-term meaning and contentment in life over short-term satisfaction.

You see, everyone thinks they have thousands of different problems. But what I saw clearly over time was that everyone was coming in with only four—four emotional blocks to their personal joy and happiness. People described thousands of different examples of Anger, thousands of examples of Anxiety, and many thousands more of Depression and Guilt.

I capitalize these four words throughout this book because they are more than just negative emotions—they are the four most critical blocks to happiness and contentment in life. Rarely do we have just one or two of these stumbling blocks; everyone has, at some point, encountered all four of these emotional ob-

stacles to our contentment in life. In addition, we all have what I call our personal 'racket,' which is defined as our favorite bad feeling. It is not your favorite because you love it so much, but when you upset yourself, it is the one you choose most often. If you enjoy angrily criticizing the drivers on the road around you, Anger is probably your racket!

There is an endless assortment of things that can add to our happiness and joy. However, we all get unhappy—and stay unhappy—in exactly same way. This fact of the human condition shows how, despite how we may often feel, we are never alone! We have always been and always will be interdependent and interconnected across all varieties of the human family.

These are just a few of the things your therapist doesn't tell you, unless you have a Rational therapist or, even better, a Mindfulness (or Zen) based Rational therapist. Then you have a higher probability of getting effective, efficient, and eloquent treatment. This has been supported by nearly 70 years of research, 75 books, and over 6,000 articles on Rational Emotive Behavior Theory by Dr. Ellis alone. A simple Internet search for REBT or CBT will yield even more results supporting the effectiveness of Rational theory and mindfulness in improving mental health.

The main purpose of this book is to spell out in very simple and straight forward terms how we continue to upset ourselves and how we can effectively and practically eliminate the occurrence of these events. The wordiness has been stripped to a bare minimum to keep the message as direct and accessible as possible. I want to get directly to the heart of disturbance, to address the source of and solution to emotional suffering. Consider this a practical guide to managing these thinking habits rather than

a *magnum opus* covering everything there is to know about Rational Theory.

Learning to manage your thoughts, emotions, and beliefs is a gradual process. There is nothing hidden or subconscious or magical about it. The solution is right in front of us and always has been. No matter your age, religion, culture, or creed, these teachings can be effectively applied to any situation at any time by any person. Many have reported noticeable progress within hours of study and application!

Learning how you create unhappiness is more than half the battle to having a mind of peace and joy. I will walk you through the process with thorough explanations, formulas, tools, and examples you can apply to your everyday life. The cause of and solution to the pain caused by Anger, Anxiety, Depression and Guilt is quite literally in your hands. If you read, practice, and apply these techniques, you will learn to master your emotions and create a mind of peace, contentment, and joy.

As Lao-Tzu so beautifully said: “When you realize there is nothing extra and nothing lacking, the whole world belongs to you.”

Let’s begin.

INTRODUCTION

"If knowledge does not liberate the self from the self,
then ignorance is better than such knowledge."
SANA'I

"No inside, no outside, no in-between."
HSIN HSIN MING (*TRUSTING THE HEARTMIND*) BY SENGTS'AN

We spend a large part of our lives arguing with reality; obsessing on past events, sighing over regrets, grumbling about unmet expectations, and railing against circumstances we perceive to be disagreeable. Yet most of us would agree, if we thought about it, that *arguing with reality is a total waste of our precious time!* No matter how hard we try, truth and reality are immovable things—absolutes—that can't be different. Our opinions, ideas, and beliefs can't alter the inalterable or move the immovable. Yet we waste countless hours of our finite lives debating whether things are fair, whose fault it is that they are the way they are, and why it should be this way and not that way! We create and carry with us the perpetual notion that we have piles upon piles of problems, large and small, trivial and critical, temporary and permanent.

The truth is that you only have four problems at the root of all your suffering; four devastating emotions you create from your fixed false beliefs, opinions, and ideas about reality and truth. Every painful, stressful, frustrating, or terrifying moment in our

lives is caused by how we deal with Anger, how we deal with Anxiety, how we deal with Depression, and how we deal with Guilt. These emotions rob us of our life and block our joy.

The purpose of this book is to help you stop suffering. Not just today and tomorrow but for the rest of your life. It is a guide to not only relieving the emotional disturbances caused by these four blocks, but about how to replace them with what the Buddhists refer to as The Four Immeasurables: 1) lovingkindness—active goodwill towards all, 2) compassion toward others and the self, 3) sympathetic & empathetic joy, and 4) equanimity, or even-mindedness and serenity. These 'sublime attitudes,' as they are sometimes referred to in Western traditions, are too powerful to be measured. For you materialists out there (and who of us are not, raised in this society?), this means that billions of dollars cannot match, in a lifetime of experiences, these Four Immeasurables!

It sounds like a simple enough concept, doesn't it? Well, it's not new, this idea of alleviating emotional pain by replacing negative thoughts with positive ones. It is, however, often oversimplified to the point of being thoroughly ineffective in a practical sense. The actual process of letting go, of routing out these long-held ideas and beliefs is much more complex. The ideas presented here go back to the ancient Greek and Roman stoics and skeptics as well as Indian, Chinese, Japanese, Confucius, Taoist and Buddhist cultures and philosophy. But don't be discouraged—anyone can learn how! Wisdom endures through the ages.

Unfortunately, so does ignorance and disturbance. Ignorance does not mean stupid or low I.Q.—some of the most stupid-acting people I have ever met have advanced degrees and seem

very smart. As George Carlin said when listening to a guest speaker, "Well, they have a great education, they went to all the great schools, they seem very smart. Aha, they are full of shit!" Ignorance is simply a lack of knowledge, learning, or information. My goal is to help alleviate this ignorance by challenging the ideas and beliefs you hold. As you will see, it is clinging to our opinions, ideas, and beliefs, that cause not only our own suffering but contribute to the suffering of others.

I will not be giving you opinions or a new belief system to grasp onto or define yourself by. What I offer you here is truth, the opposite of opinions, ideas, and beliefs. Truth can be seen directly—our belief is an illusion! However, it can't be dismissed as 'just' an illusion, because it is a *real* illusion in the sense that it can cause suffering. When we believe the illusion or that our opinion and ideas are right and true, this is delusion. Good luck trying to be happy there.

Delusion dooms us to disagree and fight over petty concerns, and to argue over whose beliefs are right—as if we will ever come to a rational compassionate solution under these circumstances. Throughout the course of human history, most of human suffering has been the result of beliefs. This is the world of conflict. Not just between ourselves and our loved ones but with and between nations. All wars, killing, fighting, bigotry, prejudice, hate and loathing are the posturing of the righteousness of our precious belief over someone else's. Enlightenment is the only way to see through delusion, and truth is the path to enlightenment. Truth is what you will find here and in my online course.

Also, and I think even more importantly, we can begin teaching these to our children as soon as they enter elementary

school and even before, if the parents have been trained. We can prepare them for a rational, peaceful, purposeful life. An observation by Socrates inscribed over the door of the library of Alexandra says, *"The unexamined life is not worth living."* Teaching your children this is the most important thing you can give them. You are giving them the keys to the good life.

In addition to this book, I have also created an online program, The 4 Blocks to Happiness Mastery Course at theparrinstitute.org. The course is not absolutely necessary for understanding the concepts in this book, but the videos, podcasts, and exercises in it can be extremely helpful in learning and remembering what you read here.

The goal of this book and *The 4 Blocks to Happiness Mastery Course* found on my website at parrinstitute.org is three-pronged:

1: The almost complete elimination of human disturbance
2: Personal happiness and contentment
3: Enlightenment

Yes, this is a tall order, and you may be skeptical. It is good to be skeptical! I am one of the biggest skeptics there is; I belong to two national skeptic organizations and I sit on the board as vice-president of one, The Institute for Science and Human Values.

So please by all means, be skeptical, doubt, and look for ways to solve our human issues and eliminate suffering. What else are we going to do with our precious time here—watch *Dancing with the Stars* and eat Cheetos?!

CHAPTER 1

MENTAL CONTAMINATION

"This is one of many things your therapist doesn't tell you and they don't teach you in school—which is most important for your social life, and your emotional well-being."
VINCE PARR

Nothing and no one has ever upset you.

Think about that for a second. A very common, restricting, and self-defeating idea is that we get upset because bad things happen—that happiness or unhappiness is externally caused and that we cannot do anything about it. This is not true. Happiness and unhappiness are internally caused, and we can freely choose either one. Your joy and happiness are not dictated by your experiences in life, but by your relationship to those experiences. What you'll learn in this book is that *events* don't make you upset—our stress, emotional disturbance and negative feelings are all caused by our own internal mental contamination!

The Negative Feedback Superhighway

There are three reasons why you are the way you are right now. Number one is genetic predisposition. We are predisposed to think, feel, and react in certain ways. Millions of years of natural selection led to your parents creating you, and with that you became predisposed to all sorts of tendencies like Anxiety, Depression and so on.

Number two is environmental conditioning. This is the sum of the beliefs you were taught, the books you read, the religion, culture, social influences you were exposed to. This category has dramatic impact on why you are the way you are, and it cannot be changed because it is your past. You *can* change the environmental conditions in your present life situation, and that may be a good idea, but to be able to do that you must recognize the third and most important reason why you are the way you are right now.

Number three is self-conditioning; that is, the way you talk to yourself, the story in your head. The Buddhists call it the monkey mind. I call it The Narrator or sometimes the 95 Maniacs in your head! No matter what you call it, it represents the 60,000+ sentences that we say in our mind every day. This running monologue we generate is why we are tired at the end of the day. The way we describe ourselves to ourselves, the stories we construct, inform our opinions of ourselves and the world around us.

Some say that the mind is the neglected organ. In our society, we go to the dentist to have perfect teeth, we go to the gym to have a perfect body, but very few people take the time to develop a strong, clear mind. Mankind has landed on the moon, invented self-driving cars (well, almost), and developed computers small enough to fit in the palm of our hand, yet many of us do not have the tools to cultivate an undisturbed mind. This is our purpose here. To train you to refine your mind on a daily basis. A refined mind is a mind of clarity, a mind of happiness.

Mental contamination is when we mistake our opinions, ideas, and beliefs for facts and truth. It's another way of describing egocentric thinking, assigning godlike accuracy to our thoughts.

Mental contamination distances us from reality, and without a realistic view of ourselves and our lives we become less capable of making positive change. We alienate others with our stubborn opinions and open ourselves up to clinging to false, outdated, or otherwise damaging beliefs. I am not implying that it is impossible for a belief to be true, but—and this is one of the most important things I will say to you—it is the Beliefs we hold that go *unchallenged* that have the potential for causing us the most harm! Dōgen, a twelfth century Zen monk said: "Never believe what you think!" Yes! This is delusion.

If you were to add up all the words you tell yourself every day, you would probably average between 60,000 and 74,000 sentences you say every day inside your head. The vast amount of these sentences come directly from cognitive habits—thought patterns we're so used to we don't even question whether they're true or not. These patterns can play out in a negative feedback loop, a never-ending cycle of distressing thoughts, feelings, behaviors, and physiological effects. Our self-created conceptions inspire painful emotions that lead to undesirable actions. We then create more conceptions about our negative actions and those actions get our adrenaline pumping. Now we're thinking more negative thoughts and the loop begins again. The effects of your inner dialogue on your emotions and behavior are almost immeasurable! If you do not learn how to observe this constant dialogue, you can't change it or the habits it creates. It's like driving in circles on a highway—you're dizzy and running out of gas with no relief in sight!

There are two essential keys to getting out of this negative feedback loop and removing mental contamination. The first is training the Observer and the other is disputing the irratio-

nal beliefs we hold. Of course, the fastest and most effective way off the negative feedback superhighway—and onto the path to inner peace and happiness—is to combine both of these techniques.

Let's look first at how to identify and train the Observer.

The Narrator vs. The Observer

Understanding and training the mind to be aware is the foundation of meditative practice and most all Eastern/Buddhist philosophical traditions. If I ask you to observe what you are thinking about, *who* or *what* is doing the observing? Your first instinct might be to respond, "Well, it's me of course!" But how are you the person observing you at the same time as you are the person being observed? It blows your mind if you stop to think about it, doesn't it?

Thinking is a fact. It happens. It is what the mind does. The illusion is that there is a 'me' doing the thinking. This has never been proven! No one has ever successfully documented the ghost in the machine—the 'me' in the mind. *The real Wizard of Oz!*

Our five senses are simply gatherers of facts, creating a direct route from external data to our cognitive center in the brain. Eyes see, ears hear, noses smell, tongues taste and nerve endings in skin feel. But these senses can't interpret the data for us; only our brains can do that. The eyeball doesn't tell us that the collection of light waves bouncing off an object into our retinas is a picture of a cow. Our brain must know that 'cow' is a thing, recognize its likeness, and give it context. It can fill in smells we can't smell (manure), textures we can't feel (hairy), and sounds

we can't hear (mooing). It may even feed us a bit of fear or disgust or nostalgia depending on our opinions and past experiences with cows.

Now Eastern philosophy has, for thousands of years, included a sixth sense—thinking. This sixth sense has nothing to do with the 'woo-woo' ESP stuff you see on sensationalist talk shows or late-night TV. The sixth sense is simply the observable, physical activity of the brain—electricity firing neurons and tracing synapses. Through the miracle of electronic imaging we can actually observe this involuntary reaction to incoming data. It's no more profound than the reaction of your salivary glands to incoming food, yet we cling to an entire belief system we build around this physical response! It makes no more sense than turning to your salivary glands for answers and truth. I don't know one person who wouldn't respond to that idea with an emphatic "WTF?!"

Observation and interpretation are accompanied by a constant running dialogue provided by the two parts that make up your thinking mind. The Narrator runs the inner dialogue, and the Observer can observe and change the inner dialogue.

The Narrator is the part of the mind that makes up the 'ego.' It is what we think of and identify as our 'self,' the author of all we think, feel, and believe. It takes the input you receive through your senses—by itself only impartial bits of abstract information—and assigns meaning based on our beliefs, feelings, and conceptions. It tells us stories that make up our mental formations of who we are and how we relate to the world around us. These stories may be in line with provable facts, but because they're happening in our head where no one else can check, they may not be. The danger of conception is that it

need not have any relationship with fact at all. It can devolve into self-delusion without warning and often without any conscious thought.

Imagine you can smell steak grilling. The scent of steak in the air is a fact anyone in the vicinity can confirm. Now, you like steak and think it is delicious. That's not a fact, it's an opinion. Some people don't like steak. But because to you steak means good food and good food is desirable, your Narrator tells you that smell is good and that it represents something delicious, juicy, and satisfying. This, however, is a story that exists only in your head no matter how much you believe it to be true.

Because it equates beliefs with self, the Narrator is very protective of its beliefs and will not hesitate to employ greed, anger, or delusion to keep them intact. It clings to its own interpretation of sensory information as if it were an undeniable fact and becomes irrationally reactive when those beliefs are violated or threatened. It may explain why if you meet a vegan who perceives that same smell of steak as representing something cruel, inhumane, and undesirable, your Narrator tells you their perception is wrong, and maybe even that they are a bad and worthless person. It's easy to see how our conceptions can create emotional distress. Understanding that The Narrator exists only in your head is the key to the first insight. This is where we have the option to choose our path. We can choose to create positive change or continue drowning in our emotional conceptions of unchangeable reality.

One of the foundations of Zen and Buddhist teaching is that clinging is the source of all suffering. Learning to let go of the Narrator—and of the narration itself–is the main purpose of

meditation. It is a critical component to clearing mental contamination and overcoming the four blocks to happiness.

The Observer, unlike the Narrator, simply observes events, situations, and facts without forming an opinion or conception. It is the part of the mind that watches, asks questions about and can even choose what it's doing. You can train your Observer to notice impermanence (i.e., constant change) at all the five senses, as well as your inner dialogue. This is where you train it to red-flag irrational thoughts, feelings, and beliefs. This is popularly called mindfulness in Buddhist and Eastern Principles, while in the west we call it consciousness, attention, and awareness.

How do we shift to the Observer? In order to become or cultivate the Observer, you must shift from being your thoughts to noticing your thoughts—that is, being consciously aware of—your thoughts. You act as a spectator without getting wrapped up in or attached to the thought process. It's as if you are watching a movie. When you are absorbed in the action you are taken right along with the story. However, at any point in the film you can stop and say, "This is just a movie," and just like that you become aware of the movie and distance yourself from the action on the screen. In that same way you become aware of your mental images when you stop yourself and say, "This thought is just a thought. It is not a fact and I can let it go." A thought is just a thought. It has no power except the power you give it!

It's one thing to understand what the Observer is, it's another thing to practice it. One way to train yourself is to imagine you are two people; one of you is watching, one of you is doing. Place your mind's eye outside of your body and watch yourself from far away. This will begin to give you a level of detachment from being caught up in the emotions of the moment.

Another important part of the shift to observing is connecting deeply to your breath in every moment. You will never be able to shut off your thoughts completely, but you can reduce the volume and effect of mental chatter by being as aware as possible of your breath, and knowing that a thought is just a thought—you don't have to believe it or cling to it rigidly.

Building new cognitive habits will not happen overnight. Be patient with yourself in this process of creating a more rationally thinking mind, and trust that your physical brain will begin to heal as well.

Thinking Mind vs. Reactive Mind

Another way to look at being an Observer is to compare a mind that is consciously aware (a thinking mind) to a reactive one. The thinking mind is the problem solver; the reactive mind is the unthinking, emotional reflex, often of a disturbed mind. When we do not take responsibility for our thoughts, feelings and behavior we have a reactive mind instead of an aware mind, and to be reactive is to give up our freedom. The thinking mind is a mind of stillness and a mind that doesn't struggle with the passing show. The show is always passing and we can chose to react to it and be more disturbed or to observe the passing show and know that this will soon pass and thus leading to a mind at peace. As the ancient Greek and Roman Stoics have told us: *"Contentment is our greatest wealth."*

Most people function in a reactive state all the time—they only use the reactive part of their mind. We train our minds to be reactive from a young age. An event happens, and we react to it. A similar event happens, and we react the same way. This cycle repeats itself until we become caught in a never-ending rut of

mindless reaction. This mindless reaction is at the root of all Anger, Anxiety, Depression, and Guilt.

In the following chapters I'll discuss how to function with the thinking part of your mind rather than the reactive part. I want you to get to the point where you are conscious of your thoughts, eventually choosing rational thoughts intentionally. This is a much more effective lifestyle than being reactive, and a victim to knee-jerk irrational, egocentric beliefs.

When you train the Observer, you are un-training the reactive mind and choosing something other than reflexive action. You are training yourself to observe and watch the passing show instead of getting wrapped up in acting and reacting. This does not make you a passive or weak person. Rather, when you are an Observer, you are aware of and can choose to take action when you decide it's appropriate rather than simply unconsciously reacting. When you take action, you solve the practical problem without the unnecessary and often harmful emotion. In other words, you take control of your life.

For example, an untrained fighter, when punched, reacts by hitting back. He doesn't strike with accuracy and he is quickly forced into submission. In contrast, a black belt in karate, someone who has trained their body and mind to consciously take effective action, would choose their response carefully. They would observe the action and judge the best way to gain the advantage. This is the difference between responding and reacting.

Although they would move quickly, in terms of reflexes, they would have consciously chosen to place their kick or punch in the most effective place for the best and most effect de-

fense. This is non-emotional and non-reactive; it is responsive. Similarly, when you train your mind to think rationally, every time you are confronted with a situation that you would previously have been angry or frustrated or depressed about, you will act with your conscious mind and choose not to be angry but rather to handle the situation in the most effective manner.

When you get a flat tire, you fight with your wife, or the kids are driving you crazy, you can choose not to react to those things. You use the conscious part of your mind, trained with the tools we are about to discuss, and make the conscious choice to avoid feeling disturbed and unhappy.

> *"The instantaneous mind is 'It!' What is the need to seek somewhere else? The Great Way is right there before your eyes. There is nothing hidden, nothing left out, nothing extra. There is no miracle, no manic, no mystery."*
>
> VINCE PARR

CHAPTER 2

THE THREE INSIGHTS TO A MIND OF PEACE

"The mind is the root from which all things grow.
If you can understand the mind, everything else is included."
BODHIDHARMA

"He who is not contented with what he has, would not be
contented with what he would like to have."
SOCRATES

"Happiness or Unhappiness don't come from
outside your body."
VINCE PARR

After I studied REBT and CBT with Dr. Albert Ellis, I went on to see patients for 50+ years, and what I discovered was that no matter what the thousands of presenting problems were, people mainly feel four negative emotions: Anger, Anxiety, Depression, and Guilt. Our perceptions and behaviors vary widely, but the negative emotions connecting the two are common to us all. And even though many different things influence people's happiness, we all create our unhappiness in exactly the same way.

I call these the four blocks to happiness and inner peace because they are the four things that can stop you from feeling good. These are the main causes of your suffering! All emotional upset—what we often refer to as stress or 'disturbance'—is created by these four emotional blocks which can be broken down into four formulas and seven irrational beliefs. Learning

how to get past these blocks to our happiness is a critical step, and once you've mastered this I will show you the science of happiness and well-being as well. This probably sounds like a crazy idea—if everyone wants happiness and it's as simple as a choice, then why don't we choose it? Simply put, it is because we are unaware of how we upset ourselves. Or even that we do!

There are three basic insights into the human condition that help us become more aware of how we upset ourselves. These insights are the fundamental building blocks to a rational mind. Without these insights, it's practically impossible for you to be happy or content in your lifetime.

The First Insight

You create and maintain 100% of your thoughts, feelings, and behavior.

The first insight may seem startlingly simple, but it is a profound statement: this means nothing and no one else can cause your thoughts and feelings. Someone can hurt you physically, but they can't hurt you emotionally because it's not the outside world that causes your emotions. Your beliefs about these events cause your emotions, and no one can make you think a thought. Understanding that you are 100% responsible for 100% of your thoughts, emotions, and behaviors is the first step to freedom.

Most people have only one strategy for happiness—trying to control the conditions of the outside world, whether it's with money, romantic relationships, a drug addiction, politics or religion. This does not work because the only thing we have control over is our thoughts, feelings, and behavior. The outside and inside world is in constant state of flux, flow, and change.

In fact, change is the only constant. We cannot control the outside conditions that are always changing, just as we cannot control other people or situations. The only thing we have a great deal of control over, or as I prefer, 'mastery' over is our internal world.

If you don't take responsibility for controlling your own thoughts, emotions, and behavior, not only do you block out happiness, but you will always look for someone or something to blame; others, your bad luck, or yourself for your problems and feelings. Blaming is disturbance! And it is the executioner of love! No love survives blaming! You may stay in your relationship, but all the love dies primarily because of blaming. You cannot change for the better while continuing to blame everything and everyone else for how you feel right now. One of my favorite mottos is *"No pissing, moaning, bitching, whining, or complaining!"* Believe me, you will feel better and people will love you more!

The Second Insight

It is essential to become aware of how you create your emotions.

The second insight is what the next chapter is all about, the ABCs of emotional disturbance, as created by my mentor Dr. Albert Ellis in the early 1950s. These ABCs are as fundamental as the ABCs you were taught in school, but these will have an even greater impact on you because they determine whether you live a life of peace or of struggle.

Much as the ABCs you learned as a kid help you identify words and sentences; the ABCs of emotions will help you identify irrational beliefs and the stories your Narrator is telling you. You

will begin to understand how those stories, conceptions, and beliefs affect your state of mind and how to red-flag them by listening for key words and phrases.

It's essential that you recognize irrational beliefs before you can begin to dispute them. You can understand how and why you create your emotions and feelings as simply as ABC and knowing the equations for Anger, Anxiety, Depression, and Guilt. That's where the third insight comes into play.

The Third Insight

It is essential to learn how to dispute and let go of your negative emotions rapidly.

The third insight is the key to removing the four blocks. The four formulas I present for identifying and disputing Anger, Anxiety, Depression and Guilt will help you learn to challenge the stories your Narrator tells you and rely instead on accepting the information you receive from your Observer.

The formulas for the four blocks will show you how to receive information from your Observer without conceptions and beliefs that lead to emotional disturbance. You will learn tools and techniques that help you turn Anger, Anxiety, Depression and Guilt into peace, acceptance, and contentment. In this way, you can have a life of meaning and minimal struggle even through the tough times. Let's start at the beginning—with our ABCs.

CHAPTER 3

THE ABCs OF HOW EMOTIONS ARE CREATED

"We cannot choose our external circumstances,
but we can always choose how we respond to them."
EPICTETUS

"You are the way you think."
VINCE PARR

Just like you learned your ABCs in kindergarten as the building blocks for reading and writing, these are the building blocks for understanding your emotions. Once you are comfortable with your ABCs, you will be able to attack and conquer the most complex emotional problems. Knowing your ABCs, actively red-flagging, and consistently disputing them are the keys to mental health and a successful life.

In this model, 'A' refers to the **A**ctivating event, which is anything that happens to us—a situation, another person's behavior, or even our own thoughts. 'B' refers to our **B**eliefs, the 60,000+ sentences that we say to ourselves every day, day in and day out. There are two kinds of beliefs, and whichever kind we choose leads to the 'C', or **C**onsequence; the emotional, behavioral, and physiological responses to the belief about the activating event. So thus far:

A = Activating Event
B = Belief or Belief System

C = Consequences

In the ABC model, A-to-C thinking refers to how we blame circumstances for our emotions and behaviors. Many of us have fallen into the trap of believing some*thing* or some*one* pissed us off, made us sad, scared us, or made us feel worthless. We react negatively based on an irrational belief we're not even aware of. A-to-C thinking is not rational. It's reactionary and illogical. Circumstances or other people are *never* to blame for our thoughts, feelings, and actions! They simply are as they are because conditions exist for them to be that way. We can, however, train ourselves to recognize A-to-C thinking so we can challenge it. Let's look at an example.

Dave and Jim are watching a political debate on television. A candidate makes a controversial remark. Dave gets upset and complains, "That's so stupid! He's such a liar!" Jim, however, agrees with the candidate and nods, "That's so true! He's a smart guy." Dave argues with Jim and storms off, grumbling to himself, "Jim's really pissing me off! He always sides with that jerk politician." Jim thinks, "Wow, Dave got really angry! It's too bad—I really would like to be able to have a calm discussion about this."

Let's look at Dave first. The Consequence is he is feeling angry (emotional response), his heart rate is up (physiological response), and he argued with and abandoned his friend (behavioral response). He believes the politician's remarks and Jim's response caused the argument and his anger. Those things were, in reality, just the Activating events. In Dave's mind the argument (A) made him respond angrily (C). This is A-to-C thinking. It is incorrect because it wasn't the argument that made Dave mad. Dave was angry because he believes (B) the politi-

cian should tell the truth and Jim should side with him. This is not fact and it's not reality.

Jim, on the other hand, is simply stating what happened and what he'd *prefer* to happen. What happened is provable and observable. Anyone could have witnessed the Activating event and observed the result. And it's true that Jim would prefer to discuss politics calmly with his friend. That is rational because it accepts the reality of the Activating event and does not counter any provable facts. He did not have a negative response (C) because he held only rational beliefs (B) about the Activating event (A).

If the Activating event were the cause of the response, then both men would have responded the same way. But an Activating event is just information gathered by the senses—in this case the sound of words absorbed by Dave's ears. Dave's *interpretation* of the information, the meaning he assigned to the words, caused his response. Dave, like all of us, is responsible for his Beliefs and therefore for the Consequences.

In short, when Dave heard (A) the words that were said, he told himself (B) they should not have been said, and (C) responded angrily. His emotional process, in reality, went from A to B to C. Jim's process also went from A to B to C, so why didn't *he* have a negative emotional response? Jim's response (C) was rational because his Belief was rational! Most of us, without even being aware of it, are more likely to respond like Dave than Jim. But that doesn't mean we have to continue to do so. We can learn to let go of irrational Beliefs, accept Activating events for what they are, and enjoy a life positive Consequences.

Positive Consequences lead to a path of peace, while a negative Consequence will lead you down a path of suffering. The path, or Consequence, is determined by one of two kinds of belief; rational or irrational. A rational belief leads to positive emotions and an irrational belief leads to negative emotions. *There are no negative emotions without irrational beliefs.*

What makes a belief rational vs. irrational? A rational belief is a preference. A belief that, although you might like a different outcome, you accept reality as it is, just as Jim did after his argument with Dave. There is no labeling and it has little or no resistance to reality *as it is*. An irrational belief is a belief that you hold that rejects reality and demands that it be different than how it is. It is also labeling and insisting that reality is wrong and should be different or should not have happened at all. Irrational beliefs are always an indication of egocentric thinking, which we will get into more later.

When these two friends perceived the same activating event (A), Dave had the belief that what was said was wrong and shouldn't have been said. Jim had the belief that what was said made good sense and accepted it on face value. So who is right and who is wrong? It doesn't matter! I don't bring this up to discuss the rightness or wrongness of politics. The point is that no matter what the activating event is, a negative emotion is caused only by rejecting reality, and a positive emotion happens through accepting reality.

Now when I say acceptance, I am not implying endorsement or resignation. I am not saying you must approve of the activating event in order to be happy, but you do have to be able to accept that it is inarguably, unalterably happening right now. One of the major keys to happiness is being able to accept all Activating

events—pleasant, neutral and unpleasant—because they are always happening. In the Tao Te Ching, a book written some 3,000 years ago by Lao Tzu, he says, *"Life is 10,000 joys and 10,000 sorrows."* What happens if you embrace only the 10,000 joys? You will be disturbed at least half of your life—if not more—because in addition to sorrows, there are a lot of neutral things that happen every day that you may not like either.

How do you accept something you don't agree with? The answer is simple and perfectly logical—*it exists, therefore it* has *to exist.* A situation exists exactly the way it does because all the conditions (and there are trillions of them) that are necessary for it to exist have occurred. They have already happened. How can it not exist if all the conditions for its existence have occurred!? It's not possible for it to be different than it is just because you don't like it. Resisting this reality is what causes every negative emotion and is technically psychosis, the denial of reality. The negative emotion is a cognitive dissonance in the mind that is caused by insisting that reality be different than how it is right now simply because *you* want it otherwise! You'll see this concept repeated often throughout this book because it is the most critical component of irrational thinking, and the most difficult for most people to accept. We are born into the center of our own universe; it's shocking to learn reality will continue to be exactly as it is, regardless of how we feel about or react to it. Another saying I love is *"If you accept reality it will continue as it is. If you do not accept reality, it will continue as it is."*

When you see your true self as being interconnected with totality, or all things, then you'll see that duality—compartmentalizing people, objects, and events as separate and distinct—does not exist. You will understand our interconnectedness, that all

existence is you and you are all existence—including the things you like and the things you don't like. It takes a new set of eyes to truly see this reality, but once realized, you will experience the enlightenment that has been expressed by the wisdom teachers throughout history. As the Stoics said some 1,000 years after Lao Tzu, *"Amor fati (Love it all)!"* Why? Because this is your life—in its sorrows, its joys and everything between. It cannot be other than it is, at this moment. It will be a false substitute, a 'wishful thinking' version of the life you are actually living! Good luck loving an imposter.

One of the bottom lines in Rational and Zen philosophy states, *"This moment doesn't have an option."* You can work hard to change the next moment if you choose, but this moment is what it is. This is not only true now but has always been the case. Another says, *"Flowers fall amid our longing; weeds grow despite our loathing."* The spring flowers will come on their own regardless of our personal wishes. We are not in control here!

Now that we understand how we create emotions through the first three letters of the ABC model, the next chapter will teach you how to find all the irrational beliefs that make up the equations of the four blocks. Then we will add the 'D' and 'E.' The 'D' represents Disputing, Dissolving, and Destroying our irrational beliefs, and 'E' is the Effective, Efficient, and Eloquent new rational belief that comes as a result of disputing.

So the entire ABC model for creating emotions is:

A = Activating Event
B = Belief or Belief System
C = Consequences
D = Disputing

E = Equanimity or new Effective Belief

Remember, any time you feel a tinge of Anger, Anxiety, Depression or Guilt always look for what you're telling yourself about the event, for the non-acceptance of reality as it is. In the next chapter you'll find a guide to the irrational beliefs that will help you along the way.

"Suffering is when we resist the moment."
KAMAL RAVIKANT

"To a mind that is still, the entire universe surrenders."
ZHUANGZI

CHAPTER 4

THE SEVEN IRRATIONAL BELIEFS

"Pain in life is not an option. Suffering is."
BUDDHA

"There are 7 irrational beliefs behind all human suffering."
VINCE PARR

"Look past your thoughts, so you may drink the pure nectar of this moment."
RUMI

Crazy & Disturbed Thinking

When we hold onto irrational thoughts, our emotional reaction can escalate until it becomes sickness and disturbance in the body and mind. Anger may produce elevated heart rate and high blood pressure. Anxiety can take the form of sweating, dizziness, and blurred vision. Depression is often accompanied by lethargy, sleeplessness, and weight fluctuations. Feelings of Guilt and shame may lead to disordered eating or profound isolation.

We can avoid or remedy these extreme physiological reactions by recalling the three insights to guide our thinking. First acknowledge that you create and maintain all of your emotions. Stop and observe the sensations in your body. If you feel angry—flushed face, fast pulse—first acknowledge that you created the feeling of Anger and only you can change it.

You are not a prisoner of your feelings; the key to release is in your own mind!

The second insight requires you to understand how you create these beliefs. This insight involves a little investigation on your part. You must ask yourself *why*; "Why do I think, feel or believe this?" Become aware of your thought process, switch from Narrator to Observer, and identify the irrational thinking that's causing you to feel the negative emotion.

There are 7 irrational beliefs that cause all of human suffering and personal misery:

1: 'It' Statements
2: Awfulizing
3: I Can't Stand It!
4: Shoulds, Musts, and Demands (SMDs)
5: Rating
6: Absolutistic Thinking
7: The Idea of Entitlement

What makes a thought, feeling, belief, or behavior irrational? It is irrational when it is unprovable—the opposite of what is provable or real. Events are subject only to the laws of physics and have no inherent meaning except the meaning we give them. If they are occurring, they can't be other than they are. This simple *if/then* statement is the basis of logical, rational thinking:

- *If* the conditions for a situation exist, *then* the situation must exist.
- *If* the conditions have already happened, *then* the situation cannot be different than it is.

- *If* the conditions change, *then* it may be possible for the situation to change.
- *If* the conditions do not change, *then* the situation will not change and must continue to exist.

These statements are rational, provable, and factual, no matter how pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral they may be to us or our loved ones. The events that result from existing conditions are not personal attacks on us, even though they often seem like they are. This is where most of our dissatisfaction and disappointment in life starts—our self-talk, our Narrator's story. If we do not learn to master our emotions, they'll gain momentum and keep looping around that Negative Feedback Superhighway until we're convinced there's no escape.

This progression is the culprit behind all Anger, Anxiety, Depression and Guilt. While the steps are not always perfectly linear, most people will experience the process in the order I present it here. The point of learning these irrational beliefs is to red-flag them every time you hear them, and to double red-flag them if you hear *yourself* think, say, or write them. Red-flagging means to become consciously aware of the irrational belief, the story our Narrator is telling us. Once you have red-flagged your irrational beliefs, you can dispute them with rational thinking. Therefore, it is important you learn to identify all seven before moving on to disputing. These irrational beliefs, with a consistent effort, can be disputed, dissolved and destroyed, leaving peace and contentment in their absence!

Disputing means challenging the irrational beliefs that you hold as a fact in your mind using observation and rational thought rather than conception and emotional belief. Learning to effectively dispute irrational thoughts, feelings, and beliefs will allow

you to stay on the path of lasting happiness, personal contentment, and peace.

Another technique in mastering our irrational thoughts is called cognitive stoppage. Cognitive means thinking, and stoppage means to halt; stopping the thought process in its tracks. When focused on with pure awareness, any sensation, physical tension, or reaction that is caused by beliefs and emotions will begin to dissolve. This is the beginning of mastering that self-conditioning, the beliefs we tell ourselves about life that either leads to a path of peace, or a path of suffering. This is change at the cellular level, not just changing a few words around. If you don't control or master your thoughts, they will control and master you!

In the next chapter, we will go deeper into disputing, but for now let's take a closer look at the phrases listed above that represent the irrational beliefs.

> *"All that we are is the result of what we have thought. Nothing can harm you more than your unguarded thought."*
> BUDDHA

> *"The mad mind does not halt. If it halts, it is enlightenment."*
> ZEN SAYING

> *"What is most truly valuable is often underrated."*
> AESOP

Red-Flagging

The first step to overcoming the 7 irrational beliefs is red-flagging—noticing and mentally marking when we realize we're having these thoughts. When you are constantly tuned in to red-flag phrases you will realize how often people verbalize these damaging and disturbing thoughts. In over half a century of

clinical practice I have approximated that in our daily conversations, we either hear someone else say these things or we say them ourselves every eight seconds! No wonder being happy, and content is such a difficult task—we're talking ourselves out of it 7.5 times a minute!

If you want to get some practice red-flagging, just head over to social media. Twitter is a rich source of irrational thinking from all walks of life! If you aren't sure what to red-flag or if you are deciding whether something is irrational and needs to be red-flagged, walk yourself through The 4 Steps to Disputing:

STEP 1: OBSERVE

Try to observe yourself objectively, as if you were an outsider watching you. Ask yourself:

"How am I feeling and acting in this situation?"

STEP 2: THINK S.O.S.

Review your thoughts about Self, thoughts about Others, and about the Situation. Ask yourself:

"What am I thinking that makes me upset and keeps me acting this way?"

"What am I thinking about myself?"

"What am I thinking about others?"

"What am I thinking about the situation?"

STEP 3: IDENTIFY

Review the 7 irrational beliefs and try to pinpoint where in the process you're getting stuck. It might help to jot down your thoughts and match them to the red-flagged phrases above. Ask yourself:

"Which irrational belief or beliefs am I creating?"

"Are my thoughts rational and provable?"

"Which of my thoughts are irrational or unprovable?"

STEP 4: REPLACE

The final step to disputing, dissolving, and destroying your irrational beliefs is to replace them with rational thoughts. Once you identify which irrational beliefs are causing your disturbance, you can dispute those thoughts, but it will be far more difficult if you don't replace them with something more rational. Sure, you could just tell yourself to stop thinking those thoughts but that's rarely successful. It's like telling yourself not to think about pink elephants. You just pictured a pink elephant, right? Now what if you're told to think about your favorite pair of shoes? No more pink elephants!

Replace your red-flagged thoughts with rational thinking. Ask yourself:

"What realistic preferences can I substitute for my irrational 'Shoulds, Musts and Demands?'"

"Is my situation 100% awful? Can I stand it, even if I don't like it?"

"Does this situation make me or other people bad, horrible, and worthless?"

"Will it truly never end or change?"

This last step is critical. Remember that what makes something irrational is that it is unprovable, so it makes sense to replace an irrational belief with one that is provable.

Disputing the Irrational Beliefs

Disputing means challenging irrational beliefs that you hold as a fact in your mind. When you dispute, you are using your thinking or rational mind rather than falling back on your reactive or irrational mind. You are engaging your inner Observer to observe the facts, identify the story your Narrator is telling you, and dispute the conception that's causing your disturbance. Once you learn how to do this, you'll be able to understand the equations for Anger, Anxiety, Depression, and Guilt and find personal contentment and peace.

For example, let's say a car cuts you off in traffic, and you start feeling angry. First, you recognize that you are beginning to feel Anger. Remind yourself of the first insight and realize that you are creating this Anger. Now look for the A (activating event) and recall the second insight. You can understand how you have created the feeling by examining the story you're telling yourself. What irrational beliefs can you red-flag? You probably say something to yourself along the lines of, "he or 'It' upset me" or, "people should be better drivers (shoulds, rating, entitlement)."

This is when the disputing starts: ask yourself why. Why shouldn't he cut you off? Why should people be better drivers? Why should other drivers let you go first? Why should everyone be a good driver, just because you want them to be one? For over one hundred years there have been drivers of all skill levels on the road with all kinds of reasons for the decisions they make (spoiler alert: none of them include your desires and preferences!). When you ask yourself these questions, you are beginning to challenge your irrational beliefs.

Sometimes it is hard to determine where the unreasonable part of your thinking is. This is because some of the 'facts' we consider to be infallible are so ingrained in our thinking that we do not realize that they need to be disputed and questioned. Some questions that are good to use to challenge a thought we hold as a fact came out the work of Dr. Albert Ellis and Byron Katie. You can always use these four questions to challenge your thoughts. They are very powerful in helping you give up your irrational beliefs.

1: Is it true? Ask yourself if what you are saying or thinking is an actual fact or if it is a demand that you are assuming things should be a certain way.

2: Is it absolutely true?! Is it 100% correct beyond a shadow of a doubt? Are you sure you are 100% correct, and anyone who disagrees with you is 100% wrong? Is there is any room for error? Maybe 90% true, or is there any room (1%) that you might be mistaken?

3: Well let's assume for the sake of arguing that you 'are' 100% correct! How do you think you are going to feel if you keep thinking these thoughts all day long? Happy? At peace?

4: How do you think you would feel if these thoughts never entered your mind? Our feelings follow our thinking. If we don't think about it, we feel fine. If we do, we feel upset over and over again!

Let's try applying these challenge questions to the idea that everyone should be a better driver. A lot of people would agree with this statement, but does that make it an incontestable fact? Let's look at those four questions.

1: Is it true that everyone should be a better driver? It would be arguably safer and more pleasant if they were, but the conditions for better drivers—stricter law enforcement, more extensive driver training, tougher licensing requirements—do not exist.

2: Is it possible that you are not 100% correct? What does 'better' mean anyway? Slower? More cautious? More considerate of your desires? I can think of one counter example off the top of my head where that statement would not be true: If someone had a pregnant woman about to give birth in the back of their car, it would not be prudent to be a 'better' driver. It would be in the best interest of the driver, the woman, and the baby to drive quickly to the nearest hospital and not obey each and every driving rule.

3: How will you feel if you keep thinking the other cars on the road should drive differently? You will probably be frustrated and angry on a regular basis.

4: Well, then, how do you think you would feel if you never thought about how the other drivers should drive? Probably a lot calmer with little or no anger or anxiety, which would probably make you a better driver.

When you ask yourself these four questions, you can see that this is a statement that can be disputed, and once it is disputed, you will have less disturbed thinking when you are behind the wheel.

Remember, it is the beliefs we hold that go *unquestioned* that cause us the most harm! Become a master at disputing your held beliefs—the key word here being 'held.' You suffer because

you cling tightly to your beliefs, refusing to let go under any circumstances; this will always eventually lead to emotional disturbance. Hold your beliefs—if any—very lightly with a cupped hand instead of a clenched fist, and always be willing to let go of it in an instant when new evidence emerges to refute it. One of the major reasons I love Zen so much is that it encourages us to have (i.e., hold) no beliefs! This is ultimate freedom. Nothing is holding us back. We do not have to consult some sacred standard or book to see if we are doing 'right.'

Let's now look back at those seven irrational beliefs and explore how to prove that they are irrational by disputing them.

1: 'It' Statements

An 'It' statement starts with the idea that something or someone beside yourself is responsible for your emotions. "He, she, it, that, they, or you upset me." It can also be a positive: "You make me happy." This kind of thinking will only lead to disturbance. Some phrases to be aware of (and to red-flag) are:

- It upset me.
- He or she pissed me off.
- That upset me.
- They made me angry.
- Those people really annoy me.
- It's not me, it's my nerves.
- If it wasn't for them, I would be happy.
- He or she is driving me into someone else's arms!
- You upset me!

When you begin to pay attention to your inner dialog, you'll notice much of your disturbance begins with blaming something or someone for creating a painful, inconvenient, or undesirable

feeling. If your computer is slow to open your email program when you're in a hurry to leave work you might gripe, "It's annoying how slow this stupid computer is!" On your commute home you might rail at the driver on your bumper, "This guy is such a jerk, he's really ticking me off!" When you arrive home to bikes in the driveway you might grumble, "It's so irritating when the kids don't put their stuff away."

In each of these examples you are handing off the responsibility for your emotions to something outside your control. You are telling yourself something outside of you—your computer, that driver, your children—has the power to force you to respond angrily! We cannot be upset by the outside world. We can only be upset by our conceptions—our thoughts, feelings and beliefs—about it.

If a person or thing could force you to be upset, then that same person or thing would cause everyone to be upset for all time. You may be angry when you get a flat tire, but that's not the flat tire's fault. If flat tires caused disturbance, every flat tire would lead to disturbance for every person! It would be a simple case of cause (flat tire) and effect (angry person).

A familiar example of cause and effect is how gravity works here on Earth. Gravity results in objects falling. Making things fall—all objects, according the same rules, every single time—is a function of gravity. It is measurable, provable, and predictable; g = 32 feet per second, squared. Does an object fall faster or slower at your house than it does at mine? I didn't think so. Same for you, same for me. None of us has any choice in the matter.

If disturbance were an inherent function of flat tires, this would also be a predictable, measurable outcome for everyone all the time; flat tire=x degree of y-disturbance/second. Getting angry—all people, to the same degree, at the same rate, all the time—would be the outcome of getting a flat tire. This is silly because we can't even measure disturbance! So, you can't be 'more' upset than I over a flat tire. There would be no variance in how we would feel. It is not cause and effect!

But you might think, "Well, I felt the Anger when the tire went flat, so if the flat tire isn't causing my Anger, then what is?" The answer is simple—it is your conception of what a flat tire means that's causing Anger. You've told yourself a story: that a flat tire means dirtying your clothes, waiting on a tow truck, arriving late to work, and maybe getting yelled at by the boss. But these things are not reality! They haven't happened and may not ever happen. You've assigned meaning to a simple fact. This creates a feedback loop of feeling, thinking, and behaving, and that's how you're creating feelings of Anger. It's not a personal attack by the tire! The tire doesn't care. It doesn't know if it's inflated or deflated—it doesn't even know it's a tire! The only thing that's true is that your tire no longer has air in it. The rest is a story you are telling yourself in your mind, your inner Narrator.

Let's go back to our traffic jam. When you feel your frustration building, look at the people in the cars around you. Are all of them banging on their steering wheel and screaming in Anger? No. Some of them are talking on their cell phones, or singing along to the radio, or listening to their books on tape. So the traffic jam cannot be making you angry, because if traffic jams caused Anger, then everyone around you or in traffic jams for all time would have to be angry too. You conceive traffic to be

inconvenient and have assigned a negative meaning to it—it is just wasted time and now you're going to be late for dinner. The lady singing along to the radio beside you is not angry because her perception of the situation is different. For her, it's a good time for an impromptu concert!

In short, 'It' did not anger you; 'It' simply exists because all the conditions are there for it to exist. The way you're conceiving 'It' did. It's what you tell yourself about these kinds of situations that create your feelings. Again, this is good news, because while situations will not always be convenient for you, and although there may be nothing you can do about it, you *can* master your *reaction* to these situations.

Let's say you hear someone at work swearing at the copy machine and shouting, "This machine sucks! It makes me so angry!" You can red-flag that irrational belief, noticing that your coworker is blaming something or someone else (in this case, an inanimate object) for their feelings of anger. You can practice disputing 'It' statements by recognizing that the copy machine is not capable of creating Anger in a human. It simply is what it is—working or not—and the human who is angry is the one creating the emotion. You can train yourself to recognize flawed thinking in others' behavior so you can avoid doing it yourself.

When you identify an 'It' statement as your irrational belief, ask yourself why you think 'It' is upsetting you and why it should be any different than it is. Remember that it is the way it is because the conditions exist for it to be that way—*if* the roller is jammed, *then* the copier doesn't copy. *If* air escapes from a tire, *then* the tire goes flat. This if/then relationship is based on scientific principles that are true for everyone all the time. It is not affected at all by your beliefs about it. The only way to

change the outcome is to change the conditions—to alter the 'if.' *If* you could fix the copier, *then* the copier *could* work, and wouldn't that be nice for you? But more often you can't change the conditions (i.e., make traffic flow more smoothly), so the outcome is a fixed, unchangeable reality. It is more rational and therefore less upsetting to realize that you are creating a conception that is negatively affecting only you and to replace it with acceptance.

The more you train yourself to notice 'It' statements the less likely you are to get upset with circumstances beyond your control and instead simply accept them for what they are.

2: Awfulizing

Awfulizing is when we take unpleasantness and make it more unpleasant than it is; we exaggerate the event or situation to an extreme degree. Now, the dictionary defines awful as simply unpleasant, but the way Ellis used it—as the basis for 'awfulizing'—is closer to what we may call 'catastrophizing.' In this sense, indicating the thought that something is not just unpleasant, but so much worse than unpleasant that it can't be measured. When we awfulize, we are perceiving something as being off the scale of suffering. This belief that anything can be completely 100% negative is irrational and damaging.

These are seven main ways we awfulize:

- Awful
- Horrible
- Terrible
- Dreadful
- Overwhelming
- Disastrous

- Catastrophic

We've all done it. We come down with the flu and groan, "Everything hurts and I'm dying." When you're exhausted you might remark, "I'm about to pass out right here." To many of us this kind of hyperbole seems harmless: just a little creative license to illustrate the severity of our discomfort. There are, however, emotional consequences. Every time you tell yourself, "This is as bad as it gets," you are creating an irrational belief. Can you prove this is the most extreme bout of flu you could ever suffer—worse than Stage 4 pancreatic cancer? It sucks and it feels physically uncomfortable but reinforcing the belief that you could not possibly feel worse than you do right now will create emotional disturbance. It's certainly not going to make you feel any better!

There are three ways to dispute Awfulizing. You don't need all three, one should be enough, but in case one doesn't work for you have options.

OPTION 1: AWFUL AS AN ATTRIBUTE

We often use awful as an attribute. That is, when we ascribe an inherent characteristic to something else that doesn't actually possess it. It's subjective—an opinion. There is nothing that inherently possesses awful, so this is automatically false. For example, if you stood in a modern art museum in front of a Chagall painting and asked the first twenty people what they thought of the painting, some would love it and others would say it was awful. You say to all the second group, "Put your finger on the awfulness in the painting." It can't be done.

All twenty of these people could point to the red, the green, or the blue in the painting and agree that those are indeed red,

green, and blue, but none of them could show you where the 'awful' is. This is because awful doesn't actually exist in the painting—it is something that exists in the mind! Calling something awful is attributing a characteristic to it that it in itself doesn't possess.

When you realize you have created the concept of awful in your mind, you can then dispute the irrational belief that you have no choice but to feel disturbed. If you created the disturbance, you can get rid of it!

OPTION 2: AWFUL AS AN EXAGGERATION

The second way to dispute awful is to put it on a scale of unpleasantness from 0% to 100%. Zero percent would mean that nothing was unpleasant and 100% would be the worst thing that could ever happen to you or others in this lifetime.

How Awful Is It?

On a scale of 0% to 100%, where would having an itch that you couldn't quite reach fall? How about getting a speeding ticket? How about being tortured to death? Some people react to a spot on their shirt or blouse as if were a first strike nuclear attack! There is a variation in our experiences in life and we will have them all up and down this spectrum. Where does the thing you are calling awful fall? If your boyfriend didn't call last night, is this really a catastrophe? Where would that fall on the scale? Probably not very high, once you put it in perspective. Also, visualizing a scale helps us see that things could always be worse. Perhaps you would say that losing a loved one is very close

to 100% on your scale. But what if you lost 2 loved ones? That would be worse, right? What if the plane crashed going to the Parr family reunion? Surely that would be awful—right? No, it could still always be worse! So nothing can be entirely awful because things could always be worse. Thus, looking at things on a scale of unpleasantness disputes the idea that something can be entirely awful.

When we use 'awful' to describe our belief about a situation we don't like, we are saying it isn't even on a scale of unpleasantness. It's off the scale! It's 110% or 400% which, of course, is impossible. It's like the coach who tells his team, "We are going to give 110% today!" If 100% means 'as much as exists,' where does that extra 10% come from?

I used to say that being tortured to death was probably at 100% on the scale and qualifies as truly Awful. But someone in my audience correctly pointed out that something could always be worse than this. When I asked, "Well, what could be worse?" he said, "That you could be tortured to death slower!" And he was correct! Something could always be worse.

To dispute awful, realize you can never get to 100% unpleasant in reality; something could always be worse. Hitler could have killed all the Jewish people. He could have won World War II; this would have been worse. Again, things can be very unpleasant, but awful exists only in the mind. It may take a while for this to sink in. It did me. But give it a shot. Eventually the light will come on and it will make complete sense (well, almost complete sense).

OPTION 3: AWFUL AS A SHOULD

The third way to disprove awful is to realize when we are using awful as a Should: to say that it is so unpleasant that it shouldn't exist! For example, "I can take 69% unpleasantness, but 70% is too horrible and it Should not be!" But 70% unpleasantness has always existed and always will (at least in our mind!).

When you call something awful, you are saying that because you don't like it, it shouldn't exist! This is egocentric thinking and leads to suffering, because no matter how much we would like something not to exist (or exist), it exists because all the conditions are there for it to exist. Reality does not adjust itself to our likes and dislikes.

> *"Poverty and hardship are created by false thinking."*
> BODHIDHARMA

> *"With our thoughts, we make the world."*
> BUDDHA

3: I Can't Stand It (ICSI)!

The third irrational belief says we cannot survive under the current conditions: "I can't stand it!" This belief is a funny one because if you truly couldn't stand something, you would be dead! If you're reading this sentence at this moment in time, it is proof that you have stood everything that has ever happened to you in your entire life. And you will continue to stand everything until the millisecond of your death. If you truly couldn't stand something, you would just keel over!

Other "I can't stand it!" statements to red-flag are:

- It crept up on me (e.g., the irrational response, the feeling, etc.)
- It's driving me crazy.

- Something just snapped.
- Something came over me.
- Those people are driving me…*up the wall / crazy / bananas / to drink / to the brink, etc.*!
- It fell on me from out of the blue! (e.g., again, the irrational response, feeling, or behavior)
- I can't stand it.
- I've had enough!
- I can't take it anymore!
- It's unacceptable!
- This is the straw that broke the camel's back!

We know "I can't stand it!" is irrational because every time you have said it to yourself you were wrong. You have provably stood every single thing that has ever happened to you in your entire life! "I can't stand it!" has never been true about anything that has happened to you, and you can't reliably predict if you can't stand something in the future, so that statement can never be correct. You may have stood things poorly in the past, which is what you are here to work on so that you don't keep repeating this pattern of behavior in the future. But let's start with: "You have and will 'stand' everything in your life until your last breath."

Many parents have remarked, halfway through the summer break, "These kids are driving me crazy." I know my own mother said it many times! A new intern at a busy firm might find herself thinking, "I just can't handle this pressure!"

Most listeners will understand you are not driving yourself to the psychiatric ward once the kids are in bed or that you're going to keel over with the next paper added to your inbox, but you've nonetheless formed an irrational belief. You've told

yourself a person or situation has pushed you to your absolute limit—the end. Goodbye to your life as you know it!

You may say, "I can't stand cockroaches!" Few people will argue with the sentiment that cockroaches are not desirable houseguests, but even fewer people have died from a nighttime visitation. "Cockroaches are gross" is a conception, you cannot perceive gross this is a concept, not a universal fact; believe it or not there are people who like and collect cockroaches. That people don't generally die from seeing or touching a cockroach is a provable fact and, by that standard, Rational. Therefore, the opposite statement, "I cannot continue existing after seeing a cockroach," is unprovable and irrational. However, you may still not like them. But they are not, alas, the Grim Reaper!

I once heard a colleague confess how irritated he gets when he seems to get stopped by every single red light on his commute to work. By the fourth or fifth light he'd be fuming and Awfulizing. "This happens every time! I can't stand it!" he'd yell. He realized this irrational belief was causing him emotional stress and starting his day off on an unnecessarily negative note. One day he imagined literally not surviving a red light—that the glowing red eye glared him to death right there in the intersection. He envisioned his obituary headline 'Man Loses Life to Killer Stoplight' and began to laugh. He disputed his "I can't stand it!" statement with rational, provable evidence: no one's ever died from waiting at a red light. On the other hand, getting angry about stoplights—which exist and over which we have no control—could certainly raise your blood pressure to dangerous levels.

To dispute "I can't stand it!" statements, it is essential to acknowledge that if a statement is not true or provable, it is by

definition irrational and will lead to feelings of Anger, Anxiety, Depression and Guilt! It is not true that you are now insane, dying, or about to pop open. These are not provable facts and are therefore irrational.

When you find yourself thinking any of the red-flagged "I can't stand it!" statements, recognize that you most certainly *can* stand it. You can say to yourself, "I can and will live through this. This is not a death sentence." Otherwise you'd already be dead, and the situation or person you believe you cannot stand would be your murderer! The sooner you stop telling yourself you can't stand it, that you 'just' don't like it, you will realize that you can and will stand everything that happens to you until the millisecond you stop existing, the sooner you will stop being disturbed and start living well.

As Albert Ellis always said:

> *"You stand everything until the millisecond of death. The fact that you are saying that you can't stand it is proof that you 'are' standing it! You may be standing it poorly, but you are standing it. If a steamroller rolls over you slowly in first gear, you stand it to the point of death!"*

Big Al always did have a way with words!

4: Shoulds, Musts, Demands (SMDs)

The fourth irrational belief is that a person, situation, or thing should be different than it is because we don't like it: "It should be this way, not that way." SMD's (Shoulds, Musts & Demands) are the underlying irrational beliefs behind every negative emotion. You can't feel bad without a Should, must or demand!

Dr. Albert Ellis use to say: "When you are upset—*cherche la Should* (look for the Should)." This is what happens when our preferences become demands. What you would like reality to be becomes what you believe reality *ought* to be. In essence we have two philosophies toward life: a 'desiring philosophy' which is sane and rational, and a 'demanding philosophy' which is crazy and self-defeating. SMDs are the latter.

The 17 major SMDs to red-flag are:

- Should
- Must
- Ought to
- Have to
- Got to
- Supposed to
- Need to
- Expect
- Insist
- Obligation
- Ultimatum
- Fault
- Blame
- Deserve
- Owe (as in "You owe me.")
- Imperative
- Demand

I strongly recommend putting these 17 Should statements on your refrigerator or bathroom mirror and memorizing them, because this is the main cause of your disturbance and what ruins most of your relationships!

You can sum up emotional disturbance in a nutshell. You can throw away your Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM)-IV, V, VI, and all later additions, forget all the labeling and rating of your friends, patients, and yourself, and look for one of all three of these ways of distorted thinking:

1: "**I should** be perfectly competent, adequate, achieving, and successful in all possible ways, and isn't it awful if I am not!" This belief can lead to Depression, Guilt, shame, and self-loathing.

2: "**You must** treat me kindly, lovingly, considerately, respectfully, and of course put my "needs" first and ahead of yours, and if you don't do this, you are a bitch or a bastard that deserves severe punishment." This, as you can see, leads to Anger, rage, hate, vindictiveness, revenge, murder, and even genocide.

3: "**The world must** be fair, just, kind, loving, forgiving, and give me everything I want on a golden platter (screw the silver one), and if it doesn't do this then it is a horrible and terrible place and I might as well kill myself!"

This leads to low frustration tolerance and can cause all of the above emotions and mistreatment of self and others.

You have almost no control over what happens outside of yourself! Dr. Ellis was also famous in saying, "The Universe (or reality) doesn't give a fuck about you or what happens to you! And if you still believe it does after all you have seen in your life, then you are easily disturb-able!"

You do, however, have a great deal of control over your *reaction* to what happens to you. You can replace irrational thoughts and

demands with rational thoughts and preferences, which we'll cover in the disputing section a little later.

These SMDs are irrational, widespread and probably so rooted in your thoughts and belief systems that you don't even realize you are thinking them. Start listening for the 17 SMD statements in your thoughts and words. Look for them, stop them, dispute them, let them go, and you will be on your way to rational living and personal happiness.

The easiest way to dispute SMDs is to realize that what exists, exists. What doesn't exist, doesn't exist. This leads us to the only Rational should: "Everything that *happens* today *should* happen!" The key word in this sentence is 'happens,' not 'should.' If it happens, then it must exist. Since something *does* exist, it *should* exist because all the conditions occurred for it to do so. Everything that happens is the result of past events that created current conditions. Each millisecond is composed of trillions of conditions. You don't have a time machine to change all the preceding events, so how can you expect to change the ones that are happening now? If the conditions exist for an event to occur, then the event must occur.

When you are sitting in traffic, thinking, "There shouldn't be so much traffic," you can take a breath, be aware of the key words 'should or shouldn't,' and consciously note that this statement is irrational. Reality shows us traffic exists—you can see it, you can hear it, and you can't move your car because of it! It exists because all the necessary conditions to create a traffic jam have already occurred and are still occurring—a lot of cars on the road, roads that are not wide enough, everyone getting out of work at the same time, etc. How could you have clear sailing under these conditions? Not without a flying car you couldn't!

Since the conditions for traffic exist, traffic *does* exist, it *should* exist, and *will* exist for as long as the conditions remain. It cannot be otherwise regardless of whether it is pleasant or unpleasant for you or me.

Once you have become aware of your irrational, demanding philosophy (SMDs) you can replace it with a rational, desiring philosophy. Some desiring or preference words to replace your demanding words are:

- It would be better…
- I would like…
- I would prefer...
- It would be nice…
- We could…

Let's put these desiring words into our three examples from before. If we replace these with a rational, desiring philosophy toward life, these statements become:

1: "**It would be better** if I were more competent, adequate, achieving, and successful in most ways!" You are accepting what is true and making a rational, provable statement about what would be better for you.

2: "**I would like** you to treat me kindly, lovingly, considerately, and courteously." This is rational. The desire for kind treatment exists in you, therefore it is true.

3: "**It would be nice** if the world were fair, just, kind, loving, and easy." This is a rational statement, and leads to tolerance of ourselves, others, and the world in general and helps us behave in those ways. As a bonus, we usually feel better too!

Do you see how much softer and more pleasant these words sound when compared to demands? A Should can be replaced with 'I would prefer,' or 'it would be better.' This we can prove or disprove. This is what makes it rational and scientific. It would be better if you didn't cheat on me (at least for me), but there's no law of the Universe that says you shouldn't do it! If there were such a law, then no one could ever cheat on anyone, because physical laws of the Universe must be obeyed and wouldn't allow it. It is when our preferences become demands that we are saying a Should and becoming upset.

Let's say you look in the mirror and tell yourself, "I should go to the gym," or "I should not have eaten that cake." But you didn't go to the gym and you did eat the cake. That's reality. But by practicing disputing, you can train yourself to hear those irrational beliefs (the 'Shoulds'), stop, and change them to preferences; "It would be better for my health if I went to the gym a few days a week," or "I'd like to practice healthier eating habits." These are true statements that don't contradict reality.

Zen has a great statement I love: "No snowflake ever falls in the wrong place." How could it? Events have already happened that created conditions for each and every snowflake to fall exactly where it does. In the past hours rain clouds piled up and the temperature dropped. The pressure changed and water droplets were released, freezing as they hit cold air. The laws of physics determined the velocity, drift, and landing zone of each flake. That snowflake doesn't care in the least that it landed on top of the other four inches of flakes you are unhappily wiping off your windshield. It is exactly where events and conditions dictated. In all of history, no snowflake, no grain of sand on the beach, no atom in the vastness of space *has ever been in the*

wrong place. Each one exists because all of the conditions happened for it to exist, right where it is.

When you find yourself 'Shoulding,' recognize first that the situation exists because all the conditions are there for it to exist. It can't be any other way! Then you can replace it with softer language and acceptance. "It would be lovely if I were the only person on this road but that's not the reality of rush hour in the city!"

> *"He who is not contented with what he has*
> *would not be contented with what he would like to have."*
> SOCRATES

> *"Everything that happens today should happen!"*
> ALBERT ELLIS

5: Rating

The fifth irrational belief is the concept that someone or something is good or bad, better or worse, right or wrong. "I'm worthless and I'll never amount to anything!" We are rating when we arbitrarily judge and define something, someone, or our self with a label—good or bad, right or wrong, worthwhile or worthless—and decide, in that moment the entire worth of that person. This may be directed inward at ourselves or outward at someone or something else.

Some phrases to red-flag are:

- I'm the best or worst…*athlete / husband / artist, etc.*
- He is always…*late / loud / rude, etc.*
- You're a bad…*student / child / lover / friend, etc.*
- I am worthless and no damn good!
- I am great and wonderful.

Rating—in either a positive or negative way—leads to disturbance, so red-flag both kinds of rating. Watch for '-er' words. When we use -er words like better, smarter, funnier, prettier, hotter, cooler, richer, dumber, etc., to describe ourselves or others, we are nearly always rating. Rating is a major cause of all kinds of human suffering, even leading to wars and conflicts between loved ones and nations. This is no small matter.

When you apply any kind of label to a person, you are essentially deciding their entire worth. When you say someone or something *is* bad, you are assigning them the exact same qualities as the word. Bad, by definition, can contain no good or it wouldn't be bad, and good can contain no bad or it wouldn't be good. But people do both good and bad things, so if a person is entirely bad, they can contain no good. Someone who contains no good would *only* be capable of bad things forever! They would be incapable of petting a dog on the head or sending their mom a Mother's Day card, because that which *is* bad can only *do* bad. Good could *only* do good. They could never spit on the sidewalk, forget their anniversary, or ever have one bad thought. This doesn't mean we allow ourselves to accept poor or destructive actions, but it is more rational and correct to rate the action separate from the person. It may be beneficial to rate your behavior but never yourself.

This belief is the most difficult to dispute because it requires you to give up the pervasive concept of self and self-esteem that has been ingrained in you since childhood. We hear and are taught from day one in our culture, society, and religion that self-esteem and self-worth are necessary, that We are a good person or a bad person depending on whether we do the things our particular society or culture tells us to do. If we do not do

what religion and society says, then we are awful and terrible! And we are not only awful in this life, but we will also burn in hell in some sort of afterlife—forever! How can anyone be happy with that hanging over their whole life? We are perpetuating ideas that will never lead to contentment.

Many people claim you can't find happiness without self-worth. I will go so far as to say that you will never obtain true happiness and contentment with a concept of self-worth! But why do we treat self-esteem as a desirable trait, something we must accumulate and accommodate as we grow up? If our thinking creates a conception of self-esteem as 'good,' then in order to be good we must rate ourselves as good at all times, regardless of our thoughts, feelings and behaviors. I have done a lot of work in prisons and will tell you for certain that most of the sociopaths and criminals I worked with possessed an overabundance of self-esteem. The desire for self-esteem, at its pinnacle, tops out with sociopathy. Is that what we want our children to emulate? How much self-rating will yield 'enough' self-esteem?

The same goes for physical appearance. I feel so sorry for the young girls that grow up in our society today. They are taught that they should not only strive to be beautiful, but that it is directly related to their self-worth. As a result, we have a society full of plastic surgery addicts and formerly healthy teenagers who are slowly starving themselves to death because of eating disorders. Even as adults we rate ourselves as "thinner than her, but not as thin as she is" or "more handsome than my brother, but not as handsome as my best friend."

For example, a student facing a big exam or trying out for the varsity football team believes that if he doesn't make an A on the exam or secure a place on the first string, he is a failure.

And since failure is bad, he must be a bad person. What he has been taught by his parents, his school environment, and what he sees on TV assigns meaning to his failure—that *doing* bad means *being* bad.

So, how do we dispute rating? Giving up the concept of self is the first step. Along with Rational Theory, I find the Buddhist Philosophy can help us to not cling so tightly to a concept of self. Many people mistakenly believe that the Buddha said that there was no self. This is not what he taught. He said that no matter where you look, you cannot *find* a self. Many people will point to their body and say, "Here I am." But that is the body. Where is the 'I,' the self that we are so protective of and have to please and get more and more stuff for? Go to your nearest medical center and tell them you want an MRI so you can find yourself. You may soon hear them calling the Psych Department. All of science, philosophy, or religion throughout human existence has never been able to find it, but feel free to give it a shot! How can you rate something you can never find? You can't! If you find yourself, you will be famous—the first person in human history to have ever done it. You will be the next Albert Einstein! Many religions claim that they not only know that you have a self, soul, I, or me, but they even know what happens to it after you die! Wow, what power! George Carlin called this "major bullshit!"

The second part is to understand rating as a product of your own conception, a story your Narrator tells you about the information it receives. Joseph Goldstein, an excellent Vipassana Meditation teacher, explained it in the following manner: When you go out at night, and the moon is not out, look up at the stars and pick out the Big Dipper. Most everyone can do this.

Now ask yourself; "Is there really a Big Dipper in the sky? Can I reach up, grab the 'handle' and scoop out a bit of space?" Of course not! We have assigned a shape, label and meaning to an arrangement of pinpoints of light completely unrelated cooking tools! Would it be a Big Dipper to primitive man? To a raccoon? They are stars—no more, no less. They exist, and they exist in those positions regardless of what we think, feel, or believe. But we teach and have been taught to call it the Big Dipper, which makes some sense anyone who's seen a ladle or dipper, so we believe it. Once you understand the concept of the Big-Dipper-that-isn't, try looking in the sky and *not* seeing the Big Dipper. Once this concept has formed, it is hard not to see it. The same with the concept of self. Once this concept has formed, it is very hard to let it go, but is very much worth the effort. On the other side is *Satori*, or enlightenment. This is major work and necessary for long term joy and happiness.

In the same way, we look in the mirror, and having already formed a conception of sour elf we say, "Oh, there I am!" However, the reflection in the mirror is not *you*—it's just an image reflected in the glass. It can do nothing on its own and has no meaning of its own. It is not us. Our thoughts, feelings and behaviors shift from moment to moment, always acting and reacting differently. Our cells are constantly changing, dying, and multiplying. We are literally a different being every second, and when we rate ourselves (or others) we are placing a sweeping total evaluation on the entirety of our existence. How can you rate an ever-changing system? I may be good now, but am I still good 15 minutes from now? Are those newly created cells still good, or did the good disappear with the ones that died over that time period? Are my current thoughts and behaviors

bad? Does that mean my thoughts and behaviors for the rest of my life will be bad?

How would you be different if you never rated yourself? Imagine looking in the mirror and only seeing whether your hair is out of place or your outfit matches, instead of tearing yourself to pieces over a birthmark or a grey hair or a few extra pounds. Rating is inherently damaging to your mental health. Even if you look in the mirror and think, "Wow what great shape I am in!" you are hurting yourself, because what happens in fifteen years, when you don't look the same? Are you somehow inferior to your younger self? Rating positively or negatively is still negative!

Another excellent perspective on the negative effects of self-worth comes directly from Albert Ellis's book, *A Guide to Rational Living*:

> *"Above all, don't confuse getting love with having personal worth. If you rate yourself as having intrinsic worth or value as a human, you'd better claim to have it by virtue of your mere existence, your aliveness, and not because of anything you do to earn it. No matter how much others approve of you, or how much they may value you for their own benefit, they can only give you, as Robert S. Hartman noted, extrinsic value, or worth to them. They cannot, by loving you, give you intrinsic value or self-worth. If intrinsic value exists at all (which we seriously doubt, since it seems an undefinable Kantian thing-in-itself), you get it because you choose, you decide to have it. It exists because of your own definition. You are good or deserving because you*

> *think you are and not because anyone awards you this kind of an inherent value."*

The third step in disputing rating is to stop evaluating *people* and only rate *behavior*. This applies to rating yourself as well. Stop calling people bad and simply realize their behavior might be bad or unpleasant to you at that moment, but the person's entire 'ever-changing system' is not bad. If a child draws on walls or pulls his sister's hair, he is not a bad child. His behavior was bad and unpleasant, so as a parent you would try to alter his behavior, but his essence is not bad. If someone cuts you off as you drive down the road, it is their actions that you don't like, not the person. They may be exhibiting asshole-type behavior at that moment, but that person does not exist solely and unfailingly as an asshole.

When you recognize that we are all changing every moment for our entire lives, it is easier to understand why rating a person is irrational. If we are not the same from one millisecond to the next, how can you apply a permanent judgment of self-worth? It is more reasonable to say, "I did not accomplish the things I wanted to today," than to say, "I'm lazy." If you tell yourself you exist as simply and wholly lazy, you're saying you will never accomplish anything. All it takes is one day of checking things off your to-do list to prove you are not, by definition, lazy.

Our varsity football player can dispute self-rating that his failure to earn a first-string position means he is a failure and a bad person. If he were to apply rational thinking, he might say to himself, "I don't like failing, but 'I,' my essence, is not a failure. I am changing all the time!" Because his cells, thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are always changing, it is rational to think that he can perform better if the conditions exist for him to do so—if

he trains harder, practices more often and eliminates distractions. But even if he does succeed, that doesn't mean he's a better person. It's just as irrational to apply positive self-rating; "I'm a great guy because I scored two touchdowns!" It would be more rational to think, "I performed better tonight and man, that feels pretty good!" (I would prefer this person commit to Auburn University, but that's another topic for another time!)

If you find your irrational belief falls into the 'rating' category, determine who you're rating. Is it you or someone else? What are you or they doing? Why is that behavior or trait upsetting to you? Recognize that it is not the person being rated causing your disturbance, but the meaning you've assigned to the behavior or trait. The person—you or another—is simply who they are at that moment in time and can't be any different in that moment. "As it is, not as I want it to be."

Once you stop this kind of self-defeating defining, you will tend to lose your desperate needs for others' approval. You can accept that you need never rate yourself—the entire sum of your ever-changing system—and that you can choose a life of awareness and acceptance, just because you decide to do so. Recognize that you only think you need their acceptance, not because of the practical advantages it may bring, but because you foolishly define your worth as a human being in terms of receiving it.

Conversely, as you reduce the need for the approval of others, you will find you reduce the need to rate yourself as a person. You may continue to rate many of your traits, but you will create unconditional self-acceptance regardless of those traits.

When you truly stop evaluating yourself and others, you will eliminate the concept of personal worth or of human worth. This sounds negative but it is in reality very positive. Keep in mind, it's just as self- defeating to rate yourself as good and wonderful and deserving as it is to tell yourself that you're bad, awful, worthless and non-deserving. There is no universal scale of best to worst for us to be rated on. There is no Yelp! review system for humans, much as we may sometimes wish there were. You are you. They are them. Don't compare or rate. Just be better in the ways you can, in your behavior and actions. Let the rest go.

If you give up all rating and just learn to enjoy the present flow of all of life as it is—likes, dislikes, and everything between—you can *Amor fati*, love it all, simply because it is your life. Wouldn't it be great if this were taught in our school systems? No more popular kids vs. the 'losers,' no more bullies vs. teachers' pets. Everyone is unconditionally accepted just as they are!

The Golden Rule of Rational Living and the four blocks is this:

Never, never, ever, put yourself down about anything!

"Every situation—nay, every moment—is of infinite worth; for it is the representative of a whole eternity."
JOHANN WOLFGANG VON GOETHE

6: Absolutistic Statements

The sixth irrational belief is absolutistic statements. Like Awfulizing, absolutistic thinking is another way of exaggerating the circumstance to unnecessary extremes. When something is absolute, it means there are no exceptions under *any* circum-

stances, *ever*. "I'll never find love," "I always screw up," are just a few examples.

Some phrases to red-flag are:

- Always and Never
- Good and Bad
- Right and Wrong
- Good and Evil
- Praise and Blame
- Gain and Loss
- Pleasure and Pain

These are examples of extremes in our thinking that are almost always incorrect. The universe does not exist in black and white, but in millions of glorious hues and shades in between! There are many positions between the absolutes. We often identify ourselves with; pro-life or pro-choice, pro or anti-gun laws, one religion or another, Democrat or Republican, pro- or anti-LBGQ+ rights, for or against legalizing marijuana, etc. These are black and white labels for tiny, defined sets of absolutes. Always & never thinking says you either fit into the box (always agree) or you don't (never agree). What one person believes is right another will view as wrong, and we can fight about it forever, can't we?

So, which is it? Neither! Thinking makes it so, as Shakespeare told us in Hamlet (Act II, scene 2) almost 600 years ago! *"Nothing is either good or bad but thinking makes it so."* The actual truth is that both extremes exist—they simple are. This is seeing totality—and you can embrace this fact or continue fighting. You choose. And how will this affect your personal happiness? Do you really have any control over this?

In absolutistic thinking the conditions are permanent and complete. This is true of scientific laws and very little else. It is certainly not true of our circumstances for three main reasons we've already discussed;

1: Events only happen as a result of a specific set of conditions.
2: Our emotions are created by our beliefs about events not the events themselves.
3: We are an ever-changing system, never the same at any two moments in time.

Therefore, if we are always changing, our conceptions, thoughts, and events will change, too. When our conception of events changes, so too do our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. Just because you're feeling distraught about your job options today doesn't mean you'll always feel this way, or that you are a failure and you'll never get a job. It could change today, or tomorrow, or 50 years from now, but it won't last forever. In fact it never stays fixed at all. All of life is in a constant state of flux, flow, and change. This is reality as it is; our thoughts about reality are never reality.

It may help to understand that your brain has evolved over millions of years to anticipate patterns in an attempt to protect you from pain. If a certain set of conditions preceded a painful event in the past, your Narrator will associate that event if it notices indications of that circumstance again. Because we often see what we're looking for, your Narrator may tell you those conditions exist where they actually don't. You end up in a negative feedback loop where the pattern repeats itself until you begin to believe that it will always be that way. The only way out of that loop is by engaging the Observer. Look at the

facts. The only thing you know for sure is that you don't have a job right now. Your conception of what it means to be jobless—that you're a loser, a failure, a no-talent slug—is a story you are choosing to tell yourself. You are assigning irrational meaning to a provable fact, but you can choose not to! Humans can't tell the future so you can't possibly know if you'll have a job in the future—neither does anyone else! What you can know is that sitting on your couch binge-watching TV isn't as helpful as distributing resumes. That's a fact, too.

Is it true that you'll never find love? You don't know! It happens when you least expect it. One of my colleagues had a Grandfather in a nursing home who was romantically involved with two women he called his two wives—and he was 106 years old! Is it true that you'll never be successful? Well that's up to you! For most of our life, our outcomes are largely the result of our actions, timing, and being in the place most optimum for change to occur.

The last step to disputing an absolutistic statement requires acceptance of the facts you've observed. Be willing to release your belief about the present circumstance and accept that the conditions are the way that they are and that they are changing. Resisting this moment won't change anything because it's already happened. For example, snap your finger — can you get it back? The best definition of mental health I have ever heard is 'infinite flexibility in a world of constant change.' Conversely, disturbance can be characterized as 'rigidity in a world of constant change.'

When you let go of the extreme, that a situation or circumstance is permanent and absolute, it begins to feel less urgent, less hopeless. You can choose to observe the facts, note how things

change from moment to moment, and realize that a shift away from absolutistic thinking, however minor, is a step toward peace and contentment.

> *"The moment is the sole reality."*
> KARL JASPERS

> *"People say that what we're all seeking is a meaning for life. I don't think that's what we're really seeking. I think that what we're seeking is an experience of being alive, so that our life experiences on the purely physical plane will have resonances within our own innermost being and reality, so that we actually feel the rapture of being alive."*
> JOSEPH CAMPBELL

7: The Idea of Entitlement

The seventh irrational belief concerns delusions of being deserving or undeserving: "I deserve to be respected!" This irrational belief has two sides: one extreme is believing that we are more deserving or better than anyone else and that we automatically deserve things to go our way. The flip side to this is feeling un-deserving—that because of our mistakes in the past, we are not worthy of happiness or joy. Guilt, self-blame, and Depression soon follow.

Some phrases to red-flag are:

- I don't deserve this…*gift / compliment / award, etc.*
- I deserve the diamond tennis bracelet (an actual quote from a client!).
- You worked hard and you deserve it.
- They deserved the punishment they got.
- I am entitled to better treatment.
- I deserve respect.

- I am entitled to…*a better neighborhood / the best food / higher education / prompt service / affordable medical treatment / etc.*, because of my…*title / position / family / ancestry / race / religion / wealth / caste, etc.*

Entitlement begins with egocentric thinking—that yours is the only perception that matters. This idea of entitlement is to me one of the ugliest ideas about the human condition. This 'my way or the highway' belief system is the basis of nearly all human cruelty, racism, bigotry, wars, murder, and genocide. "My Aryan race is exclusively entitled to a privileged existence (the finest art, luxurious living conditions, bountiful food, the rarest delicacies)" is the essence of the entitled thought that created the Holocaust.

When you believe you are entitled, you are saying you're special. Everything should always go your way, you should have everything you want, and anything you dislike should cease to exist immediately if not sooner. Yet from experience we know things don't always go our way, we don't have everything we want, and we can't avoid things we dislike, let alone erase their existence. Expecting any other outcome is a clear recipe for emotional distress. A sense of entitlement can make you blind to reality. You become so confident and absorbed in your story—of which you are the perfect and infallible star—that you lose touch with what's really going on around you.

If you find yourself clinging to feelings of entitlement, first pause to zoom out and look at the big picture. There are more than 7 billion individual humans on this planet who are all the star of their own unique story, some more than 100 years long. This planet is only one celestial body among trillions of stars, galaxies, and planets; the potential for life scattered across

the Universe beyond the comparatively tiny rock we occupy is limitless. You, on the other hand, are a teeny, insignificant speck of consciousness in the vast complexity of the cosmos, so why should *you* get the last pint of Chunky Monkey?

Every human who has ever existed is the imperfect and ultimately fleeting product of conditions, both internal and external. We all have complex lives and intense emotions, and we are all struggling with problems that can feel painful and overwhelming. Many of us *think* we know what we deserve; good, bad or in between. But both Zen philosophy and Rational Theory state that 'deserve' is just another Should, a concept that has no meaning except the meaning we give it, so let go of any 'deserve' or 'not deserve' concepts. True understanding and contemplation of reality will help you approach others from a place of compassion rather than a place of disdain or superiority. Life will go a lot easier. The only thing you will lose is your disturbance and you will become a lot more kind.

A healthy balance of confidence and humility (acceptance of yourself and acceptance of others) will often render you more likeable, attractive, and trustworthy. People will feel at ease with you, grateful to be around someone who is not judging or competing with them. Remind yourself that allowing other people to shine does not make you less valuable or dull. We are all on this planet together. I once heard a great Rational statement on a program on Minimalism: "Love people and use things. Because, the other way around never works." Great advice.

Once we've mastered shifting from The Narrator, which tells us stories about how the world should be, to The Observer, which allows us to view ourselves and the world as we are, red-flagging and disputing the irrational beliefs, and replacing those

beliefs with rational ones—we will take it to the final step, the formula for happiness that I will teach you at the end.

"When you understand interconnectedness,
it makes you more afraid of hating than of dying."
ROBERT A. THURMAN

"The good life is one inspired by love and guided by reason!"
BERTRAND RUSSELL

"Our life is what our thoughts make it."
MARCUS AURELIUS

CHAPTER 5

THE FORMULA FOR ANGER

"We all get angry in exactly the same way: with a Should, Must or Demand."
VINCE PARR

The formula for Anger is universal. It doesn't matter the language, race, religion or culture, we all get angry in the exact same way. We can put this in an equation that will work with everyone on the planet:

A = ET + S

A*nger* = **E***gocentric* **T***hinking* + **S***hould*

ET: Egocentric Thinking

Egocentric thinking is the concept of 'I'-ness. In other words, we place ourselves at the center of the universe; "Anything I don't like, find unpleasant, inconvenient, frustrating, or annoying, should not exist. Anything I do like should spring into existence!" This is crazy thinking! Whether or not we like something does not change its existence.

You are not the center of the universe and the universe is not here to bend to your every wish. Scientists estimate there are more suns in the universe than there are grains of sand on all the beaches on planet Earth. Many, if not most of these suns are surrounded by planets. Just in our own solar system, we

are only one of 8 planets (sorry Pluto!) and on this one planet, there are now some 7 billion people! Each of us is just one of billions of carbon based life forms that have evolved on just one of billions of planets: specks on specks! When you consider how many possible other living beings there are and could be, and how many problems each of them may have, you can see how ridiculous it would be to assume reality would bend to you and your wants. It may be nice for you if it did, but it doesn't. A famous Zen proverb states: *"If you understand, things are just as they are. If you don't understand, things are just as they are."* Your opinion of the situation has absolutely no bearing on its existence.

While we are not born with a sense of self per se—there is no Ego to speak of—our feelings and needs are our sole concern. We don't care that Mom hasn't slept more than two hours at a time since we arrived, or that Dad is still figuring out how to diaper correctly. We have no idea—nor do we care—whether bottles spring into existence solely as a result of our relentless squalling. All we know is we are hungry and wet and we don't like it. We want it fixed right now and will yell until it happens (which, to be fair, isn't that different for some of us as adults!) This is to be expected of an infant. They are not yet capable of rational thought. As a child develops a sense of self they may still be most concerned with their own wants and needs, but they can be taught—and perhaps more importantly, shown by example—that their preferences do not dictate the outcome of a situation. But if that child isn't taught that they are not the center of the universe, they will eventually become that obnoxious-acting person in the bank line yelling at the poor teller about an overdraft charge and demanding a refund.

S: Should

Egocentric thinking alone doesn't create Anger. It only sets us up for it. We only get angry when we say to ourselves a Should, Must or Demand. Let's take that example of being charged unexpected bank fees and break down the emotional response using the ABC's. The ABCs, if you recall, are:

A = Activating Event
B = Belief or Belief System
C = Consequences

So our overdraft charge situation would look like this:

A = You find a $30 overdraft fee on your bank statement
B = "I should not have been charged this fee!"
C = You are angry and your account is still $30 short.

The A, the activating event, occurred because you spent more than you had in your account, and because banks tend to discourage that sort of thing by charging hefty fees. This is a provable fact.

The B, the belief, is a Should—that bank fees shouldn't apply because they are inconvenient to you and you don't like them. "I'm a loyal customer. I deserve a refund!" The B is critical because it is the step that allows you to red-flag and dispute. Without it, you'd jump straight to C.

The C, or consequence, is that you are angry that you have less money in your account than you expected, and it was spent on something you didn't want.

Now let's stop and think about this for a second. How can a bank fee make you angry? It is a line of print, an abstract concept executed by a series of 1s and 0s, yet it has the power to

infuriate a human being? The transaction has no feelings, no desires—it doesn't even know it exists, so it certainly doesn't see you and say, there's Vince, I think I'll rob him of his lunch money! When you say the bank fee makes you mad or angry, you are practicing egocentric thinking, and you are insisting that it should be different simply because it is inconvenient for you.

I can show you quickly how to disprove the idea that something outside of you makes you angry. If I drop a pen at my house, it falls onto the floor. If I do the same thing at your house or in Europe or anywhere on earth, it falls at the same speed because all objects on earth will always fall consistently according to the law of gravity. It's a matter of cause and effect.

If the activating event (in this case a bank fee) were the cause of our feelings, then all humans would experience the same effect—we would always get angry in the exact same way over a bank fee. But that doesn't happen! I don't have any billionaire friends to ask, but it's rather silly to imagine someone with a 10-figure bank balance flipping out over a $30 penalty! So it clearly is not the inconvenience that causes the Anger, but the way we choose to think about the inconvenience.

We only get angry when we insist that reality should be different than how it is, right now! In its extreme form, we call this psychosis—the denial or the non-acceptance of reality. When we are angry, we are all a little bit psychotic because we are saying that what exists should not exist just because we don't like it. You don't get any crazier than this!

Now that we understand how Should is so irrational, it's important to replace it with a concept that is rational. Should is a constricting concept, which means that it cannot be proven

and leads to misery. A freeing concept is something that can be proven and leads to a mind of peace, a mind that doesn't struggle. A more freeing concept than Should (a demanding philosophy) is a desiring philosophy, such as "it would be better…," "it would be preferable…," "I would have liked if so and so happened or didn't happen." This we can prove or disprove. This is what makes it a science—it has a way to be measured. It is evidence-based. It would be better (or more convenient) if you had not spent more money than you had, or if you had more money altogether, but that's not the case. We are so conditioned to think in terms of Should that at this point most people go, "Well if it's better for you, then you should do it!" There is no rational reason why you should do what is better for you; it would simply be more pleasant if you did. In fact, as humans we tend to be talented at not doing what is better for us and do it all the time! Should implies a moral obligation and demand that simply does not exist in nature.

Let's look at some examples:

- "She should not call so late at night." Well, she should have because she did, although it might have been better or more convenient for you if she didn't.
- "He must not cheat on me." Must is a demand word, and again, although it's much preferable for you if he did not to cheat on you, there is no law in the Universe that says he must not do what he wants to do or what he does.
- "I ripped my shirt and it shouldn't have ripped and now I'm really pissed!" How did your shirt piss you off? The shirt has no emotion nor any direct connec-

> tions to emotions (that's A-to-C thinking). When you look for the B, the belief that your shirt shouldn't rip because you don't want it to, you can replace that with, "It would have been a lot more convenient if my shirt didn't rip, but it did."

It is important to realize that we create and maintain our own thoughts and feelings, and we do this largely through our choice of inner dialogue. *Our thought* is what upsets us, not anything that anybody or anything did or said!

Now, at this point a lot of people would ask, "Are you saying it is okay for people to cheat?" No, and this is a very important concept. Acceptance does not mean endorsement! You do not have to approve of poor behavior in order to be happy, but you do want to accept that people are fallible and make mistakes often. Unpleasant things happen to everyone on a regular basis—you and I are no exception. I am not saying to endorse cheating or any other behavior we may define as bad, but usually when something like that happens, we insist that it should not have happened. This is irrational, because it already did happen. Insisting that it must not be the way it already is, is what causes the negative emotion. So if you want to feel better from the negative emotion, find a way to accept and embrace what did happen, even if it's something very unpleasant.

Stop Shoulding on Yourself

When you should on yourself, you get angry at yourself and you put yourself down. When you should on others, you get angry at them and put them down. You may be as correct as you want to be about how poor their behavior was, but not being able to control your Anger won't benefit you or them or the situa-

tion. Here at The Parr Institute we like to think of should as a four-letter word, because it is as useless and harmful as any profanity and leads you to being angry. Should is the number one irrational belief to always be red-flagging. There is no emotional disturbance without a Should, Must, or a Demand!

Let's talk about poor or bad behavior—which is only regarded as poor behavior because you define it as such. Someone else may define the same behavior as good. You may believe giving a dollar to a homeless person is a compassionate gesture. Your friend may argue that you're rewarding laziness or alcoholic addiction and encouraging others to do the same. So which is it—is giving to the poor bad or good? Neither! It is only the way you define it.

Now there are clear examples of people behaving in ways that are not in their best interest. You can learn to accept the reality of any behavior—whether you define it as good or bad—if you realize there are only three reasons people do things that harmful or unproductive:

1: Diminished Mental Capacity
2: Ignorance
3: Disturbance

1: Diminished Mental Capacity

Some people through no fault of their own simply do not have the intellectual capacity to understand how to do things that are in their own best interest. I used to visit a hospital ward for patients with exceptionally diminished mental capacity. Many of them lacked fine motor skills, bowel control or even speech. Objectively we don't generally consider flailing one's arms, relieving one's bowels in bed, or yelling incomprehen-

sibly to be 'good' behavior. It doesn't really benefit anyone. It would be inarguably in their best interest if they could brush their hair, take themselves to the bathroom, or express their thoughts clearly, but this is simply not possible given the conditions that exist.

Now the condition need not be so severe as this. Many of us would very likely fail to pass a test on quantum mechanics not because we were too lazy to study, but because our brain simply cannot comprehend that level of complexity. It may benefit us if we better understood physics, but this is simply not possible given the conditions that exist.

It does not do well to judge or berate someone for behavior that results from diminished mental capacity. It may or may not be possible for a person to increase their intellectual capacity in certain areas, but that is out of your control. The only truly appropriate emotional reaction on your part is compassion and acceptance of the situation as it is.

2: Ignorance

Sometimes we say or act in a certain way that inconveniences ourselves or others simply because we were not aware of all of the conditions. When we first start at a new job, we often fail at doing it well, not because we lack intelligence, but simply because we have not yet learned all of the conditions that allow for doing the job properly.

I met a woman who was distressed because she had made a mistake at her new job that cost her company money. She had sent a large number of postcards to the printer with some incorrect information resulting in extra printing costs and a delay while the corrected cards were reprinted. While it would have

been in her best interest—and that of the company—to have put the correct information on the cards in the first place, she was not aware of the 'quality check' policy. It was not a mistake of diminished mental capacity and it wasn't malicious—she was simply unaware that she hadn't followed procedure. She did not make that mistake again!

A freshman quarterback in college football is not expected to perform to the level of Joe Namath or Cam Newton. He will make many more mistakes, but he has the capacity to improve his performance over time with experience and skill.

When someone doesn't know how to do the thing that is in their or your best interest, the appropriate emotional reaction on our part is again compassion. Her manager could have gotten angry, charged her for the reprinting cost, or even fired her, but he understood she was new to the company and just learning the ropes. Is it really rational to expect a new person on the job to get everything correct?! It is possible for them to change with knowledge and experience, but that too is out of your control.

3: Disturbance

If someone is acting poorly and they are not stupid or ignorant, there is the only one other reason they might do something that is not in their best interest—disturbance! It has to be disturbed thinking on their part. We have already proven that a negative emotion is psychosis; when someone is feeling intense negative feelings, their physical brain and their thinking mind is not functioning properly. The appropriate emotional reaction from you to a person's poor behavior from disturbance is again compassion. You cannot change or alleviate someone else's

disturbed thinking. Their disturbance is entirely out of your control. The only disturbance you can control is your own.

Notice a pattern? The poor behavior of others is not something we can control, regardless of its source. The only rational response to all three is compassion. If you do not act out of compassion, caring, and patience, then you are acting disturbed! Hopefully others will treat us better and with compassion when we screw up, as we inevitably will.

Disputing Anger

There is only one rational Should: everything that happens today should happen! All others can be disputed. When you feel angry, first ask yourself, "Where is my Should, Must, or Demand? Second, Why should (or shouldn't) it be this way? Why shouldn't it be the way someone else likes? Why shouldn't it be exactly as it is?"

If you are actively red-flagging your Shoulds, it will be easy to see your Anger coming and begin to dispute it by asking yourself specific questions about your belief. When you say you shouldn't have to pay overdraft fees, ask yourself why you shouldn't. Is there a law in the universe that says banks can't charge overdraft fees? Other people pay the same penalty, so why should you be an exception? If you signed an agreement with your bank to pay overdraft fees if you spend more money than is in your account, then you are going to pay those fees regardless of how inconvenient it is for you. You were charged, so you should have been charged. You can try to bargain with the bank to forgive you this time. Your response—asking for an exception—is something you do have control over and maybe it will work. Good luck.

You can dispute by asking any question that challenges the belief, but if you get stuck, you can always go back to Ellis & Katie's four challenge questions:

1: Is it true? The conditions exist for it to be true: banks charge overdraft fees to all customers who overdraw their account. You overdrew your account, therefore it is true that you should have been charged the fee.

2: Is it 100% true? The universe has not singled you out for financial punishment because you neglected to check your balance before you bought gas. When penalties are given for certain conditions, those penalties apply to all instances of those conditions. Exceptions may be made (e.g., if the banker feels kindly toward you, or you have extenuating circumstances) but if those conditions are not met, the fee remains.

3: If I keep thinking this all day long how will I feel? Frustrated, wronged, and angry!

4: If I never let the thought enter my mind, how would I feel? Calm and undisturbed.

When you feel angry, find and observe the activating event, and then red-flag your SMDs. There will always be a Should, Must, or Demand! Finally, dispute the statement you red-flagged. This is using your conscious mind rather than your reactive mind.

Let's apply The 4 Steps to Disputing to the bank overdraft situation to see how this works.

STEP 1: OBSERVE

Ask yourself, "How am I feeling and reacting in this situation?"

What physiological sensations are you experiencing? What actions have arisen from it? Perhaps when you opened the statement your face got hot and your heart began to race. If you stomped into the bank, crumpled your bank statement and threw it at the teller, your level of anger may have reached a new level. This could accelerate even further if they don't comply to your demands and the next bank visit could include an AK47.

How Angry Are You?

STEP 2: SOS

Ask yourself, "What am I thinking about myself, others in this situation, or the situation in general, to make me upset?"

Look for the story in your head about what's going on. Identify irrational beliefs that make up the formula for Anger: Egocentric Thinking + Should, must and demand statements. You don't like the bank charge because it's inconvenient, so you shouldn't have been charged! The bank or teller should made an exception for you. Right!? Because, "I am entitled to better treatment—because I am special! Can't they see this! I am a Harvard graduate after all!"

STEP 3: IDENTIFY

Ask yourself, "What irrational thoughts am I believing? What are the rational, provable truths?"

Belief: You should not have been charged. Truth: You were charged; it's right there in black and white! The conditions

existed for it to happen—1) the bank put in place a monetary penalty for spending more money than you have in your account, and 2) you spent more than was in your account—therefore it should have happened.

Belief: The banker should have made an exception for you. Truth: She did not make an exception for you because the money is still missing from your account. The conditions existed for it to happen—1) the banker had the authority to make exceptions, 2) He or she didn't, 3) therefore the banker chose not to remove the charge—so it should have happened because of these conditions.

STEP 4: REPLACE

Ask yourself, "What realistic preferences can I substitute for my irrational thinking?"

Replace irrational, demanding statements with preference statements or desiring philosophies. "That idiot teller should have given me back my money!" can become, "It sure would have been nice if the bank cut me a break." Remember, it's impossible and insane to insist that the conditions be different than they are. Anger is psychosis. And besides, that teller may be a future Nobel Prize winner in physics and not really an idiot! It's okay to have preferences, but it is when our preferences become Shoulds, Musts and Demands and down ourselves and/or others that we get emotionally disturbed.

CHAPTER 6

THE FORMULA FOR ANXIETY

"We make stuff up about the future that doesn't exist and then we scare ourselves about what we just made up—very creative!"
VINCE PARR

"A great deal of talent is lost to the world for want of a little courage. Every day sends to their graves obscure men whose timidity prevented them from making a first effort."
SYDNEY SMITH

Anxiety can be as mild as being afraid to approach the beautiful woman across the bar or as severe as consistent panic attacks. Fear has a unique power to prevent one from fulfilling their potential. It can influence practically everything a person does. It can destroy a man or woman of genius and suppress any talents they might have.

Anxiety is always a future oriented emotion. We all have different fears, but the pattern of thinking behind Anxiety is the same for every single one of us. No matter what you are anxious about, all Anxiety follows this pattern:

AX = WI + AW + ICSI

Anx**iety** = **W**hat **I**f? + **A**wfulizing + **I C**an't **S**tand It!

WI: What If?

'What if' is projecting our mind into a future that doesn't exist and may never occur. The 'What If' component has to do with the story that you make up in your mind. "What if my car doesn't start or I get in an accident?" "What if my boyfriend dumps me?" "What if my boss fires me?" This part creates at most a concern, until you add the other two elements. 'What If' statements are not a bad thing when taken by themselves. They can serve as a safety net to keep us from taking unnecessary and harmful risks. It's just problem solving. You only get the feeling of Anxiety when you add the next two parts of the equation.

Aw: Awfulizing!

The Awfulizing happens when you take that event and alter it through your conception. "If my car doesn't start or I get in an accident, it would be truly horrible and awful," "It would be terrible if my boyfriend didn't love me anymore!" or, "If my boss fired me that would be catastrophic!" Every time you say that something is awful, you are taking something that is unpleasant or inconvenient to you and exaggerating the unpleasantness until it is so universally bad it simply shouldn't exist. Awful doesn't exist except in your mind—you created it by defining it as such.

ICSI: I Can't Stand It!

The final component, "I can't stand it," is the thought that is incorporated with the Awfulizing. Not only would it be terrible if any of the events above happened, but if they did, you wouldn't be able to stand it. You would fall apart if you lost your job, your boyfriend or girlfriend, or if you were in an accident. You know this isn't true because you've withstood every other

unpleasant thing that has happened up until this moment in time; you've lost other boyfriends or girlfriends, other jobs, and had accidents, but if you're reading this, you're still alive. This is immediately provable! Therefore, you have stood everything that has ever happened to you and you will until *memento mori*, the moment of death. And who knows? As Aristotle said: "This might be our finest moment!" The moment of final liberation and freedom."

Fear of the Future

Now that you know what you are feeling, how do you stop feeling that way? This process can be broken down into three simple steps: confronting the thought process that causes Anxiety, then confronting the situation you believe is causing your Anxiety, and finally, letting it go.

Confronting the Thought Processes

When dealing with Anxiety, you are always looking for the 'What If' statement; it's what sets you up for Anxiety and panic attacks. Let's say you're nervous about giving a presentation at work. If you're like the estimated 289 million other people who fear public speaking, you're probably focusing on what might go wrong. First, find and red-flag your 'What If' statements: "What if I completely forget what I was saying?" "What if no one laughs at my jokes?" "What if I choke on a sip of water?"

Observing your inner dialogue is the first step towards changing your thinking. Also take note of what your body is telling you. What are you sensing and feeling when you start to feel anxious? If you are aware of your physical sensations, you can feel the Anxiety coming on even if you haven't found the 'What

If' statement yet. This will trigger you to start looking at your thoughts and disputing them.

The ultimate 'What If' driving your thinking is 'What if they don't approve of me?' In your thinking, it's bad enough if one person doesn't approve of you, but 100+ people all at once would be truly catastrophic and you couldn't stand it. So there you have Rating, Shoulding, What If, Awfulizing, and ICSI—all in one sentence!

When confronting the process of Awfulizing and ICSI, why is it important to accept that you can stand anything, no matter how unpleasant it is until the moment of death? For several reasons:

You will often experience unpleasant happenings. If you want to preserve your safety and peace of mind, you would do better to realistically define them as adversities and try to reduce or eliminate them. Poverty, violence, rape, disease, imprisonment and torture are all extremely unpleasant adversities that are best avoided. You can dislike these events, plan to ward them off and stop contributing to anything that could create them but you can't control them. Resorting to Awfulizing and ICSI thinking accomplishes nothing other than agitating yourself, your friends and your family. When you say, "I can't bear this adversity!" you're implying you can't even tolerate contemplating it let alone create a plan to diminish it. How can you deal with or change it if you cannot even bear to acknowledge it? It only takes one exception to your firmly-held belief for it to fall apart. Nelson Mandela spent 20 years of his life in prison and not only did he stand it, but he even changed the prison guards around him who witnessed his calm state of mind. There are many people throughout history who have withstood much worse than

we will probably ever experience. So, you probably 'can stand' traffic or even someone's rejection.

ICSI thinking tends to make you think crookedly and act disruptively about people and events that you find obnoxious. If you think you can't stand critical people, you will most likely make yourself angry at them, exaggerate their 'wrongs,' block yourself from being assertive, and overdo your complaints against them. Where will any of these behaviors get you? Nowhere useful or constructive! Much less to a place of feeling compassion for them.

I had a patient once who was terrified of elevators—just seeing the doors open was enough to send him into a panic. He couldn't even contemplate getting on an elevator and this fear was impacting his ability to travel, go to job interviews, shop or visit any friend in a high-rise building. Have you ever tried climbing 10 flights of stairs in a business suit, or with a load of groceries? By the time he came to me he was desperate to make a change.

In my patient's case, as with most cases, it is a good idea to change anxious thought patterns through The 4 Steps to Disputing irrational thinking:

STEP 1: OBSERVE

Ask yourself, "How am I feeling and acting in this situation?"

My patient knew what he was feeling because he was having panic attacks doing something that most everyone else seemed to do without a problem.

STEP 2: SOS

Ask yourself, "What am I thinking about myself, the others in this situation, or the situation in general, that makes me upset?"

That patient was thinking that the elevator might fall or that he might get stuck on it, and if it did, that would be awful, and he couldn't stand it.

STEP 3: IDENTIFY

Ask yourself, "What irrational thoughts am I holding? What are my red-flag statements?"

When my patient compared his irrational beliefs to rational truth, he saw that elevator failures are extremely rare, laws governing elevator inspections are quite stringent, and there are a great number of safety measures and backups in place.

The only rational conclusion was that the probability of his elevator falling at the exact moment he was in it was very small indeed. It is much more likely he would be involved in a car crash on his way to visit his friend in the high rise, but he wasn't. Therefore, if his Anxiety were based on reality he would have been petrified to crank the engine in his car.

STEP 4: REPLACE

Ask yourself, "What realistic preferences can I substitute for my irrational thinking?"

Of course he—like most everyone else—would prefer that the elevator didn't crash. And the statistics are on his side—any elevator will most likely be fine every time he rides in it. The realistic chances of his dying in an elevator, for the rest of his life, are practically zero!

After about 10 to 12 months of weekly practice, combining rational thinking with *in vivo* (in life) desensitization exercises that involved going to many elevators in the Tampa Bay area, my patient can now ride an elevator to the top of the tallest building in New York without panic!

Confronting Your 'What If?'

You're almost done being anxious, but there is one more step to controlling your Anxiety. In order to conquer Anxiety, it is necessary to take risks. When you have completed the first part, confronting your thought processes, you have the tools and are ready to approach the very thing you are afraid of, to confront your 'What If.' You need to use your rational thinking skills and do whatever it is you're afraid of, whether it's speaking publicly, approaching an attractive person, flying on planes, getting in elevators, etc. It is important to face the very thing that you are afraid of. If not, your fears will follow you always.

I had another client who was afraid of many things, one of the larger being open spaces. After several sessions in the office, I told him it was time to confront his fears and we went to an open field. We parked near the center of the field and started walking distances from his car. We would get a little way from his car and he would crouch down, throw his arms out, and turn to make a beeline back to his automobile. He apologized and said that it felt like he was going to fly off the earth. I said, "Great, do it and we'll both be rich!" I told him not to apologize, but to keep trying. So we continued to progress one or two steps further from his car each time, and after two months he was able to walk all around the field without any trouble.

Confronting your 'WI' may not be this dramatic or this obvious. For example, if you're afraid of public speaking, it might be as simple as giving a toast at the next big dinner you attend. Or if you fear rejection, it might be forcing yourself to approach people in social settings. Whether your 'WI' is physical or mental, large or seemingly small, it will take more than one successful confrontation for you to fully overcome it.

When Panic Attacks

If you've ever experienced a panic attack, you know the feeling can be terrifying and confusing. Rationally you may know there's nothing dangerous or scary threatening you, but you nevertheless feel very intense fear and may suffer severe physical reactions. You're not alone. Many people will suffer at least one panic attack in their lifetime.

I once had a patient, a very intelligent doctor, tell me of a dissociative episode she'd suffered while shopping in a crowded mall. She was suddenly terrified of her surroundings and exhibited all the sensations we associate with panic—short, constricted breaths, a racing heart, dizziness, and sweating. She was absolutely certain she was going to die right there outside the food court.

If you are feeling a panic attack, do not try to dispute your thinking right away. Panic is by nature irrational and you will most likely make it worse by trying to battle it head-on. Don't fight the physical sensations. Allow them happen while you turn your attention to your breathing. It is critically important that you practice the Centering Breath, a breathing technique to help you release negative emotions and physiological sensations. Forcing yourself to breathe deeply will 'hack' your body into

feeling better. You may find it difficult to breathe deeply at first because your chest is tight and your muscles are constricted, but the deeper you breathe, the more your body will relax. Once you are a little calmer, you can move on to disputing.

Here's how to do it:

1: Take a gentle breath in. Be aware of your inner dialogue and any tension in your body.

2: Pause briefly at the top of your breath.

3: Breathe out slowly while thinking, "Let go." You let go of two things; your inner dialogue and the physical tensions that you are feeling.

There is no magic number to count your breaths or time your practice, but the deeper you expand your lungs, the more you will relax, and the longer you do the exercise, the calmer and more centered you will feel. '*Let go*' becomes your mantra, a phrase you can repeat to yourself as a cue to pause, breathe, and become still. The more often you turn to your breathing and awareness, the more instinctual the practice will become. When I give this to patients as a learning experiment, I tell them you can literally say, every 15 seconds for the rest of your life, "Let go."

With Anxiety, if you can use the Centering Breath to successfully dispute and let go of the 'What If' scenario that you are making up in your head, you won't actually need to dispute the Awfulizing or ICSI. You can simply be aware of the irrational beliefs as you let go.

Another one of the main benefits of the Centering Breath is that while you are observing each breath you can't stay attached

to the Narrator's reactive thinking. This is multi-tasking in the mind, and the mind cannot do this. You can multi-*shift*—switch back and forth between tasks so quickly it may seem as though they are simultaneous—but you cannot be fully and totally absorbed in more than one thing at a time. When you try to multi-task or multi-shift, you're performing none of them as well as you could if you were performing just one with exclusive, complete awareness. The more you can bring attention your breathing, releasing the dialogue and tension, the more the mind and body come to the single point of awareness of the moment. You shift away from the Narrator and remove yourself from that fight-or-flight state. A mind at peace doesn't struggle; a mind of stillness cannot be disturbed.

Mistake Making

Things to remember about mistake making:

1: If you are human, you will make mistakes.
2: Mistakes are opportunities to learn.
3: There is no shame in making mistakes.
4: There is no such thing as a mistake!

If we define a mistake as an unintended or undesirable outcome directly resulting from our behavior, then we humans are exceptionally talented at making mistakes. Most of us would agree that we don't like mistakes and it would 'be best' not to make them. Yet if we look at the human condition, we know that we are all FHBs—Fallible Human Beings. We are imperfect; therefore logic and practical experience tells us we will make mistakes. Imperfect beings *will* perform inadequate actions that lead to unintended outcomes! There is no escaping that fact. No matter how hard you or I try, there is no way to live a

mistake-free life. That's just the way it is, and it would be better to accept this fact or you'll find yourself in a never-ending cycle of Awfulizing and rating.

Mistakes, while often inconvenient to us, are not necessarily a pointless waste of time and energy. There are benefits to seeing (and admitting) when we've fallen short. When you make a mistake you have an opportunity to learn, and if you've learned something, even the worst mistake was not without some benefit. The very fact that you made that mistake tends to make you more alert to what you are doing, and when you really focus, you generally learn more quickly. Conversely, if you are unwilling to admit to making a mistake, you are likely to repeat the behavior that caused it and keep getting the same undesired result! So treat your mistakes as an opportunity for discovery and improvement rather than a failure for you to fear or feel shame about. Stop putting yourself down for making mistakes—you can't *be* any better than you are at any given moment! Conditions, remember? Instead, when faced with an undesirable outcome, ask yourself how you might *do* better next time.

Regardless of whether we see, admit or learn from our mistakes, we tend to be quick to notice and rate the mistakes of those around us. We may perceive that people close to us seem to make more mistakes than others. This is not necessarily because they do, but simply because we see them more often and are more involved in their behavior. In the same way, we will seem to make more mistakes than they do. That's probably not true. We are just more focused on ourselves—our own behavior and outcomes—than others and so our mistake making is more apparent to us. We are not only the star of our own little mistake-ridden show, we are the producer, director, choreog-

rapher, and critic! And where is this story taking place? Well, not on Broadway!

Now that you better understand mistakes, let me let you in on a little secret—*there are no mistakes!* Mistakes are a product of conception, a subjective judgement of reality as you conceive it to be, not as it is. "My car broke down because I screwed up. I should have put oil in it yesterday."

One of my favorite Zen proverbs states, "Everything comes exactly as it does." And so, if all the conditions are there for the event to have occurred, as it did, how could it be a mistake? It happened exactly as it should have happened! Now you can relax, because this means that ultimately you are a mistake-free person. Your behavior may leave room for improvement, but *you* are exactly as you should be—at every moment. Now that's freedom! Dainin Katagiri, a wise Zen teacher, used to say: "You are all perfect as you are and can use improvement."

You can dispute by asking any question that challenges the belief that you hold, but if you get stuck, you can always go back to Ellis & Katie's four challenge questions:

1: Is it true?
2: Is it 100% true?
3: If I keep thinking this all day long how will I feel?
4: If I never let the thought enter my mind,
how would I feel?

Is it really important what others think of us?

Yes, sometimes it is important what *some* other people think of you. For instance, it is certainly important that our spouse or lover thinks well of us, for if they didn't it would not be very

nice for us to be with them. If they thought poorly of us, they might not treat us very well which wouldn't be very beneficial to us. It is also important for our boss to think well of us, or at least to think well of the work we do. Otherwise we would probably not make much progress in the company, a situation that we would not like. Doing a job well often leads to opportunities and a beneficial path within a company or mate we may like, but forget about your *reputation*, which is just another way of rating yourself. This is the opinion of others and you have no control of this. If you work to solve problems and are kind to others, most people will like you. So concentrate on that, not on yourself. Love people and use things. Let go of all self-rating and other-rating and you will at least be happy in this lifetime.

We had best do what we can to maintain a healthy, considerate relationship with people we identify as important in our lives. This will often lead to them thinking well of us. I had a client who would get so angry at her husband she would put bug parts in his meal just to get back at him. It brought her a great deal of glee to watch him happily slurping down her special chicken cockroach soup (recipe not included). So best at least try to be on your spouse's good side!

The rest of the people in the world are another matter. Why must we spend any time at all worrying whether or not the people in the club think our dancing is good? Even if they thought we were awful at dancing, their opinion—which we don't really know and can't prove even exists—would never have serious repercussions in our lives. While we certainly would like everyone in the world to approve of us and our behavior all the time, that will likely never happen. Worrying about the other dancers' approval might prevent you from getting out on the dance

floor with your wife who enjoys dancing and whose approval is more important to you. And look at all the fun you'd be missing by thinking you 'must' have everyone's approval. Who decides what's good dancing and bad dancing anyway? Are you a contestant on Dancing With the Stars? Some people dance like they're being electrocuted and yet they're having a blast. Ellen DeGeneres and Seinfeld's Elaine Benes are known for terrible dancing and yet we love them! Isn't this what is really important? That we enjoy ourselves! Can we control what others think? And, is that really important in your life, all the time?

Limiting our experiences and constricting our personalities because we are worried about what others may think is the opposite of living free. The irony is the fear of caring what other people think will not help your reputation or relationships; confidence inspires trust and ease, while neediness often leads to others around us feeling burdened. While others are having fun and experiencing life to the fullest, we sit constricted by our fears of disapproval. Nothing is more effective for our reputations than having positive emotions and a rational mind. Let go of the concepts of ego, pride, self-esteem, self-worth and respect, and you will have a ball. Albert Ellis use to say the goal of life is: "To have a goddamn ball!" (Of course, I give Ellis credit for this because I don't want you to think poorly of me for using 'bad' language—that would be fucking terrible!).

Freeing Concepts to Practice

You can train yourself to have a more healthy approach to the approval of others. You can say to yourself, "I will move through my life experiencing as much of life that I can. I will try to never do anything that is harmful to myself or others. I will be aware

of how people close to me feel about my behavior and I'll try to be kind to them and with them at all times. But I will not limit myself because of my fear of disapproval for an act that I see as harmless to myself and others. I will be genuine and congruent with my thoughts, feelings, and behavior and not worry so much about the world's approval or disapproval of me. By doing so, I will be able to accept myself as I am and experience life more fully."

You can strive to reach the point where you can say of yourself, as the Dalai Lama did when pointing to his mouth: "These lips have never told a lie."

Worry

A lot of people use the words 'Anxiety' and 'worry' interchangeably. Although the two are similar and often travel together, they are not the same.

Anxiety is the name of the negative emotion—a feeling or belief identified by Awfulizing and ICSI statements. Let's say you're dreading hosting a dinner party for your in-laws. Anxiety is the *feeling* caused by Awfulizing—"Screwing this up would be the worst thing I have ever done!" and ICSI—"I couldn't stand it if they hate my food!" You might even find you are rating yourself or others—"I'm not as good a cook as my mother-in-law."

Worry, on the other hand, is a *behavior* you do when you feel Anxiety—it is a cycle of repetitive thinking in which you are actively feeding and entertaining those irrational beliefs. Worry is a covert behavior—no one knows you're doing it but you—and rarely has any benefit. Some of the more obvious characteristics of worry that often differ from the process of Anxiety are:

- Preoccupation with and dwelling on the future event. "I can't stop thinking about how my mother-in-law will berate me if this dinner isn't perfect."
- Over-inclusiveness; seeing one event as innately connected to virtually all other phases of life. "If I bomb this dinner party my family will never respect me."
- Predicting that if a certain event takes place you will be an emotional prisoner and will no longer be in control of your own destiny. "If my family doesn't respect me, my marriage will fail and I'll be alone!"
- Falsely perceiving worry as a positive trait to be deliberately cultivated. "What kind of host would I be if I didn't worry about my guests being happy and satisfied with my cooking?"
- Assuming personal responsibility; fearing being labeled inadequate or being blamed for the outcome of an event. "If I burn the turkey everyone will think I can't cook a simple meal and they'll be pissed at me for ruining their evening."
- Focusing on and attending to only the negative elements of change. "I hate having family over; it's too much pressure and I don't enjoy anyone's company."

Don't confuse 'worry' with 'concern,' the concept of caring about a matter that affects your welfare. Concern can be wise and efficient but worry almost never is!. We can be concerned about the quality of our child's education but worrying about every bit of information they receive or harassing the teachers and the school about the 'wrong' curriculum is counterpro-

ductive. You'll spend so much time and energy spinning your wheels over whether Junior hears a swear word that you won't be present to help him make sense of what he hears. No one is born a worrier; it is a learned trait and habit that can be unlearned. Do not worry about worry. You can do something right now to help you break the worry habit.

What You Can Do About Worry

The following program has been designed to minimize worry, but will only work if you follow it all the way through. Admittedly, it is a time-consuming process (perhaps an hour or so the first few times it is followed), but it will become easier and more natural each time and the habit of worry will weaken. You are encouraged to not just think about it—do it!

1: List as specifically as possible the predictions you are making and the negative consequences of each.

Example 1: If the company folds (prediction), I'll be out of work (consequences).

Example 2: If my wife runs off with my best friend (prediction) my life will be ruined (consequence).

2: Place a specific time frame around each prediction. When would it begin? How much time must pass? What conditions cause it to end?

Example 1: If the company folds in one month, then I will have to go job hunting in one month.

Example 2: If my wife leaves me next week, I'll have to sell the house before the end of the year.

3: List in detail the important characteristics of yourself and your life that will not change if the event takes place. It is important to recognize the essential stability of personality: even a highly-important event will not transform your entire life.

Example 1: If I lose my job, I can still be intelligent and caring, my kids will be bright and healthy.

Example 2: If my wife leaves me, I can still be good at taking care of myself.

4: List possible positive changes that might occur if the event takes place. Pay particular attention to negative elements in your current situation and elements you've wanted to change even when things were going well.

Example 1: If I lose my job, I may have to budget expenses, but I will have time to start my novel.

Example 2: If I find myself alone, I can be more independent, simplify my life and look forward to meeting new people.

5: List the feelings you anticipate having. Analyze each individually as if it had already occurred and dispute the irrational or untrue elements in each.

Example 1: If I lose my job, I'll have to go job hunting. It will make me feel anxious because interviews are the worst! I shouldn't have to 'sell' my skills—I deserve a good job!

Disputing Example 1: Interviews are the way employers find out if I'm the best fit. Although I'd prefer to be

hired from my resumé, someone else may be just as qualified. I don't like it, but it won't kill me!

Example 2: If my wife divorces me I will be alone forever and it will be the end of me. I won't survive.

Disputing Example 2: This is going to suck but I won't die. I will not only learn from this, but I can choose to grow, learn, and move forward and meet others!

6: Actively imagine, for a period of about three minutes, being in the situation you're anxious about. Picture yourself in detail feeling calm and relaxed. Force this image until it comes clearly and easily.

Example 1: Imagine yourself, confident and prepared, walking into the building, asking for the personnel director, and talking with him or her in a calm and relaxed manner.

Example 2: Imagine yourself sitting down with your wife for a rational, compassionate conversation, resolving to cooperate and even perhaps remain friendly.

7: Start planning and acting in preparation, even before the event happens. Having a contingency plan or plans is proven to be a productive way to reduce the stress associated with worry.

Example 1: You could look for another job before the company folds, brush up on your resume, or learn an enjoyable new activity.

Example 2: You can propose and follow through with marital counseling, schedule date nights, and strive

to better appreciate and listen more often to your wife's point of view.

8: List actual or potential sources of comfort and support and how you might best make use of them. Be aware there are two kinds of support seeking; short-range escape and long-range assistance. Long-range assistance will provide lasting benefits far beyond the end of your feared crisis; cultivating meaningful relationships and taking good physical care of yourself, for example. Eating, drinking, and being merry is a great short-range escape, but tends to result in hangovers, weight gain, and further training in worry!

Example 1: My spouse can help me budget, my friend might throw me some freelance work.

Example 2: There are many divorce support groups online and in the community. I have friends who have been through this who will listen and help.

Example 3: I can look for a Mindfulness Based Rational Therapist to help me during this difficult time.

Use this emotional retraining exercise as many times as necessary for each predicted negative feeling. While this technique may seem odd or even difficult, if you practice each step diligently it will pay off!

CHAPTER 7

THE FORMULA FOR DEPRESSION

"When you realize there is nothing extra and nothing lacking, the whole world belongs to you."
LAO-TZU

"There is always an underlying 'Need' in Depression."
VINCE PARR

Depression is probably the most painful negative emotion that human beings experience. There are three major concepts or thought processes that lie behind Depression: Hopelessness, Helplessness, and Need. These three factors can fit into a mathematical equation for Depression as follows:

D = H1 + H2 + N

Depression = **H**opelessness + **H**elplessness + **N**eed

H1: Hopelessness

Hopelessness means that you have decided that your situation is beyond help; that is, that your current position in life is so bad that it will never get any better. There are three components to H1, Hopelessness:

1: A pessimistic or negative outlook toward the past.
When you give up on the past, you are thinking that since bad things happened in the past, you are doomed to more

bad things for the rest of your life. You think that the negative choices or events that occurred in your past are the cause of your current Depression and since you can't change those, you can't stop being depressed.

Example: My mother died and I'll never have her back. I am depressed that she is gone, and I cannot do anything to change that. She died! So I'll have to keep being depressed. Or, I am depressed because I am unattractive. My parents were unattractive; exercise and diet never worked for them, and since I am genetically predisposed to be fat and not stick to decisions to improve diet and exercise, I will never be attractive so I will always be depressed about it.

2: A pessimistic or negative outlook toward the present. When you give up on the present, you believe that your situation is unchangeable, no matter what you do today.

Example: In the situation where someone loses their mother, they think, I am sad today and nothing I will do today will ever make me happy, so I'll just keep being sad. Or for the unattractive individual in the previous example, they tell themselves, eating healthy and going to the gym today isn't going to change anything, so I'll just give up and sit on the couch, watch TV, and eat bonbons instead.

3: A pessimistic or negative outlook toward the future. Since you can't change the past, and you won't change the present, the future is also bleak and gloomy.

Example: I was fat, I am fat, so I will always be fat. Or, I miss my mother so much and without her I

will never be happy, therefore I am doomed to a life of unhappiness.

H2: Helplessness

Similarly, there are three components to H2, Helplessness:

1: Self-Pity
When you experience self-pity, you feel bad for yourself and you throw yourself a pity party and invite all your worse friends. There is nothing wrong with grieving when something happens that you perceive as bad; I am not going to tell you that you won't feel sad when you lose a loved one. It's when you take it to the next level, telling yourself things like, "*Nothing* ever works out the way I want it to," or "life is *always* unfair to me," and that life is useless and worthless." You tell yourself that you are helpless. So, poor you, everything *is* always bad!

2: Other Pity
When you pity the plight of others, you feel bad about things that are outside of your control. For example, you look at the animals on the extinction list and feel bad for them and their destroyed environments. You think things like, "The world is always a bad place, the environment is getting worse all the time, and everything is bad and going to hell in a handbasket!" You tell yourself that the world is an awful place and you are helpless to change it, and you get depressed about your impotence to do anything about it.

3: Self-Rejection
This is the final component of helplessness, the rejection of yourself, or putting yourself down. When you reject

> yourself, you say things like, "I didn't get the promotion that I thought I would, so I am an awful failure. I am helpless to be any better than I am, so I am doomed to fail at everything forever. I am worthless."

N: Need

The N in the Depression formula stands for, 'Need.' The Need or Necessity is more complex than the other two components of Depression, but it's simple to identify once you understand it. I put the word 'Need' into quotation marks because it is a pseudo-need, i.e., a false Need. There are only five things we need as humans to remain alive: food, water, shelter, air, and the elimination of waste. Everything outside of these five 'contingent needs' for life is a want. If I decide I want to die, then I do not even need to have the five contingent needs for life! There are really zero 'Needs!' Whatever it is you feel you lack that is at the root of your Depression is not a true need, it is a want.

Often we believe that 'Need' is love. While love from others is desirable and enjoyable, it is not necessary for you to continue to exist or for you to exist and be happy if you don't have it. That magical jump from "It is pleasurable" to "I need it, I must have it, and I will fail without it," is where true disturbance lies. I these all lead to feelings of Depression. For the person who lost their mother, they believe that they need their mother so much that they cannot live happily without her. Or for the overweight and unattractive person, they believe that if they aren't skinny and beautiful they can never make friends or find a mate or live a happy and fulfilling life. As we said earlier, Depression is often linked to the 'Need' for love and acceptance from others.

What Causes Depression?

Depression, like the other blocks to human happiness, is a choice to think and believe in certain ways. There is always the other side of the coin, non-Depression, or acceptance and contentment with the way things are, not as we wish they were. It may take more effort for you to choose non-Depression, but it is well worth the effort in the long run.

Depression is unique because, unlike the other four blocks, hopelessness, helplessness, and need don't necessarily occur in order. Rather, they all occur simultaneously and are linked to one another. Although you may want to look for your need first, you also want to be aware that all three are occurring at once.

Even in Depression you can change your thought processes through red-flagging and disputing. What can you red-flag for Depression? First, look for the 'Need.' Once you've identified your Need, your need for love and approval for example, it is easier to see where the hopelessness and helplessness come in. Why is understanding the 'Need' component so important? If you pushed on an eight-story building, you would be in a hopeless and helpless situation. Are you depressed? No? Well, why not? Because you don't have any real need for the building to move over a couple of feet. In order for Depression to occur there has to be an underlying need for things to be different, such as a need to get out of a marriage, a need to have children, a need to finish school, a need to have more money, or the need to date a total hottie.

Everything outside the five true or contingent needs is simply a preference or a desire. It's okay to have desires and preferences, but when we cling to and *demand* them, we get emotionally

upset and disturbed. This is how we trick ourselves into having Depression. We convince ourselves that we must have our desires met in order to be happy, and then we follow that up with how impossible it is, that it's hopeless and we are helpless, and *voila*! We feel terrible and depressed.

Once you have identified your 'Need,' it is necessary to dispute the Hopelessness and Helplessness that most often follows it. Instead of falling into your negative feedback loop of depressed thoughts and habits (your reactive mind), stop and ask yourself what you think you need and must have right now in order to be happy? Are you really a hopeless person? Is this true or is it just another way of saying "I give up?" I had a patient who felt her marriage was hopeless, that it was beyond repair and certainly doomed, she had to ask herself, *Is this marriage truly hopeless? Or am I just looking for a way to give up and get out?*

If you feel deeply distressed or Depressed, ask yourself why you feel helpless to do anything about it. Why should the woman who believed she was in a bad marriage think she is powerless to change the situation? Is it true? She could choose either of two paths: she could accept that her husband had moved on with his life and choose to do the same , or she could do everything she could to save her marriage—pursue couples counseling, start working out and taking classes, and otherwise take better care of herself. And if he still wasn't interested, she would be in a much better position to pursue life single! She wasn't really helpless; she had many options she could pursue. When you are in the throes of Depression it is just hard to see the many options you actually have.

Another way to approach the red-flagging and disputing is to refer back to the 4 Steps of Disputing. For the woman in a bad

marriage, the steps to disputing her Depression would go something like this:

STEP 1: OBSERVE

Ask yourself, "How am I feeling and acting in this situation?"

Here my patient would look for excessive Anxiety, Anger, Depression, Guilt, upset-ness, hurt, defensiveness, frustration, jealousy, threat, intimidation, withdrawal, procrastination, avoidance, hostility, etc. For her, she would say that she is feeling frustrated by her lack of control over her disintegrating marriage and feeling depressed about it, hostile towards her husband, etc. When you look for these unhealthy and inappropriate reactions, you are red-flagging them.

STEP 2: THINK SOS

Ask yourself, "What am I thinking about myself, others in this situation, or the situation in general, to make myself upset?"

For my patient, she would say that she is thinking that she must be able to control her marriage, that people will think badly about her if she gets divorced, that her husband should still love her the same way he did when they first got married 17 years ago! That she should be more attractive and smarter, and so on. (Insight alert: "We do not love our mates the same way from moment to moment. All things are impermanent and constantly flowing and changing like the spring or river. No two seconds are ever alike—anywhere in the Universe!).

STEP 3: IDENTIFY

Ask yourself, "What irrational thoughts am I believing?

What is the reality, what is actually true?" For the woman in this example, she could tell herself "My husband is unhappy and wants a divorce." This is a true statement that does not over-dramatize what is happening. When you accept the true aspects of a situation, it can help you to recognize what you are exaggerating or Awfulizing about, how you are doing that, and how to dispute it and get through it.

STEP 4: REPLACE

"What realistic preferences can I substitute for my irrational thinking?"

The woman about to get a divorce could say "I find it very unpleasant to get a divorce," or "I'd like our marriage to be happier and to last." All of these are better than a Should, Must or Demand statement.

Often individuals in a situation like an unhappy marriage will give many reasons why they cannot do anything to change the relationship, thus rationalizing their unhappiness. In the case of a bad marriage, they will say things like "I am staying for the children" or "...for the family" or "...because I don't have any work skills" or "What will others think?" They will know I have failed and that would be even 'more' awful, and I couldn't stand that!

This is just one example of how we convince ourselves to stay in an unpleasant situation, not that the situation is hopeless or that we are helpless to do anything about it. One of the reasons we do not change our belief is that even though we are miserable in our situation we are also familiar with it. I call this *comfortable misery*. Change involves doing something different and often outside our comfort zone, and we fear they may experience more Anxiety and discomfort than in the present situation.

So many people would rather choose unhappiness over uncertainty! And this brings us to the four needs and fears behind all Anger, Anxiety, Depression, and Guilt.

The Four 'Needs' & The Four Fears

Every 'Need' is attached to a fear. If we believe we 'need' something in order to be happy, we fear not getting it and that not having the need met will be Intolerable, Awful, and they Couldn't Stand It!

NEED = FEAR

The four pseudo needs are:

1: The 'Need' for love and approval from others = the fear of Rejection.
2: The 'Need' for success = the fear of Failure.
3: The 'Need' for comfort = the fear of pain and discomfort.
4: The 'Need' for certainty = the fear of uncertainty, ambivalence, and death.

These fears have a certain irony to them, because often having the fear will cause you to behave in such a way that the fear materializes in the mind and body through physiological processes and behavior that becomes a self-fulfilling prophesy. When you're afraid of rejection, you don't act confident, and you get rejected. When you fear failure, you are paralyzed when it is time to perform or take a risk. When you fear pain and discomfort, it is practically impossible to escape addiction or unhealthy habits. When you fear uncertainty, you will stay in the same comfortable misery for as long as you have the fear. And this may be forever.

When confronting your fear, try tapping into what Zen calls 'The Mind of Totality.' This simply requires you to zoom out from your narrow, stressed out perspective and look at the big picture. Consider the size of your city or town with the hundreds or thousands of people in it. Widen your view to include your state or province with the millions of people, then your country and the world, with all the millions and billions of other people in it. All of them flawed, all of them temporary. Think of the vastness of the solar system, the galaxy, the universe. Zoom out until you can contemplate the whole of this massive experience, we call life. Realize it is all just a passing show; the pain isn't forever, the pleasure isn't forever. Your ego has never even existed. The mind of totality is your antidote for fear. If this feels like a complex concept, it is. But have no fear—we'll discuss this in greater detail later.

> *"The less I needed, the better I felt."*
> CHARLES BUKOWSKI

Practical Tips for Change

Changing your thought patterns takes time and practice, but there are a number of practical tips for creating an environment conducive to your work on the mental part:

- Do NOT hibernate (stay at home, in your room, in your bed, etc.).
- Do NOT drink or do so very sparingly. (I'm referring to alcohol here, because alcohol is a depressant. The last thing you need when you're already depressed is to put a chemical in your body that will often lead to more depressed thinking).

- Do NOT watch sad movies or listen to melancholic music (this will only reinforce your already negative mindset).
- DO PYA (Push Your Ass—Albert Ellis again here) to leave the house at least once a day.
- DO talk to and spend time with people who are positive and who you enjoy being around.
- DO get some sunlight and take a walk in nature.
- DO eat healthier. Have some fruits and vegetables and drink 6 to 8 glasses of water every day (see our food and supplement brochure).
- DO some physical exercise (if you are physically able), exercise is incredibly beneficial for
- managing Depression. Almost everyone can do a form of Tai Chi, even if in a wheel chair.
- DO watch and practice meditation at least once a day.
- DO get 8 hours of sleep every night.
- DO practice the Centering Breath when you feel upset

And finally, love with reckless abandon!

A Medication Nation

"Zoloft, Wellbutrin, Xanax, and Prozac…these are a few of my favorite things!" (No, they really are not! My apologies to Julie Andrews!)

It is considered nearly blasphemy to question the necessity of prescription medications for treatment of Depression in our society today. But the truth is the myriad of medications prescribed to people suffering from Depression are largely unnecessary, ineffective, and accompanied by undesirable side effects.

Medication will at best provide only temporary relief, if any at all. Pharmaceutical treatment is dependent on finding the right prescription, the correct dosage, little or no side effects, and avoiding psychological addiction.

Experienced mental health professionals will tell you therapy is a critical component of long-term improvement of mental health. Yet many patients who seek treatment never attempt to examine and adjust their thinking before jumping to the 'instant solution' of prescription medication. And there are plenty of M.D.s who are quick to accommodate this dependency!

You may say, "But I feel better!" That may be, but medication is not an effective or permanent solution because it does not address the primary cause of your Depression; your irrational belief system, your non-acceptance of reality as it is. So anti-depressants, anti-psychotics, and anti-anxiety medications are, in essence, anti-reality! Which of these pills can stop or change your thoughts? None of them! Well if it is our inner dialogue that is the main cause of our Depression, and these pills can't change *that*, then why are you taking them? *Medication can never change your thinking!* It cannot shift your conception from Narrator (reactive and irrational) to Observer (active and rational). It can't change your inner dialogue or red-flag irrational beliefs. No matter how comforting the short-term effects, medication will never provide an exit from the Negative Feedback Superhighway! That is up to you.

I'm not saying you should quit your medications cold turkey! In many cases a sudden change can be damaging to your health and make healing even more difficult. Just realize its limitations and understand that if you want to get to the root of your emotional distress, you would do better to adjust your thinking.

There are no negative side effects or addictions to awareness, to observing, disputing, and releasing irrational beliefs. The only side effect of rational thinking is peace and contentment. You *just get better!* You will find it takes more time, but you didn't get here over night (60,000+ sentences a day, remember?). Be patient with yourself and be consistent. You can and will change with patience, persistence, and practice. Daily meditation can help things along by creating a calm environment for change. You will succeed—this is a fact you can prove!

On a lighter note, here is an ode to Big Pharma I think is brilliant. Written by an associate of mine, Melissa Gridley:

A Prayer to Big Pharma

"Our Effexor, who art at bedside,
venlafaxine be thy name.

Thy calmness come, thy pill begun
to work as it does with Haldol.

Give us Navane to clear our head
and help us forget as we consume Strattera.

Leave us not with buproprion
but deliver us from Paxil,
for thine is the Klonopin
and the Prozac
and Restoril
for ever and ever,

Zyban."

MELISSA GRIDLEY

CHAPTER 8

THE FORMULA FOR GUILT

"Guilt is the rejection of the Self."
VINCE PARR

Depression and Anxiety get a lot of PR, but not a lot of people realize how serious Guilt is. I call Guilt the bottom line of the four blocks because it takes rejection to a whole new level with the rejection of the 'Self.' In fact, you can feel guilty about having Depression, you can feel Guilty about having Anxiety, you can feel Guilty about having Anger problems, and you can even feel Guilty about feeling Guilty! Again, we are so clever in the ways we disturb ourselves.

Even though we all feel guilty about different things, we all create Guilt in the exact same way:

G = W1 + W2

Guilt = **W**rongness + **W**orthlessness

W1: Wrongness

Wrongness is the idea that you have done something wrong, that some action you have taken, or some thought that has passed through your mind was wrong and bad and you should feel Guilty about it. There is a Should component in Wrongness too of course (always look for the Should). For example, you

might feel Guilty about looking at other women if you are married, and you think, "I am a married man, I shouldn't be attracted to anyone but my wife!" Or you feel Guilty about being late to work, and you tell yourself, "I should be on time all the time! Shame on me!"

There is that word again—'Should!' As Albert Ellis pointed out when he explained rational thinking, 'Should' is at the base of each stumbling block to happiness. Once you find your 'Should,' you can start disputing. When looking at Guilt, remember that it is not the event itself that causes your Guilt. It is the 'Should' you attach to the event that makes you feel Guilty. If you did something wrong and stopped right there: "I did something wrong—period! I simply made a mistake," you would never feel Guilty! It is only when we believe that we should be perfect, that we should never make mistakes, and that when we do, we are worth less as a person, as a human being, that we feel Guilt! Remember that no one is a PHB, a Perfect Human Being—we are all FHBs, Fallible Human Beings.

W2: Worthlessness

Although I'd like to blame everything about Guilt on the word 'Should,' Guilt, like the other stumbling blocks, has a rating component. This brings us to worthlessness, the W2. If you are feeling Guilty, you are telling yourself that you should have done something differently, and because you did not, you are somehow inferior. For example, "I should have picked up flowers for my wife's birthday, but I didn't get her any flowers, ergo, I am a bad husband…," or "I should have gotten that report done faster but I lacked skill and initiative, therefore I am not good at my job…." The culmination of both of these irrational beliefs is, "…and because of this, I am a bad person (my essence *is* bad-

ness)! I have failed at some or many of my ventures, therefore I must be a failure!

Is this completely, 100% actually true? If it were, you could never button up your shirt correctly, because you are a complete (100%) failure, and 100% failure=0% success! It would be impossible for you to do one thing correctly in the past, present, or future. That is what complete means.

Earlier we discussed how the irrational belief of rating is destructive and will not lead to living a healthy life. I told you there is no such thing as self-worth. This is like the example of Awfulizing the painting; you can't call a painting awful in a rational sense since you cannot touch or measure the awful in it. That's because awful is not a real, physical attribute of the painting itself—it is a conception, a story told by our Narrator (our thinking). Similarly, worth is not a real attribute. You cannot touch it and you cannot measure it, so worth does not exist except in your own mind. So if worth doesn't rationally exist, how can you be worth anything? And if you can't be worth anything to start with, then how can you be worth less? This is rational thinking! Freedom! In this case freedom from constantly comparing ourselves to others and having to 'prove our worth.' When we try to prove our worth or worthlessness, we are trying to prove concepts—which are made of words and sentences—with more words and sentences. We end up on a bigger Merry-Go-Round than the one in Palisades Park, only not so merry!

Thus, it is the combination of Wrongness—that you did a behavior you shouldn't have or didn't do a behavior you should have, and Worthlessness—that you are worth less as a person because of your wrong behavior that create feelings of Guilt. Well now,

that's not so scary. If there are only two things that make you feel Guilty, then there are only two things to dispute!

Let's first look at wrongness (W1). Wrongness, at most, just means you made a mistake or an error, and as we discussed in the Anxiety section on mistake making, mistakes and errors and are part of being human—FHBs. Unless you consider yourself a God, you better assume you're going to make plenty of mistakes in your life. On the subject of God, I once had a patient who was feeling guilty because he skipped church on Wednesday. I asked him how he could be so certain that this action was wrong, and he told me he just 'knew' it was! So what about the other people who didn't go to church on Wednesday and don't feel that it is wrong? Wrongness is an absolute, so something can't be defined as wrong unless it is wrong for everyone, thus very few things can truly be defined as wrong. Wrong exists as a belief and not a fact. To quote Shakespeare again, "Nothing is either right or wrong but thinking makes it so."

Now technically wrongness alone cannot rationally cause Guilt, although it does set you up to feel guilty. This is where the other component, worthlessness (W2) comes in. We can clearly see their relationship in the BS equation.

The BS Equation

When we believe that our mistakes damage our self-worth, it's because we've bought into the B=S equation: Behavior=Self. This equation states that what we *did* equals who we *are*—wholly and permanently! This isn't true, so it's an irrational belief. Behavior and self are not equal or interchangeable.

The biggest **BS** we tell ourselves is that our behavior equals our self and self-worth:

Behavior=Self

But this is incorrect. Behavior does *not* equal self.

B≠S

Behavior *only* equals behavior:

B=B

It is rational to rate behavior not only because rating behavior can help us see what change is appropriate to solve our practical problems, but more importantly because behavior leads to the action necessary to achieve those solutions. It is factual and provable. I can prove I yelled at the person who cut me off in traffic (and so can the others in my car!), and because I can prove it, I can evaluate it. Is it helpful or unhelpful to act in this way? What would be better for me to change to improve the ride to work for me and the others I carpool with? This is a helpful way to determine how to improve the situation in the future. Change becomes possible and attainable.

If, however, I transfer the properties of my behavior (in this case, unhelpful and abusive) to my*self*, I'm no longer rating the behavior, I'm now rating myself—wholly and permanently. I am not likely to make any headway here in my joy in the moment and in my life going forward. Now if that were true, it would look like the equation below.

If my behavior is unhelpful and abusive, or 'bad:'

B=unhelpful + abusive

And *if* behavior equals self:

B=S

Then I myself must be an unhelpful and abusive,
or 'bad' person:

S=unhelpful + abusive

But is this true? Am I wholly and permanently an unhelpful and abusive person? I would be if B=S! Yet we have established that humans are an ever-changing system, so I can't possibly be wholly and permanently 'bad'—or 'good!' When you break it down into steps you can clearly see how this thinking is irrational, and why we become emotionally and psychologically disturbed when we believe it. So does that mean my unhelpful and abusive behavior means I'm still 'good?' No, your behavior has no bearing at all on your Self!

Let's say we agree my behavior *is* unhelpful and abusive:

B=unhelpful + abusive

But because behavior does *not* equal self:

B≠S

And instead, behavior equals behavior:

B=B

Then *only my behavior* is unhelpful and abusive:

B=unhelpful + abusive

If I am not a wholly and permanently unhelpful and abusive person, then I can do better. I am still capable of helpful and non-abusive behavior. I would do better to practice those behaviors or I'm liable to lose my carpool buddies!

Let's say that, like my patient, you skipped church one Wednesday, and you are one hundred percent correct that what you did was wrong. No one is going to change your mind—skipping church on Wednesday is just unacceptable and wrong. But you did it, you stayed home and watched your favorite sitcom instead of going to church. What are you telling yourself that is making you feel guilty? You are saying that because you did not attend services, you are a bad person—lazy, faithless, and worthless! How do you dispute that? Stop for a minute and think about the concept of worth as it relates to the BS equation. Skipping church was the behavior, one you can rate as 'lazy' and 'worth less.' But because we know B does not equal S, skipping church doesn't make you lazy and worthless. Now let's say you change your behavior and never skip another Wednesday service. Does that make you better or worth more Now as a person? Nope, sorry Charlie! The BS equation applies here too; you can rate the behavior is 'good' but because B doesn't equal S, attending church has no more effect on the worth of your Self than *not* attending.

You cannot quantify worth because it is a concept we as humans made up in our heads and continue to perpetuate, contributing to feelings of Guilt. Ellis's words about self-worth resonate with this simple, rational fact: "You cannot get intrinsic self-worth from extrinsic people, actions, or things."

Now that you understand how Guilt is created, you can break it down into four steps to disputing it.

We'll use the example of my patient who felt terribly guilty over getting divorced, particularly for her daughter who now had to be raised in a 'broken' home. Applying The 4 Steps to Disputing would look like this:

STEP 1: OBSERVE

Ask yourself, "How am I feeling and acting in this situation?"

This woman was feeling extreme Guilt, so she was buying her daughter everything she wanted to compensate for the perceived lack of love.

STEP 2: SOS

Ask yourself, "What am I irrationally thinking about myself, others in this situation, or the situation in general, to make myself upset?"

My patient believed the concept that she was wrong for getting a divorce, that she was a poor excuse for a mother (Self) for not providing a traditional nuclear family for her daughter (Others), and that she was worth less as a woman and as a human being because she wasn't able to keep her marriage together (Situation).

STEP 3: IDENTIFY

Ask yourself, "What irrational thoughts am I believing? What are my red-flag statements?"

Here, I asked my patient (and she eventually learned to ask herself), "Why is it that my daughter must be raised by her biological parents, and that they stay married to each other? Where in the universe is it written that every child needs to have their every desire satisfied, at all times, and they must only be raised by their biological parents? Is it really Awful that you are no longer married to your first husband?

STEP 4: REPLACE

Ask yourself, "What realistic preferences can I substitute for my irrational thinking?"

My patient started replacing her guilty thoughts with rational statements, such as "It's unfortunate that my mar-

> riage didn't work out, but I can still enjoy being a mom." "I feel frustrated that my life hasn't worked out exactly how I thought it would." "I want my daughter to have a great childhood but giving her presents won't guarantee her permanent happiness and will not make up for my divorcing her father."

See how easy it is to dispute Guilt? Once you realize that occasionally doing wrong things is a part of the human condition, and worth is just another way of looking at the destructive concept of self- rating. You can see that Guilt is irrational. You can choose to Stop or Let Go of thinking Guilty thoughts, and you will begin to live a healthier and happy life.

> *"Never, never, ever, put yourself down about anything!"*
> THE GOLDEN RULE OF RATIONAL LIVING

When you catch yourself feeling Guilty remember that it means you're full of B=S—the BS equation, that is—and realize that your behavior does not and cannot equal your Self.

Unconditional Self-Acceptance

In Ellis' in *A Guide to Rational Living* he recounts an example of a patient struggling with self-worth and understanding the application of unconditional self-acceptance:

> *After several sessions of Rational Emotive Behavioral Therapy, my patient realized that almost everything he did since his early childhood stemmed from his fierce need to win the acclaim of his parents, wife, children, friends, and even employees.*
>
> *At his ninth session he asked, "Do I understand you correctly to mean that if I stop trying to win everyone's applause and*

mainly do what I would like to do that I'll then love myself because I'll consider myself more worthwhile?"

"No," I replied. "We REBT-ers have come to realize that worthwhileness is almost as dangerous as its counterpart worthlessness. In fact, just as soon as you tend to think in terms of a personal 'worth' you almost automatically tend to think in terms of personal 'worthlessness.'

"Thus, if you consider yourself 'worthwhile' today because you function effectively or make wise decisions, you'll tend to consider yourself 'worthless' tomorrow if you then function less effectively and make unwise decisions."

"But wouldn't I have no worth if I never functioned effectively?" asked the client.

"No, definitely not. Even if you were mentally deficient and never functioned well, you would then have little external 'worth' - because others might not find you a suitable companion or coworker. But you could decide to have as much 'worth' to yourself as more efficient individuals. You would have 'worth' if you believed you were worthwhile. But if you believed, as you obviously do, that inefficiency makes you 'worthless,' you would then feel exactly that - like a zero."

"So I am 'worthwhile' if I think I am, no matter how inefficiently I may actually perform in life?"

"Yes, exactly that, as I said before, the very idea of 'worth' has its dangers, since it implies a concept of 'worthlessness.' Just like the concept of heaven implies the concept of hell. In fact, we usually employ terms, 'to be worthwhile' to mean much

the same thing as to be angelic or heaven-bound. And 'to be worthless means to be damnable or hell-directed. Doesn't it?"

"In a way, I guess it does. I can see what you mean," said the client.

"Moreover, if you use concepts like 'worth' and 'worthlessness," even if you avoid vilifying yourself, you will tend to be preoccupied with varying degrees of 'worth.' Thus, you will tend to say to yourself: 'Today I have great worth, yesterday I had less; I hope and pray that tomorrow I will have more."

Your philosophy of 'worth' and 'worthlessness' leads to disturbed feelings of Guilt, shame, and self-loathing. You'll be much better off with the concept that you are not 'worthwhile' because of your effectiveness nor 'worthless' because of your ineffectiveness. You merely exist. This idea is difficult for most people to see and accept. But once you clearly endorse it, you eliminate the notion of intrinsic 'worthlessness' and self-hatred."

"I'll have to give this some more thought," said the client. "But it does seem to have something to it and does tie in with self-acceptance."

"Yes, it has an important tie-in with unconditional self-acceptance. For self-acceptance means fully accepting yourself, your existence, your right to live and to be as happy as you can be - no matter what traits you have or acts you do. It does not mean self-esteem, self-confidence, self-respect, or self-regard. For all these terms imply that you can only accept yourself because you do something well or because other people like you. Unconditional self-acceptance means that you accept yourself because you are alive and have decided to

accept yourself. Only a limited number of talented, intelligent, competent, and well-loved people can gain self- esteem or self-confidence. But anyone, merely because he or she chooses to have it, can gain self-acceptance."

"Does self-acceptance mean that I consider myself worthy or deserving of living and enjoying life no matter what I do?"

"Yes, although I don't like the words worthy or deserving, since they imply a rating of your you-ness. They suggest that you have to do (or refrain from doing) something in order to feel 'worthy' or 'deserving.' When you have what we call unconditional self-acceptance, you make minimal assumptions about your (and other people's) intrinsic worth or value."

"What minimal assumptions?"

"Several: One, you exist. Two, you can probably, by continuing to exist, achieve more pleasure than pain, thus making it desirable for you to keep living. Three, you can help reduce your pain and increase your pleasure. Four, you decide - and this constitutes the essence of self-acceptance - that you will try to live and make your life as pleasurable and unpainful as you can make it. Or, putting it another way, you choose as the main purpose of your existence short-range and long-range enjoyment. You may strive for achievement and approval not to prove your greatness as a person. Not to get into heaven. Just because you prefer to achieve and be loved."

"So instead of me asking myself, 'What am I worth?" 'How do I keep proving myself?' 'How can I outstandingly impress others?' or 'What do I have to do to ennoble myself?' I'd better, instead, ask 'How can I avoid needless pain and discover what I truly enjoy in life and do it? Right?"

"Right! You make the purpose of your existence having a present and future ball—in whatever personal and social ways you experimentally discover."

"You mean that I may then look for my existence as more enjoyable. But I still will not really be more 'worthwhile'—only more alive, happier?"

"Yes. And you will not, we hope, damn yourself or punish yourself whenever—as an imperfect human—you do something wrong or unwise. You will accept yourself with your foolish thoughts, feelings and actions, and use your 'bad' experiences to help you enjoy yourself and behave better in the future. What greater acceptance of self can you then have?"

"The mind is an elusive thing. Don't think for a minute you know who you are."
TE TOH

Procrastination

No discussion of Guilt would be complete without a good look at procrastination, because many people feel guilty while procrastinating. Just about everyone procrastinates at one time or another. It is a very human thing to do, and there is no need to put yourself down when you become aware of having procrastinated.

Identifying Procrastination

Identifying why you procrastinate is an important step towards getting your tasks done. Once you know how you tend to block your efforts, you can actively work to overcome procrastination. Here are some reasons for procrastination:

Fear of the Future: You are afraid of failing. If you pushed ahead and completed the task, it may not turn out as well as you thought it would. As long as you don't attempt to do a task, you don't have the possibility of failure.

Awfulizing: You exaggerate the consequences of a less-than-perfect outcome. You tell yourself it would be awful if you failed and that you couldn't stand it, so you put it off.

Unrealistic Expectations: You think you can do much more than you can. You pile up tasks and then find yourself unable to complete them. Eventually you feel overwhelmed and put off doing anything at all.

Approval: You're afraid to say no. You are afraid you may lose other people's approval which you think you need in order to approve of yourself.

Understanding Procrastination

Now that you have some reasons for procrastination, here are some of the ways we keep procrastinating tendencies alive:

Rationalizing: You tell yourself things that in your mind justify the delay: "I'll start tomorrow," "I'm tired and as soon as I've rested, I'll start," or the very popular, "I've admitted I'm a procrastinator now, so I can play the role honestly," and then, last but not least, "I always do my best work at the eleventh hour." More B=S.

Impulsivity: You give up because the task seems too hard. Then, from time to time, you burst with energy and work hard for the quick kill, which doesn't come. You then prove to yourself that the world is too hard for you and you give up.

Escapism: Instead of doing what needs to be done, you believe a magical solution will present itself if you just wait and are patient. Instead of working hard for success, you substitute fantasy for reality which will bring you only temporary relief. You might escape into television, books, walks, and minor tasks that will keep your mind off the things you need to do in order to succeed.

Overcoming Procrastination

Recognize that it is what you are telling yourself that defeats your efforts.

Begin now. Stop believing you need inspiration before you start. Getting into a task usually brings inspiration. If you avoid the task, inspiration may never come.

Accept that you are human and will find it difficult to accomplish hard tasks. Set small goals and reward yourself when you accomplish them and deny or penalize yourself when you don't do what you want. Stop believing that you will be able to do it without a reward system.

Write yourself reminders and place them where you will see them every day. Remind yourself not to procrastinate and you will help yourself achieve your goals.

Know that you can change. Sometimes you will backslide and while it is normal, it is not permanent. When you see yourself procrastinating do not conclude that you are beyond help and will never change. Behavior is still just behavior (B=B), and can be changed with effort. You are not stuck with your procrastination for life. You can do something about it.

CHAPTER 9

THE FORMULAS FOR HAPPINESS

"The percentage of the time that you are upset = the percent of the time that you are not accepting things 'as they are' in this present moment."

VINCE PARR

Now that you have learned how to overcome the four blocks and reduce personal disturbance and unhappiness, I am going to show you how to reach the ultimate goal in life—personal happiness and inner peace!

The Short Formula

The first equation for happiness is short and simple:

100% A = 0% D

Total Acceptance = **Zero D**isturbance

The amount of upset that you feel is equal to the number of things that you are not accepting in this moment; the activating event, the other person, yourself, or the situation. So if you accept everything that happens in every moment, you will never be disturbed! If you can accept only 90% of what happens, then you will be 10% emotionally disturbed. If you're 50% accepting, you're 50% disturbed. Whatever numbers you insert, the math always works out.

Given the choice, I don't know anyone who would opt to be more than 0% disturbed, but 100% acceptance is a tall order. While it may not be humanly possible to achieve a total, permanent state of acceptance, it is possible, with practice and training of the mind, to get very close! There are a couple of Zen quotes I love that may help you in those hard-to-accept moments;

"This moment doesn't have an option." There is no other 'now' than the one you're experiencing. The conditions that caused this moment have already happened. You cannot choose another reality.

"Flowers fall amid our longing; weeds grow despite our loathing." You are not in control here. All the pissing, moaning, bitching, whining, and complaining in the world won't stop the natural order of the universe.

If you're still a little confused about what this actually means, let me illustrate with a story Jack Kornfield often tells. There was a professional golfer known for both his skill on the golf course and for his charitable spirit. After winning one particular tournament in South America, he was approached in the parking lot by a younger woman. She congratulated him on his victory and then told him a heart-wrenching story about her infant who was suffering from a terrible and fatal disease, and the financial pressure she and her husband were suffering in order to pay the doctor and hospital bills. He was so moved by her story that he immediately signed over the check he won in the tournament and told her to do whatever she could to give her child comfort.

The next day this golfer was approached at a dinner in the same city. A man told him that they had heard about this woman and had made efforts to track her down. They found that she was unmarried and had no child; the golfer had been scammed. He looked at the man and said, "So you mean there is no dying baby? That's the best news I've heard all day!"

This story, and particularly this golfer, illustrates what it means to find happiness through acceptance. He could have gotten angry or frustrated at having been scammed and had lost his money, or he could have been so angry that he wanted to find this woman and shake the money out of her. Instead, he accepted what had happened and looked for the positive—there was no sick and dying baby! This doesn't mean he endorsed or approved of her behavior. He simply is recognized that it already happened so it can't be otherwise—but at least there is no suffering child!

The Long Formula

This concept of acceptance brings us to the second equation for happiness. This equation is longer than the first one, but the ideas and principles are the same.

H = USA + UAOW + SN

Happiness = **U**nconditional **S**elf-**A**cceptance + **U**nconditional **A**cceptance *o*f **O**thers and the **W**orld + **S**taying **N**ow

USA: Unconditional Self-Acceptance

Unconditional self-acceptance means that you accept yourself fully and totally, for both your faults and your strengths. It does not, however, mean you don't hold yourself to any standards or

that you give up whenever things are too hard. When you screw up, you accept that you are a fallible human being and will make mistakes. You then work hard to do your best whenever possible. Remember that there are no perfect human beings, we are all going to make mistakes many times in our life. It's irrational to expect otherwise of ourselves or anyone else. That brings us to the second part of the equation:

UAOW: Unconditional Acceptance of Others and the World

Unconditional acceptance of others and the world as it is (not as we want it to be) sounds long and complex, but the premise is simple: the world and the people around us are how they are, and they aren't going to change or be different just because you prefer them to. You will be happier if you let go of your expectations of your coworkers, the other drivers on the highway, or your spouse. They are as they are because all the conditions have occurred for them to be so. It is not possible for them to be any different in this moment. Comparing them to how they might be, or how you wish they were, is indulging in the irrational belief of rating.

When you choose to stop rating, you are by definition choosing to practice acceptance. Acceptance of yourself, acceptance of others, and acceptance of the world as it is, all lead to happiness, while rating can only lead to disturbance. Now, acceptance does not mean be a pushover. You can accept the reality that your coworker took credit for your idea without rating or being upset. It's not easy, but you can do it. But if you're a wise person, you will also realize that someone who treated you badly once is likely to do it again. So while you accept that you can't change what already happened—and that you can't change your coworker—you will be wary of them in the future. You will

not waste your time and energy being angry about it, feeling depressed that you 'let' them do it, or guilty that you didn't stop it. You are practicing acceptance and awareness without judgment or endorsement.

SN: Staying Now

The final component of the longer equation for happiness is staying now. This is a bit of a simplified term for describing 'being in the flow of all of life' (because I'm a bit lazy and it's easier than explaining each time!). In actuality, you can't stay now, because now, the present moment, has already passed. You are always moving on to a new now! This can also be said as being present or mindful, but it all means the same thing—if you keep your mind in the present and enjoy living each moment, you will be happier and less disturbed.

You may be tempted to be anxious about your presentation tomorrow or relive the argument you had with your boss yesterday, but that's wasted energy. You can't change yesterday and worrying won't do anything to change tomorrow. Instead, focus your energy on living here, in the ever-flowing now, and you will be happy. Accept that the past can't be different. Jack Kornfield had a beautiful way of saying this: "All Guilt is hoping for a better past." The future cannot be predicted. If you're feeling upset, focus on your breathing to help you get back to the moment and watch the passing show.

Staying now with this constant state of flux, flow, and change is a constant practice. You can't choose to 'stay now' and be done with it, because this moment has already passed. At every millisecond every atom in the Universe changes completely so that no two seconds are ever the same. It would be more help-

ful in achieving peace to embrace the constant dynamic flow of now from moment to moment. You can allow the flow to pass around you without getting caught up in it or thrashing around to keep your head above water. When in an undertow, move with the stream not against it. Detach, be the Observer, and just watch the show.

Adding to Happiness

I offer a corollary to these formulas for happiness:

GH = H + CA – HF

Greater **H**appiness = **H**appiness + **C**reative Absorption – **H**assle **F**actor

CA: Creative Absorption

Most people who describe themselves as happy have pleasurable and stimulating activities they pursue outside of everyday responsibilities. So many times when I ask a patient suffering from Depression, "What do you do for fun?" they respond, "Nothing." So what occupies your mind when you're not working or handling other life responsibilities? The answer is usually more of the same irrational thinking and emotional suffering that got them to my office in the first place.

It is important to occupy, stimulate, recharge, and retrain the mind for optimum function! Now, don't let the word 'creative' deter you; an activity doesn't have to involve any artistic endeavors. While many people choose painting, music, or learning a foreign language, a creative absorption simply refers to an engaging, pleasurable hobby or activity that you look forward to. It may be organizing things, scuba diving, reading, garden-

ing, or any of thousands of other pastimes. It could be painting by numbers where all the 4s you paint green and all the 3s you paint yellow. The only qualifier is that it be pleasant to you, and the only limit is your imagination!

HF: The Hassle Factor

The hassle factor detracts from happiness and contentment. While it may look a little different to everyone, it can be described as the result of decisions that complicate our lives with physical, mental, or emotional clutter. The hassle factor will cause physical conditions that promote disturbance, so it would be wise to reduce additions that often lead us to becoming stressed. Collecting can be a source of hassle when material things start to take up breathing room and infringe on your physical space and peace of mind. At best it is a source of distraction and worry; at worst it can devolve into hoarding. I once had a friend that collected Beanie Babies until you literally could not move your arms without knocking one over. It was an obsession for him, and nearly claustrophobic and unpleasant for visitors. Your HF could be buying your fourth cat or dog, buying a used boat, or splurging on Black Friday and Cyber Monday so you can collect more stuff to pack into your already overcrowded space.

Material things, contrary to what society tells us, are not the source of happiness and contentment, but the very opposite! That's why the Zen monasteries are so spartan—clear, simple, peaceful. My hassle-free motto: *"Less fuss, more peace!"*

So that's it—two equations and now you know how to be happy and content in life. Are you asking yourself why you bothered reading all the previous chapters? If being happy is as simple as

two equations, why you didn't just start out with those two and you could be happy by now? For two reasons!

First, because it is important to understand the building blocks of rational thinking to get to a place where you would be able to comprehend these equations and apply them to your life. Unpleasant activating events are inevitably going to happen, and if you are not equipped to deal with these negative events, your happiness will be easily disturbed. Anger, Anxiety, Depression, and Guilt when left undisputed, will most always weigh you down and block you from happiness.

Secondly, Happiness takes practice! For this I would highly recommend Zen which I believe just puts the cherry on top of the chocolate ice cream. Far from being some magic or mystical practice, Zen just means meditation. And when we meditate on 'just this,' we begin to see the world as it is, and how it always has been at each breath.

With the tools and knowledge you have acquired, you are now equipped to handle any disturbance you may experience. My best to you and your adventure in life.

CHAPTER 10

WHY ZEN MEDITATION IS ESSENTIAL MIND TRAINING

"Art is frozen Zen."
R.H. BLYTH

Although not a requirement for REBT and CBT, I highly recommend regular meditation to anyone struggling with the four blocks. I'm not talking about some mystical, woo-woo, 'people-sitting-cross-legged-chanting-Om' kind of thing (not that there's anything wrong with that). Rather, I encourage training yourself to be aware: to observe your thoughts without reacting, to appreciate the mind-body connection, to develop a non-clinging mind, and to flow with Now. Awareness is key to being able to red-flag and dispute, and thus essential to changing your belief system and to stop being disturbed.

The practice I recommend, as stated above, is Zen, which literally means meditation. The goal of this type of meditation is to bring a full awareness to the mind, body, breath, sensations, feelings, thoughts, and to be fully present in the flow of Now. It's essentially training in learning to see things as they really are without mental labeling and chatter. This form of meditation can be universally practiced by people of any religion or creed.

The basic practice of Zen involves sitting or lying in a quiet place, in a comfortable position with a straight back (not stiff),

and focusing on your breathing. When you have calmed yourself and are only aware of your breathing—in and out, in and out—you are able to observe sensations, thoughts, and feelings, and note how fleeting they are. You can feel something or see something and then let it go. When you do this consistently, you achieve two goals: the first is that you are able to observe your thoughts without being caught up in them, and the second is that you are able to see that they only last for a finite amount of time. Think about when you have an itch. What happens when you scratch it? You make it worse, right? But if you focus on the physical sensation of the itch, the itchiness eventually fades away and is gone. It is like this for every sensation—if you don't scratch it and make it worse, it goes away. And we make it worse by our thoughts. The Buddha said: *"We are a sum total of all we have thought."*

Although it is best to meditate in a quiet place when you first start meditation, as you grasp the concepts more fully you will be able to practice in any situation, even in the middle of Time's Square on New Year's eve! This is why so many people enjoy so-called 'mindless' hobbies such as knitting, sewing, or painting; they provide a calm and pleasant environment in which they can let go of their thoughts and connect to the Now moment. In fact, any activity that takes you out of your inner dialogue and engages your six senses, such as TV, movies, or reading, will help you tap into the flow state of complete, unthinking immersion in the moment.

As you integrate Zen into your daily routine, you'll find it easier to turn to meditation in the moment you are feeling Anger, Anxiety, Depression, or Guilt. Practice the Centering Breath referred to in the chapter on Anxiety. Don't fight the

physical sensations—the racing pulse, rapid breathing, sweating or shaking—rather, allow them to happen while you turn your attention to your breathing. Breathe in, be aware of your thoughts and tension, pause, then breathe out while thinking, *Let go,* while you release negative emotions and physiological sensations.

The more often you turn to your breathing and awareness, the more instinctual the practice will become. You can simply be aware of the irrational beliefs as you let go of the Narrator's reactive thinking and allow the mind and body come to the single point of awareness of the moment.

"Do not seek to follow in the footsteps of the wise; seek what they sought."
BASHO MATSUO

"That it will never come again is what makes life so sweet."
EMILY DICKINSON

"I wish you happiness, peace, and a fulfilling life!"

VINCE PARR

CHAPTER 11

HEALTHY BODY, HEALTHY MIND

No matter how much you study, practice, and meditate, if you neglect your physical health you will find it more difficult to develop a mind of peace and happiness. You would do well to support your healthy thinking habits with healthy physical habits. Restorative sleep, regular exercise, and a nutritious diet are all directly connected to a sense of calm and wellbeing, whereas poor sleep, lack of exercise, and insufficient nutrition negatively impact our mental and emotional health.

Sleep

Outside of reprogramming your genetic code, quality sleep is the greatest contributor to mental and physical health. Current research indicates that 7-8.5 hours of quality sleep per night is essential for mental acuity, longevity, and performance. Most people know to avoid caffeine or long naps after a certain time of day, but there are a number of other factors affecting your rest that may surprise you.

Manage Your Mood

Do you ever find your mind racing as you lie in bed watching the hours tick by? Explore your thoughts and feelings. Are you anxious? Depressed? Frustrated? That stressful chatter in your head can be a major factor in insomnia. Go back to the ABCs

and look for the activating events you may be focused on. Then use the 4 Steps of Disputing to find, dispute, and destroy irrational thoughts. Use the Centered Breathing technique from the chapter on Anxiety to center yourself, release tension, and breathe, "Let go."

Reserve Your Bed for Bedroom Activities

Try not to use your bedroom for work or watching TV. Think about it—when you bring your laptop to bed, you're bringing all your worries with it! If you only use your bedroom for rest and sex, you'll actually strengthen your brain's association between 'bed' and 'sleep.' If you're not sleepy at bedtime, go to another room or area and do something relaxing like read a book or meditate.

Say Goodnight to Your Brain

and signal 'bedtime' to your brain. Turn off electronics, dim the lights, and maybe have a cup of herbal tea or a bath before climbing into bed. Recent studies by the National Sleep Foundation have noted that meditation can also improve quantity and quality of sleep by calming the mind.

Get Comfy

Make sure your environment is clean, comfortable, and relaxing. A dark, cool, quiet room will minimize invasive distractions that keep you from falling asleep. Soft sheets and a good mattress will help reduce tossing and turning so you can stay asleep!

Exercise

Often we think of exercise as a means of increasing physical strength or preventing and reducing weight gain (often with

a great deal of groaning and complaining!) but current scientific evidence has shown long-term mental and emotional benefits, too. Regular moderate exercise has been shown to promote clear thinking, improve sleep, and lower stress levels. A University of British Columbia study found that regular cardio workouts appear to enlarge the hippocampus, the part of the brain responsible for visual memory and learning. The researchers looked primarily at brisk walking, but pretty much any exercise that raises your heart rate can improve mood, relieve stress, decrease anxiety, improve ADHD symptoms, and reduce the risk of mild or moderate depression. A 2019 study by Harvard School of Public Health found that just 15 minutes a day of walking or running reduced the risk of major depression by 26%.

Physical activity is especially essential for the physically, emotional, and intellectual development of children. The US Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans published in 2019 recommends around 3 hours a day of active play for kids ages 3–5. Children ages 6–17 need at least 60 minutes of bone-, body-, and brain-building exercise such as sports or playground activities. Over time, being active improves cognition and reduces the risk of depression just as in adults.

Exercise doesn't have to be a don't-stop-till-you-drop activity to be beneficial. Tai chi, yoga, or walking in nature can help you connect to awareness and focus the mind while building strength, coordination, and endurance. Household activities are often mindlessly repetitive efforts that get your heart pumping and make you sweat while freeing the mind to a Zen state.

If you're having trouble committing to a regular routine, try joining a class, setting goals and tracking your progress, work-

ing out with a friend who will hold you accountable, or hiring a personal trainer (I find the threat of wasting hard-earned money is a good motivator!).

While 150–300 minutes a week seems to be the recommended amount of activity, any amount has some benefit. As Karmel Choi, a postdoctoral fellow at Harvard noted, "…even if you are already feeling depressed, physical activity helps…. I would say: Start somewhere—remember that something is better than nothing at all."

Nutrition

Have you ever looked at something disturbing and felt nauseous? Been unable to eat because of 'butterflies' before a presentation? Most, if not all of us have experienced digestive issues related to emotionally charged situations. While REBT and Zen are integral to managing emotions, our diet plays a big role in supporting our efforts.

Scientists have known for many years that stress, anxiety, and depression cause or contribute to digestive issues like IBS, nausea, pain, bloating, and constipation. But current research now shows the signals may go both ways; your digestive system may also influence your mood.

Our entire gastrointestinal tract is lined with two thin layers of nerve cells—the enteric nervous system (ENS)—that functions like a little brain in our gut. It communicates with our central nervous system (CNS) or our 'big brain' via what's known as the 'gut-brain axis.' Now, the ENS can't think like our brain—it's not going to balance our checkbook or take notes during a meet-

ing—but its role in transmitting and translating information to and from the brain is critical to our health.

This is the path of communication that allows psychosocial factors to influence the physiology of the digestive system. Your emotions travel from your central nervous system, through the gut-brain axis to the ENS. The ENS translates those emotions into signals that can cause or exacerbate chronic digestive issues.

The flow of information also goes the other direction; the health of your gut can influence your mood. That post-M&M 'sugar high' and subsequent letdown is not a figment of your imagination! A good deal of recent research shows that the community of bacteria in your digestive system—the microbiota of the gut—can have a direct effect on your emotions. Balanced, healthy microbiota have been shown to have a positive effect on emotional and cognitive health, whereas a gut populated by 'bad' bacteria or under attack by infection and inflammation has been linked to depression and anxiety. You are—emotionally and mentally—what you eat!

This is why mind-body therapies like REBT and CBT have been shown to support not only the thinking brain, but the food-processing one as well. The research by scientists like Jay Pasricha, M.D., director of the Johns Hopkins Center for Neurogastroenterology have discovered the profound influence our digestive system has on our thought centers. "Our two brains 'talk' to each other, so therapies that help one may help the other," Pasricha says. "In a way, gastroenterologists (doctors who specialize in digestive conditions) are like counselors looking for ways to soothe the second brain."

Ah, but then we're faced with the big question—how do we do it? There are three factors that can make a drastic difference in the health of your digestive system, your body, and you brain.

Increase Quality, Reduce Quantity

Quality input = quality output
Garbage in = Garbage out

Caloric restriction, intermittent fasting and small portions in general allow the body to regulate itself the way it always intended to. In fact, intermittent fasting (minimum of 12-hour breaks from eating) has been shown to reset stem cells in the body, contribute to mental alertness and improved focus, better physical health, and improved mood.

The second half to Step 1 is to make sure you break your fast with the highest quality foods available. When you're truly hungry, your body is eager to absorb nutrients. If you think it is too expensive to eat healthy, let me assure you, it's a lot more affordable than getting cancer, taking pharmaceutical medications, and spending your valuable time feeling miserable.

Hydrate the Machine

Water is the second most essential element to the survival of the human body, yet most of us don't drink nearly enough to replenish what we use every day! Your body is a complex mechanism that requires fluid to survive. The adult human body is 60–80% water! Your brain, blood, skin, organs, and even your bones can't function properly without it.

The National Academy of Medicine (NAM) traditionally recommended eight 8-ounce glasses per day. Yet according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), about half of

all adults are drinking 1-4 cups a day and 7% don't even drink one cup! This is significantly less than necessary for an average-sized adult, and that deficit can have some surprisingly unpleasant side effects on both your body and mind.

A 2012 study by the European Hydration Institute found "… hydration is a key factor for mental health." Your brain is 75% water, so it makes sense that it would suffer when we're under-hydrated. Circulation slows, lowering blood flow, reducing oxygen to all areas of the body, including the brain. According to study conducted by the School of Psychology and Clinical Language Sciences in 2013, a lack of sufficient water in the body impacts cognitive functions like short-term memory and vision, and causes significant mood disturbance.

A man once complained to me that he was feeling unwell but couldn't point to anything specific. He was having trouble swallowing, his vision was blurry, he was groggy and cranky, had persistent headaches, and his heart would race erratically. When I asked him how much water he was drinking every day, he looked at me blankly. "I drink, like, 6 cups of coffee and a couple cans of Coke. Does that count?" Well, no. That's actually the opposite of hydrating because caffeine is a diuretic—it squeezes water out of your body! He agreed to reduce the coffee and replace the soda with 90 ounces of water (about 3 liters) per day. After two weeks of drinking the recommended amount, he reported nearly all his symptoms had completely disappeared!

A good way to determine your own hydration needs is divide your body weight in half—that's how many ounces you should aim for every day. Increase the amount for caffeine, alcohol, and strenuous exercise. The National Academy of Medicine now recommends setting a goal of about 3.7 liters (15 cups) for the

average adult male and 2.7 liters (11 cups) for the average adult female. This may seem like a lot, but remember you can get a good portion of your hydration needs from caffeine-free and sugar-free beverages like herbal tea or milk, and from nutritious soups, meat, fruits, and vegetables.

Start by setting small goals and making gradual changes. Swap out a soda, caffeinated iced tea or fruit juice for an equal amount of water or herbal tea. Increase the substitution every couple of days and add a couple of fruits or veggies to your meal. While I don't necessarily recommend flavored or carbonated water, these can be a helpful step in the transition as long as the goal is to provide your body with all the clean, pure H2O it needs to function!

Make Mealtimes Calm

The ENS works alongside the parasympathetic nervous system (PSNS)—the 'rest-and-digest' response—affecting every part of the digestive process; swallowing, breaking down food, helping nutrient absorption, and regulating elimination. Rest-and-digest is the opposite of the fight-or-flight response created by the sympathetic nervous system; it functions best when you are relaxed.

When you're stressed around mealtimes—a rushed lunch between meetings, shoveling a candy bar while dropping the kids off, or rushing around to feed the family—your adrenaline is surging, triggered by your 'fight-or-flight' response. Your body is unable to produce the gastric juices to absorb nutrients, vitamins, and minerals needed to support mental health. You may have trouble swallowing, or find you feel nauseous.

The key to engaging the essential 'rest-and-digest' state is feeling calm, but many times the very act of preparing or sitting down to a meal can be hectic and stressful. It takes a little effort and focus, but with practice you can create an atmosphere of tranquility wherever you are. Take a pause. Examine your thoughts. Practice the Centered Breath. Acknowledge stressful, irrational thoughts and let them go. Think of mealtimes as a way to nourish both body and mind, because that's exactly what you're doing! Your work, kids, and life will be there after lunch. Deal with them then. And above all, no emotional problem solving or arguing at meal times! Pause, rest, nourish, and relax.

These steps have the potential to change your life for the better! When incorporated with daily meditation and rational thinking, these three physical factors can literally change your mind. You will displace long-standing irrational thoughts, feelings, and behaviors and replace them with new, healthy habits. Give it time, keep practicing, and you will live a more productive, healthy, and happy life!

CHAPTER 12

LESSONS FROM THE 10 OX-HERDING PICTURES

When your time is up, all the knowledge and material wealth you have acquired in your life will be of no use at all in facing death. All human blessings and rewards are finished, you have no way out.

What will take you through this difficult time is the equanimity that you have acquired through wisdom, i.e., not knowledge itself, but living what you have learned.

In this last chapter I will present Dr. Kathleen Shakai Bishop's excellent article, *Lessons from the 10 Ox-herding Pictures Workbook.*

The Ten Ox-Herding Pictures are some of the most famous illustrations in Buddhism and Zen Buddhism in particular. It is a series of poems and illustrations that explain how one progresses toward enlightenment and then returns to society with newfound wisdom and compassion. The commentaries that have been written on these pictures are vast and wide. In this workbook Dr. Bishop took the opportunity to share her views about the pictures along with sharing the thoughts and ideas of other contemporary writers on Buddhism who have done so as well.

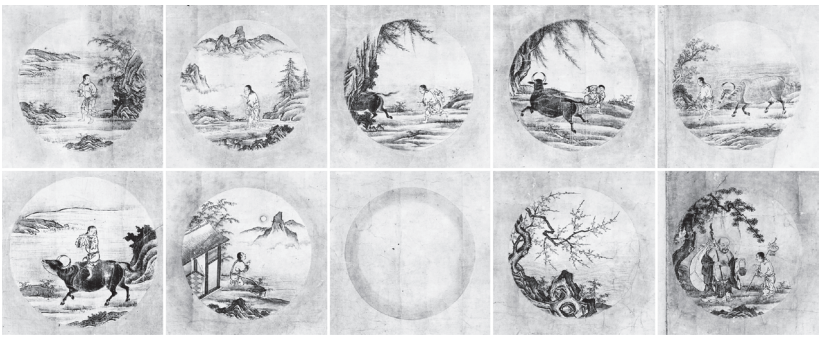
I present these almost verbatim, as she has presented them, in a clear and straightforward fashion. Nothing hidden, nothing extra, and nothing left out. I wish to thank her again for her permission to let me present these in my final chapter because of their value in understanding the human condition.

Dr. Bishop presents the 10 Ox-herding pictures as another adventure in living a life of peace, joy, love, and compassion. This is exactly how I would describe my present book. Applying these methods you will be ready for your final chapter in life. Knowledge will turn into Wisdom and you will be going back to the root source of all Reality.

PREFACE

Lessons From the 10 Ox-Herding Pictures

by Kathleen Bishop, M.S., Ph.D.



The ten ox-herding pictures are some of the most famous illustrations in Buddhism. The commentaries that have been written on these pictures are vast and wide. In this workbook I've taken the opportunity to share my views about the pictures along with sharing the thoughts and ideas of other contemporary writers on Buddhism who have done so as well.

I hope that you will enjoy the pictures, the commentaries, and the ideas shared and that they will help you in life with your studies in Buddhism and beyond.

In gassho, Shokai

INTRODUCTION

Many years ago I went on a retreat with Father Robert Kennedy who is a Catholic priest and a Zen Buddhist teacher and the author of several books on Buddhism. He studied with both Bernie Glassman Roshi and Taizan Maezumi Roshi two wonderful Zen teachers and mentors. I was so enthralled with his teaching during our weekend Sesshin that I bought all of his books.

His book Zen Gifts to Christians is based on the famous Ten Ox-herding pictures of Zen. It is a unique way to review and understand some of the basic principles of Zen in a fun and inspiring way.

John M. Koller in the Department of Cognitive Science at Renssaelaer Polytechnic Institute has written a wonderful paper on it as well entitled: Ox-Herding: Stages of Zen Practice. He wrote this in his introduction:

The ten ox-herding pictures and commentaries presented here depict the stages of practice leading to the enlightenment at which Zen (Chan) Buddhism aims. They dramatize the fact that enlightenment reveals the true self, showing it to be the ordinary self doing ordinary things in the most extraordinary way. Wonderful! I just love that idea that Buddhism helps us discover our true self in its ordinariness and its extraordinariness![1]

1 Tenshō Shūbun, Shokoku-ji Temple website, Public Domain, https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=2350512

I will use D.T. Suzuki's titles for each picture:

1: Searching for the Ox
2: Seeing the Traces
3: Seeing the Ox
4: Catching the Ox
5: Herding the Ox
6: Coming Home on the Ox's Back
7: The Ox Forgotten, Leaving the Man Alone
8: The Ox and the Man both Gone out of Sight
9: Returning to the Origin, Back to the Source
10: Entering the City with Bliss-bestowing Hands

I will use the version of the poem that Koller uses: "The twelfth century monk Guo-an Shi-yuan (also known as Ku-an or Kakuan Shien) revised and expanded upon the traditional Taoist story of the ox and the oxherd by creating a series of ten images and accompanying verses to simultaneously depict and narrate this well-known tale."

I hope you enjoy this adventure as an ox-herder! I know it seems like you're teachers are "shooting the "bull" sometimes in their desire to help you understand the Zen principles and you may think I am as well. Regardless, I know you'll enjoy this adventure from the past and see how relevant it is in your life in the 21st century.

1: SEARCHING FOR THE OX

"In the pasture of the world,
I endlessly push aside the tall grasses in search of the Ox.
Following unnamed rivers,
lost upon the interpenetrating paths of distant mountains,
My strength failing and my vitality exhausted,
I cannot find the Ox."

In truth, the person you see in this picture is all of us searching for something in life. We know that life is a great adventure and that for some of us it has been a very difficult and uphill battle. For others, we've had some good years and some bad years, and yet most of them have been simply rather normal. Regardless of which case we were living under we still found ourselves searching for something. There is the continuing question that appears on a regular basis, "What's it all about Alfie? I wrote a blog on that song sometime back, check it out I think you'll like it.

For Alfie, it was all about seeking and searching for love. What have you been searching for? When you wake up each morning are you searching for the ox? A better marriage, health, job, prosperity, enlightenment, peace, or better grades in school?

The Oxherd was searching for the eternal answer in life, that ungraspable something within him—roaming the world looking down in the valley, up in the mountains, and deep in the ocean. To no avail. When all the time his answer was right within him. He was and is the Buddha.

However, rushing and hurrying and searching and seeking outside of yourself in a teacher, a scripture, or a text or a job or money and fame is looking in the wrong place. Simply focus your attention on the power of your breath when sitting or standing or walking and watch what happens. When you focus on that in breath and out breath you will soon find your blood pressing dropping, your monkey mind quieting down, and your shoulders dropping. You'll soon see a dropping away of all your fears and anxieties. You will have moved into the place we call "just this." No past, no future, just NOW, just this one breath, one mind, one body, one moment. Your searching for the Ox can end because you and the ox are one. You and the Buddha are one in the same. You know this when you realize that you and your breath are one.

This may be a fleeting feeling in the beginning but each day that you sit and walk in a meditative and fully present and mindful way you drop off a small weight and soon several small weights, and sooner than later you'll feel 10 pounds lighter, 100% healthier, happier, and more peaceful.

Live in this moment, the ox is everywhere present in you and through you and will carry you easily into a life of peace, love, and compassion. If only you stop searching for the ox outside of you—the ox within you will appear. The ox is powerful, strong, persistent, and always there when you need him. Let your search be over! Be one with the ox in you.

2: SEEING THE TRACES

"Along the riverbank under the trees,
I discover footprints.
Even under the fragrant grass, I see his prints.
Deep in remote mountains they are found.
These traces can no more be hidden
than one's nose, looking heavenward."

The second picture shows that the oxherd has now caught sight of the tracks of the ox, bringing hope that his ox is not lost forever. This could be interpreted to mean that he has recognized his distress and has begun to seek for a solution in the teachings of Buddhism or in other teachings. But he is still at the stage of thinking and talking about his problems and various possible solutions. He has not yet found a path to follow and has not yet started to practice.[2]

For each of us as we move through the days of our lives we find ourselves searching, thinking, dreaming, seeing, and planning for that perfect oneness and perfection or solution to life's mysteries. I can reflect on my own "footprints" reliving the conversation or encounter with an old friend or family member. Or

2 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

remembering a verse I read or a course I studied at school or in the Zendo. Or seeing the traces of my life and thoughts and actions. I begin to search for the answer that I thought I had discovered in that study group or class or relationship.

As I begin to study the principles of Zen my 'nose' begins "looking heavenward" as the poem says. I begin to see footprints leading me toward something of which I do not know just yet. At the same time Roshi Robert Kennedy invites me to "…let go of everything we thought we were certain of (page 20)."[3] Let us not move toward a "fixed truth that might hinder us" but let us move each moment where the experience takes us allowing life to flow at its own pace, form, and destination.

The most exciting and important adventures in life were the ones that we least expected. Open your mind to see what is here in the moment and remember that "truth" changes with time and experience, cling to nothing, enjoy everything—without attachment—and be ready for the next adventure in living!

3 Kennedy, R. (2004) Zen Gifts to Christians. NY: Continuum

3: SEEING THE OX

"I hear the song of the nightingale.
The sun is warm, the wind is mild,
willows are green along the shore—
Here no bull can hide!
What artist can draw that massive head,those majestic horns?"

Koller writes this about the third picture and the verse:

> *"In the third picture, the oxherd actually catches sight of the ox. Now, having started to practice, he glimpses the hidden powers to heal his suffering. But he does not yet understand the source of these powers and how to apply them in his search for peace and contentment. The verse, in saying that "I hear the song of the nightingale. The sun is warm, the wind is mild, the willows are green along the shore." suggests that the reality the oxherd glimpses is not something separate from the ordinary things that he experiences, even though he does not yet know this."*[4]

And thus we cannot be separate from ourselves, from who we are on an ordinary day, week, or year. We are simply us.

4 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

Although the ox may look large and dangerous so do our fears, anxieties, and doubts. Yet when we examine them more closely they are simply the secretions of our brain, created in a mysterious way. They can turn us into who knows what when we give them the power to determine our emotions, exacerbate our fears, or harm our relationships.

Roshi Kennedy writes, "The gift the third picture epitomizes is self-reliance. It is at this stage of the journey that the ox herdsman realizes that his true nature is within himself. It depicts the real awakening of the herdsman (page 34)."[5] The Ox herder must be the one to eventually learn how to unite with the Ox and understand that he won't find something outside of himself that has control over who and what he is. Kennedy goes on to say, "Nothing exists but the self and this self contains the whole universe." You are made of the same particles as the moon and the sun and the black hole. You are the Ox and the Ox is you!

So the next time you feel afraid or in doubt remember that your true nature of self-reliance, resilience, and knowledge exists in you at this very moment. Acknowledge the source of your power and move forward with confidence. Awaken to the idea that the Buddha/Ox and you are one and the same--thus all things are possible. So go for it!

5 Kennedy, R. (2004) Zen Gifts to Christians. NY: Continuum

4: CATCHING THE OX

"I seize him with a terrific struggle.
His great will and power are inexhaustible.
He charges to the high plateau far above the cloud-mists,
Or in an impenetrable ravine he stands.
I have abandoned the whip and ropes."

The fourth picture shows that the oxherd has now caught hold of the ox, using the bridle of discipline to control it. This symbolizes the rigorous discipline required of the Zen practitioner. Although he now realizes that the power to transform his life lies within himself, in his Buddha-nature, all his previous conditionings are pulling and pushing him in different directions. Holding the rope tightly means that he must work hard to overcome his bad habits of the past that developed through the ignorance, hatred and craving that gave rise to all his afflictions.[6]

Abbot Zenkei Shibayama shares a Zen story in his book, A Flower Does Not Talk, that relates to Koller's thoughts on "working hard to overcome bad habits."

> *Bodhisattva Manjusri once asked Zenzai Doji, "Bring me something that does not do any good." Zenzai*

6 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

> *searched around, but wherever he went, everything he saw and touched was something that would do good. He was unable to find anything that would not do any good. Finally, he had to come back to Manjusri and report: "There is nothing that will not do good (page 190)."*[7]

The conversation continued from there and Manjusri said:

> *"Bring me something, then, that will do good." Zenzai, without hesitation, plucked a blade of grass at his foot and presented it to Manjusri. Manjusri took it up, and showing it to the congregation, said, "This single herb is both able to kill people and to give people life (page 190-191)."*[8]

So, what does this have to do with you today, your life, your plans, your wishes and dreams? Everything! For me when I look back upon my life I see that the challenges forced me to learn, to pray, to think, to discover, to step out of my fears and anxieties to move forward regardless of them. I was able to recognize that these challenges did NOT kill me but made me stronger, more resilient, more pliable and yes, more loving, caring, and compassionate.

Some might say I need to take off the "blinders" about the reality of life. Yes, war is hell and people living in war zones, in poverty, lack, limitation, and ill health need help from those of us who can help and are willing to help and have the resources to help. That does not remove our obligation to try to help minimize or eliminate the suffering of others. As Koeller

7 Shibayama, Z. (1970) A Flower Does Not Talk Zen Essays. Rutland, Vermont: Charles E. Tuttle Co.
8 Ibid.

said, “Holding the rope tightly means that he must work hard to overcome his bad habits of the past that developed through the ignorance, hatred and craving that gave rise to all his afflictions.”

So, let us as, students of Zen, work daily to take the discipline that we have learned in our Zen practice of sitting into the “real” world and help those who cannot, for whatever reason, help themselves.

5: HERDING THE OX

"The whip and rope are necessary,
Else he might stray off down some dusty road.
Being well-trained, he becomes naturally gentle.
Then, unfettered, he obeys his master."

The fifth picture shows that disciplined practice can overcome the bad habits of previous conditioning and bring one into accord with the true nature of reality. Although discipline is still needed because the old habits of mind still have power, living in greater awareness of the true reality gives one the energy and direction to live a wholesome life. Now the ox willingly follows the oxherd home, meaning that the separation between oneself and true reality is being overcome.[9]

Who is the master in your life? Is it your thoughts, actions, fears, joys, money, your job, your relationships, your spiritual practices? In picture #5 the ox is now following the ox-herder home. He is not tightly tethered to the ox-herder, but they are casually walking one in front of the other following the path of enlightenment. As Roshi Kennedy says in his book, Zen Gifts to

9 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

Christians, "Self-mastery then is living a full life in the present, attached to nothing (page 61)."[10]

The habits of our minds can pull us down a dark and dangerous path if we are not aware of them. It is discovering the art of sitting in meditation as a "disciplined practice" where we are learning how to let the ruminations of the mind be a visitor and not a resident. Where all thoughts can be like feathers in the wind and we can watch them as they float through our minds easily without clinging or fear or anxiety. Where we can be in front of them or behind them and they hold no power over us.

Neither do we cling to the beautiful, happy, loving, thoughts because we can grasp and cling to them just as easily and begin to chase after them with ferocity. We can cling to their images and the feelings they bring up until they hold power over us as well. And thus, we are led on a wild goose chase running after those thoughts and running away from the dark thoughts and we find ourselves in an endless circle of confusion and fear, happiness and joy. It is as if we are on the merry-go-round at Palisades Park. Round and round we go where it stops nobody knows!

Living a life of true separation from our thoughts is allowing them to come and go as they please. It is seeing them floating like a feather in the wind. It takes time and "disciplined practice." Each day it becomes easier and easier as we sit in meditation and allow those feathers to fly at their own speed and height. What a great way to live a "wholesome life" without clinging to happiness or fear.

10 Kennedy, R. (2004) Zen Gifts to Christians. NY: Continuum

6: COMING HOME ON THE OX'S BACK

"Mounting the Ox, slowly I return homeward.
The voice of my flute intones through the evening.
Measuring with hand-beats the pulsating harmony,
I direct the endless rhythm.
Whoever hears this melody will join me."

The sixth picture suggests the tranquility and joy that reunion with the source of existence brings; now the oxherd rides on the back of the ox, joyously playing his flute. The verse suggests that he has been freed from old fears and anxieties and that so freed, he can now express his creative energies in celebration of life.[11]

Oneness, what does that mean to you? The ox-herder finds oneness with the Ox as he rides joyfully home harmonizing his flute, his body, and his mind with the ox. In doing so he does not even need to hold on to the reigns as his fear of falling off the ox has disappeared. He knows that there is no separation between the two of them and thus happily rides along playing his flute.

When we separate ourselves from people, and things, and ways we limit our abilities, we hinder our creativity, and we make

11 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

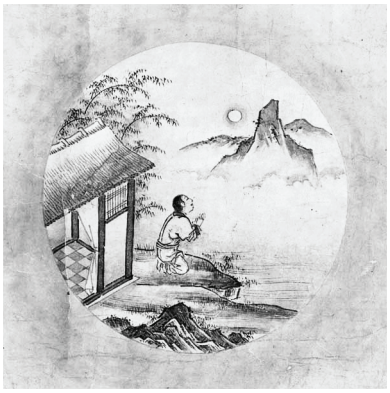
life harder and more uncomfortable. Being one with everything opens us up to insights and Ah Ha's that otherwise would have eluded us. To be one with the dying man as a hospice chaplain is an incredible experience. To allow yourself to laugh with bottomless joy along with a young child is being awakened to the oneness that permeates the universe.

Laughter is catchy if one person starts laughing others seem to join in even if they do not know what the person is laughing about. The same thing happens when someone cries, we all cry with them or try desperately to hold back the tears. And when someone yawns everyone else must yawn no matter how hard they try not to. Just reading this sentence about yawing I know you are having trouble holding back the yawn that is trying desperately to come out!

Roshi Kennedy says that the "unity between the absolute and the relative is fundamental to Zen Buddhism (page 68)."[12] Although we may not feel it most of the time that does not mean that it is not true. So, when you feel disconnected to life or to a situation or a person remember that oneness exists even if the eyes can't see it, the ears can't hear it, and the mind can't fathom it—it is still true! Just ask the tooth fairy! I can see that money underneath my pillow right now!

12 Kennedy, R. (2004) Zen Gifts to Christians. NY: Continuum

7: THE OX FORGOTTEN, LEAVING THE MAN ALONE



"Astride the bull, I reach home.
I am serene. The bull too can rest.
The dawn has come. In blissful repose,
Within my thatched dwelling
I have abandoned the whip and ropes."

In the seventh picture the oxherd has realized his identity with the ox; the ox can be forgotten, for it is none other than the experience of everyday things. This can be interpreted to mean that the separation of practice and realization has been overcome, as has the separation of ordinary reality and the ultimate reality. Until now he has been practicing meditation as a means of achieving enlightenment. But with realization of the non-duality of existence comes awareness of the identity of means and ends; practice itself is realization (page 6).[13]

This journey of ours may seem fruitless and endless at times. Remember it took time and patience and forethought for the lonely ox-herder to discover that the bliss of enlightenment was not something to be searching for as if it was lost some-

13 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

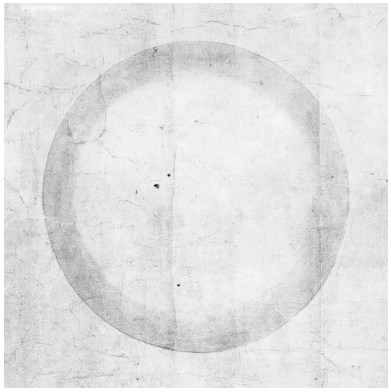
where on the trail of his journey, but something that was always there within him.

If you have a practice already take a little time to think about what it is, where it is, and how it is affecting your daily life. Our practice is not to be something or someone that is different from our life. It is not something that we set aside time for in the morning or evening to sit on our cushion and meditate to "become" enlightened. Our practice is not separate from our life it is our life. It is every word we speak, every move we make, every thought we think. It is who we are.

As Koller says, "…practice itself is realization." Realization is our practice in motion all day every day. Thus, we can live a more serene life, we can rest in the assurance that we don't have to be anything or go anywhere to transcend this earthly life and its trials and tribulations. With non-duality, there is only this moment, this word, this breath, this experience. It is how we deal with "just this" moment that makes us feel or seem that in this life we will never see enlightenment. Just "THIS," as we say in Buddhism, is enlightenment.

So, don't rush to that mountain top, or forest, or valley hide away in search of it. It is already here with you, within you, and around you. Take a deep breath each time you realize it and awaken to your ultimate reality: the existence of non-duality means that you are one with all there is. Now go out and live it!

8: THE OX AND THE MAN BOTH GONE OUT OF SIGHT



"Whip, rope, person, and bull—
all merge in NO Thing.
This heaven is so vast, no message can stain it.
How may a snowflake exist in a raging fire.
Here are the footprints of the Ancestors."

The eighth picture tells us that when the duality of self and reality has been overcome not only is reality (the ox) forgotten, but so is the self (the oxherd); the circle symbolizes the all-encompassing emptiness that constitutes the ground of all things. Now in the awareness of unceasing transformation and total interconnectedness in every experience one is freed from all craving and hatred for the other. In this freedom there is a sense of the wholeness and perfection of ordinary things (page 6).[14]

Roshi Kennedy writes about this idea:

> *"An anonymous Zen poet sums up patriarch's teachings saying that it is forbidden to search for the absolute apart from the self. Actually, it is forbidden to search for the absolute apart from the self because it is impossible. There is no path to the Buddha, to the*

14 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

> *truth of our lives but through the dust of every day existence (page 95)."*[15]

Thus, the poem says, "all merge in NO Thing." NO Thing is probably something that is impossible to understand and even frightening to think about. And yet we search, we go from "god to no god," "religion to no religion," "theory to no theory" and still we find NO answer to the emptiness. Unless of course we enter it as Koeller describes through interconnectedness in every experience, thought, feeling, movement, and desire. He says do not "try" to do anything, just be one with the moment, the things, the experience till there is no separation between you and it.

Many years ago, I had a friend that could do it. Sometimes he scared me especially when he was driving and all of sudden he was "one with the car" sometimes he was outside of the car watching himself driving. And he was not high or drunk. His focus on a long drive on a lonely highway was so powerful he became one with the elements of the universe.

I don't suggest you try it, but for me it was a graphic example of the "all-encompassing" interconnectedness of all things. I've described my personal experience with it in other blogs when I was participating in a Cherokee Indian fire walk with Rev. Edwine Gaines. There was no separation between me and the blade of grass, the stars in the sky, and the trees in the forest. Just an interconnectedness with all things or in actuality NO thing…

That is why you see the picture as an empty circle. Everything is interconnected so much so there is no way to see it, touch it, or

15 Kennedy, R. (2004) Zen Gifts to Christians. NY: Continuum

feel it. Everything is "all encompassing-emptiness." "True freedom, or true creativity, shines out only when we break through this barrier (page 257)."[16]

Remember that the next time you hit your shin on the coffee table or stub your toe when stepping up onto the sidewalk in your bare feet!

16 Shibayama, Z. (1970) A Flower Does Not Talk: Zen Essays. Rutland, Vermont: Charles E. Tuttle Co

9: RETURNING TO THE ORIGIN, BACK TO THE SOURCE

"Too many steps have been taken returning to the root and the source.
Better to have been blind and deaf from the beginning!
Dwelling in one's true abode, unconcerned with and without—
The river flows tranquilly on and the flowers are red."

As the ninth picture shows, when self and reality (as constructs) are left behind, then things are revealed to be just what they are in themselves; streams meander on of themselves and red flowers naturally bloom red. In the ordinary events of life are found the most profound truths. Only by seeking the ox as a separate ultimate reality could the oxherd discover that there is no separate reality; that the ultimate is to be found in the ordinary.[17]

And so…why is it we are always looking for our good somewhere else, somewhere outside of ourselves, in our job, our family, our hobbies, our meditation, or our possessions?

"As Bodhidharma, the founder of Chinese Zen, said in the sixth century A.D., your true nature is always right 'in front of you'—you yourself just do not see it (page110)."[18] Do we see that our true nature, our self, our ideas, thoughts, feelings, and love are

17 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf
18 Kennedy, R. (2004) Zen Gifts to Christians. NY: Continuum

not a separate reality they are the only reality available to us. That the truth of life and its ultimate answer is simply in the words of Wu Li's everyday way of living—Before enlightenment chop wood and carry water. After enlightenment, chop wood and carry water.

What more is there to life than to simply live it the best we can. When you can take the time to help make life better for another, to make yourself more approachable to others, to make yourself more loving to all creatures large and small, and to make you kinder—these things ARE your true nature. These are the things that life is made of. Here you are able to "dwell in one's true abode, unconcerned with and without." Simply being—simply chopping wood and carrying water.

Simply doing the thing that appears to you in the moment: holding the door for someone with their arms full of packages, letting someone in front of you in a traffic jam, sharing your lunch with a stranger, or mowing the lawn for a sick or aged neighbor. Living in the moment mindfully fully aware of the things that surround you with peace, love, and compassion is simply "chopping wood and carrying water." Expecting no reward simply Dwelling in one's true abode, unconcerned with and without. Embrace the life as the picture displays—a simple tree beside a stream and a few rocks on which to sit as you bask in the simplicity of life.

Close your eyes—take a deep breath! Can't you just feel the breeze and the spray of the water on your face?! Simply divine! "The ultimate has been found in the ordinary."

10: ENTERING THE CITY WITH BLISS-BESTOWING HANDS

"Barefooted and naked of breast,
I mingle with the people of the world.
My clothes are ragged and dust-laden, and I am ever blissful.
I use no magic to extend my life;
Now, before me, the dead trees become alive."[19]

Finally, the tenth picture shows the enlightened oxherd entering the town marketplace, doing all of the ordinary things that everyone else does. But because of his deep awareness everything he does is quite extraordinary. He does not retreat from the world, but shares his enlightened existence with everyone around him. Not only does he lead fishmongers and innkeepers in the way of the Buddha but, because of his creative energy and the radiance of his life, even withered trees bloom.

I love Suzuki's title for this picture "entering the city with bliss-bestowing hands." Every one of us can have hands that help or hinder. We can bless someone with a kind touch on the shoulder, or by the shake of a hand, or a pat on the back in their time of need. Or we can hinder them with a negative hand gesture (I'm sure you can think of some on your own), a shove, or a

19 Koller, J.M. http://www.columbia.edu/cu/weai/exeas/resources/pdf/oxherding.pdf

slap. Your hands can hold a crying newborn to sooth its trauma, comfort a patient in a hospice bed, or wash a baby duck covered in oil from an off-shore drilling site disaster.

Hands are powerful tools that we are given and sometimes they can seem as though they are making magic. I like to watch the talent shows like America's Got Talent and the most amazing people to me are the magicians. What they can do with their hands is mind boggling! Watching someone plant flowers in a garden, or paint a picture, or cut your hair is amazing to me. The craft, the talent, and the finesse that your hands have to make something out of almost nothing is incredible.

Your creative energy can come out in many ways. I hope that you are looking for those ways and perfecting them, and sharing them with others. We don't have to be a so called "enlightened being" like the ox-herder to do great things with our hands. We simply need to care enough, desire it enough, and be willing enough to put the time and energy in to it to find and develop that creativity, love, and perfection within us.

I love how Koeller talks about the "radiance of his life, even withered trees bloom." I don't expect to make withered flowers bloom today with the touch of my hands that's for sure. But I can pick the weeds from my garden or comfort a soul in need with them and for me that's the "radiance of life"–doing the extraordinary in an ordinary way. What is yours?

FINAL THOUGHTS

The way of Zen is a process—one that can take a life time. It is not a quick fix for your relationships, jobs, or health. It is a way of life. It is providing the opportunity for you to have a meditation practice that moves through you throughout the day not just when you are sitting on the cushion. It gives you the opportunity to live a life of peace, love, and compassion even in the most trying of situations knowing that this too shall pass. The ox herder learned this very well on his journey.

Francis Dojun Cook in his book *How to Raise An Ox* writes:

> *"In Buddhism there is a vast difference between believing that all things are impermanent and realizing that they are; but before that belief becomes true knowledge, one must practice in the faith that it is so, and will eventually be proven to be so by one's own experience (page 17).*[20]*"*

Thus, sitting and reading and practicing the principles of Buddhism will give you the opportunity and the "true knowledge" you need to bolster your faith in all things being impermanent. That impermanence makes life easier to deal with, that impermanence is why we have a saying "and this too shall pass." Every life is filled with things that come and go: a headache, a bad grade on a project at school, a failed job or relation-

20 Cook, F. D. (2002) How to Raise an Ox: Zen Practice as Taught in Master Dogen's Shobogenzo. Boston: Wisdom Publications

ship, a burnt dinner, or a cold. They came and they went, they were impermanent. They were not here to stay!

As students of Buddhism we work to realize that everyone and everything is the Buddha. We take the bodhisattva vow which consists "of selfless service on behalf of others [which] gradually diminishes self-serving, self-interested action (page 23)."[21]

Thus, the ox herder practiced and studied and believed and eventually realized his oneness with all things and no longer needed the ox. There was no quick fix, no magic pill or potion. Dojun continues with these words, "And this begins to happen when we completely abandon our own efforts and trust completely in our true nature, which is the Buddha. Again, this is Buddhist faith (page 24).[22]"

"To have faith in the Buddha is the same as forgetting the self (page 26)"[23] –And remembering impermanence! To forget the self is to find the true self. Good luck with that!

21 Ibid.
22 Ibid.
23 Ibid.

EPILOGUE

It is necessary for total wellness to embrace the whole of life, not just one little part of it. That is why it is important to read, to look at the sky, to listen to music, to sing and dance, and write poems, and yes, to suffer, and see clearly, for this is life. The 'now' is all that we have ever had and ever will have so don't let these precious moments slip from your awareness. The Diamond Sutra reminds us that these moments are like: "Stars at dawn, a bubble in a stream, a flash of lighting in a summer cloud, a flickering lantern, a phantom or a dream."

Embrace them all.

"Everything will be alright in the end. If it's not alright, it's not yet the end."
JOHN LENNON

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

First, I'd like to thank all my teachers! We all stand on the shoulders of giants. Only rarely do modern day thinkers come up with anything really new that has not been thought out, thoroughly examined, modified, or discarded through centuries of examination. Bravo! This is how these teachings of the wise continue to influence us today. Those philosophies and philosophers, mystics and sages of old are many. The Ancient Greek and Roman Stoics and Skeptics, including but not limited to Plato, Aristotle, Socrates, Epictetus, Seneca, Marcus Aurelius, to Confucius, Buddha, Lao-Tzu, Nagarjuna, Ikkyu, Thich Khat Hanh, D.T. Suzuki, Shunryu Suzuki, Jidda Krishnamurti, the scores of scientists too numerous to mention but of course Galileo, Copernicus, Albert Einstein, Kurt Maxwell, Charles Darwin, Steven J. Gould, Enrico Fermi, Kurt Gödel to more modern day philosophers like Paul Kurtz, Daniel Dennett, and the outstanding British philosopher (and one who influenced me the most) Bertrand Russell. Also, arguably the greatest poet and writer in the English language, William Shakespeare. As Harold Bloom said—and I agree—Will was perhaps the greatest psychologist that ever lived! He could see into the human condition better than anyone before or after him, apart from Dr. Albert Ellis. While Shakespeare wrote about tragedies better than anyone before or since, Ellis showed us how we create them

and how to get over them better than anyone before or since. I miss him every day.

I'd like to also thank my dear friend, Mr. Neil Schauer, for pushing me (relentlessly!) for 20 years to turn the four blocks formulas and this teaching into a book and an online video course. Without his devoted belief in rational living, this work may never have made it out into this wild and crazy world we live in. It is my hope that his fervent effort in bringing this teaching to the world may impact millions of people who are struggling with the four blocks.

Finally, I want to thank Melissa Gridley and Statler Gause for taking the burden of editing my manuscripts down to a lean and easy-to-understand guide for life. And more importantly for undertaking the massive task of both directing and editing the video programs and podcasts that complement this book's teachings. Neil, Melissa, and Statler formed a three-person army of making this teaching available as an online course that holistically takes you from beginner to master as quickly as possible.

If you or a loved one are reading this book because you are struggling with the four blocks, we do recommend that you explore our online video course as well at parrinstitute.org because repetition with this teaching is your best friend. It takes a little time and a lot of consistency to undo a lifetime of irrational thinking and painful emotions! Welcome to the adventure of a lifetime!

In the end, you will be able to sincerely and truthfully quote The Big Lebowski:

"The Dude endures."

THE FOUR BLOCKS TO HAPPINESS MASTERY COURSE

This book was originally written as a companion to The Four Blocks to Happiness online mastery course created by The Parr Institute for Mental Wellness. The complete course includes exclusive instructional videos of my teachings, audio tracks of the lessons, exercises, worksheets, and helpful animations that further explain and expound on the work I've presented here.

The course is available for purchase (and you can sample for free!) on The Parr Institute website at parrinstitute.org.